

Fire breaks out at Nature Bazaar, nearly 50 shops gutted

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A major fire broke out at Nature Bazaar in south Delhi's Andheria Mor area on Sunday morning, gutting around 50 shops and triggering a massive firefighting operation, an official of the Delhi Fire Services (DFS) said.

According to the DFS, a call regarding the blaze was received at 7.37 am, following which 10 fire tenders were rushed to the spot to control the flames. No injury to anyone was reported in the incident. The fire erupted at the Nature Bazaar market located near Andheria Mor in the Lado Sarai area, where several temporary and semi-permanent shops selling handicrafts and other items are set up, the DFS official said.

Thick plumes of smoke were seen billowing from the market complex as the fire

rapidly spread through multiple shops in the crowded marketplace. Firefighters launched an extensive operation to contain the blaze and prevent it from spreading further.

Around 50 shops were gutted in the incident, causing heavy damage to goods and structures, the officer said.

Fire personnel completely doused the flames and carried out cooling operations in the area. The cause of the fire is yet to be ascertained. Police officers also reached the spot to assist in crowd management and facilitate firefighting operations. A PCR call was received at 7.33 am about a fire near Ambdekar Colony in Chhatarpur. On receiving the PCR call, maximum staff were immediately dispatched to the spot.

"On reaching the spot, it was found that the fire was raging at the Nature Bazaar,



Firefighters douse a blaze after a fire broke out at shops near Chhatarpur Metro station in New Delhi

PTI

Delhi Haat, at Chhatarpur. No one was found trapped in the fire, however, the fire itself was found to be rapidly spreading. The fire was huge, and five fire tenders were pressed into service initially.

It took almost one-and-a-half hours to control the fire," a police officer said.

The probable cause of the fire, as per the night guards, was a short circuit. No human casualties have been reported,

and only exhibition goods like carpets and home decorative items have been gutted in the fire, the officer added.

As the fire spread rapidly due to the highly inflammable items stored inside the shops,

the blaze escalated quickly, the fire department officials said. Officials said the inventory at the market included carpets, shawls, sarees and various handloom materials, which intensified the blaze.

At around 8 am, additional firefighting resources were deployed. The total number of deployed units rose to 10 fire tenders along with a water tender, a water bowser and two multi-purpose fire-fighting vehicles. The fire officer said the firefighters battled the blaze for more than three hours before bringing it completely under control.

Eyewitnesses said the fire had actually started earlier in the morning before the official call was made to the fire department.

Mohammad Abid, an eyewitness, said many shopkeepers were unaware of the incident and later rushed to the market to check the

condition of their shops.

"Safety is very important here. Several houses are located close to the market, so it was important to ensure that the flames did not spread to the residential area," Abid said. He added that the fire appeared to have started around 6.30 am.

According to him, residents and locals made announcements from a nearby mosque, asking people to come out of their houses and help in controlling the situation. They were also asked to move LPG cylinders to safer places to avoid any further risk.

Another eyewitness, Mohammad Javed, said the damage could have been far worse if the weather conditions had been different. "It could have been a very big fire, but because of light rain in the morning hours, the situation remained somewhat under control," he said.

Javed also claimed that several fire extinguishers available in the market had expired and there was no proper water facility in the area. "If water were available nearby, locals could have tried to control the fire before the fire teams arrived," he said.

"In the early hours of this morning, a devastating fire at the Dastkar Nature Bazaar gutted 37 stalls in the permanent Gall e Khas and five stalls in the ongoing Bonanza Bazaar, totally destroying their goods, infrastructure and equipment," the market officials said in a statement.

Officials said the exact cause of the fire will be determined only after a detailed investigation. They added that the extent of financial loss will be assessed by the shop owners themselves, as most of the destroyed structures belonged to individual vendors operating in the market complex.

Woman charred to death in Badarpur

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi



A 65-year-old woman was charred to death after a fire broke out in the rooftop bathroom of a house in southeast Delhi's Badarpur area, with police suspecting that the blaze might have been triggered when she lit a matchstick to smoke a bidi, an officer said on Sunday.

The incident took place in the Molarband area on Saturday evening. Officials said a PCR call regarding a fire was received at the Badarpur police station.

Soon after receiving the information, police rushed to the spot and found that a fire had broken out in the rooftop bathroom of the house. Police found the woman's charred body inside. She was subsequently identified as Veenu Singh (65).

"The bathroom area contained wooden items and garbage that had also caught

fire during the incident," the officer said.

According to a preliminary inquiry, Singh used to smoke occasionally and would sometimes go to the secluded rooftop area to do so. Investigators suspect that the fire might have started accidentally while she was smoking in the enclosed space, leaving her trapped inside. Family members, however, alleged that the blaze might have been caused due to a leakage from a piped gas connection installed in the house around two months ago.

"She had gone upstairs and the bathroom was filled with gas due to the leak.

None of us knew about it because there was no smell. She probably lit a matchstick and that's how the fire started," the victim's daughter-in-law, Mamta Singh, said.

She said the victim sometimes smoked before having tea. Another relative said the victim's family members rushed to the rooftop after hearing people shouting about the fire.

"We suddenly heard people shouting that there was a fire upstairs. Everyone ran up and saw that she had caught fire in the bathroom," the relative said, adding that Singh had suffered severe burn injuries.

Police said the district crime team was called to the spot and the scene thoroughly examined. They said the victim's family members did not initially suspect any foul play and the death appears accidental at this stage. The body has been preserved at the AIIMS mortuary for post-mortem.

Rohtak Road drain project in final stage: Verma

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Cabinet Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh Verma on Sunday inspected an ongoing stormwater drainage project along Rohtak Road and said the work is in its final stage and is expected to provide long-awaited relief from water-logging in several parts of West Delhi during the monsoon.

The project, being implemented by the Public Works Department, involves the construction and upgrading of a large stormwater drainage network along the Rohtak Road corridor, one of the key arterial routes in the western part of the Capital.

Officials said the project has an estimated cost of about ₹113.98 crore and aims to improve rainwater drainage and prevent flooding on roads and nearby residential areas that have long faced water accumula-

tion during heavy rainfall.

During the inspection, the minister reviewed the progress of the project and expressed satisfaction with the pace of work. According to officials, the drainage system is being constructed from the Kirari Suleman Drain near Nangloi Metro Station up to the Hiran Kudna Drain.

The work covers stretches between Metro Pillar numbers 428 and 626 and extends further from Tikri Border to Hiran Kudna Drain on both sides of the road.

The reinforced concrete cement drain being constructed has a width ranging between 1.2 metres and 2.25 metres, designed to carry heavy volumes of storm water during peak monsoon periods. Officials informed the minister that around 16,000 metres of the drain have already been completed, while about 2,200 metres of construction work remains and is currently underway.



The project began in February 2025 and has progressed steadily since then. Once completed, the drainage network will improve stormwater flow along the stretch from Nangloi Railway Metro Station to Tikri Border. The remaining portion is currently under construction between Ghevra Metro Station and Tikri Kalan Metro Station.

Speaking during the inspection, Verma said res-

idents of areas such as Mundka and Rajdhani Park have faced serious waterlogging problems for many years.

"For a long time, people living in these areas have suffered inconvenience during the monsoon due to water accumulation on roads and in residential colonies. This project has been designed to solve that problem in a systematic and permanent manner," he said.

The minister said that

once the drainage system becomes operational, rainwater from the Nangloi region will flow smoothly into the Kirari Suleman Drain and then into the Hiran Kudna Drain, ensuring faster disposal of stormwater.

He said the improved network will help clear rainwater quickly from roads and surrounding areas, reducing flooding and traffic disruptions during heavy rainfall. Along with the stormwater drainage project, the minister also reviewed an irrigation and flood control project implemented in the same region.

Officials said the project, approved at a cost of ₹23.51 crore, aims to divert discharge from the Kirari Suleman Drain along Rohtak Road into the Supplementary Drain to improve water flow during heavy rainfall. Authorities informed the minister that the flood control project has already been completed.

Woman arrested for duping man of ₹20,000

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A 40-year-old woman has been arrested for allegedly duping a Delhi resident of ₹20,000 on the pretext of arranging an easy loan through a social media platform, an official said on Sunday. The accused, identified as Satvinder Kaur, a resident of Tilak Nagar in west Delhi, was apprehended following a technical investigation into the fraud case.

According to the police, the case was registered on March 13 after the victim lodged a complaint alleging that he had been cheated through a fake loan offer.

"During investigation, it was found that the accused had contacted the com-

plainant through a number and introduced herself as someone who could arrange a loan," the officer said.

He further said that she had allegedly first approached the complainant on April 25, 2025, with a similar offer, which he declined at that time. However, she again contacted him on January 16, 2026, and managed to convince him to avail the loan facility. She allegedly told the complainant that a processing fee equivalent to five per cent of the loan amount would have to be paid in advance.

"After negotiations, the accused agreed to accept a reduced processing fee of three per cent and asked the complainant to transfer ₹20,000," he added.

Delhi pays tribute to ex-CM Sahib Singh Verma on his birth anniversary

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Hundreds of people from across the national capital gathered on Sunday to pay tribute to former Delhi chief minister Sahib Singh Verma on his 83rd birth anniversary. The public remembered him as a leader who remained deeply connected with ordinary citizens and worked extensively for the development of the city's rural areas.

The tribute programme was held at Swabhiman Sthal Ghevra Mor, where residents from villages and neighbourhoods across Delhi assembled to offer prayers and floral tributes to the late leader. The gathering included residents, social workers, community representatives and supporters who participated in a prayer meeting and a hawan organised in his memory.

Delhi cabinet minister Parvesh Sahib Singh, son of the former chief minister, attended the ceremony along with other family members. He participated in the hawan and later offered floral tributes to a portrait of his father. Many citizens present at the gathering



also paid their respects and remembered Verma's contributions to Delhi's development during his tenure in public life.

Speaking to reporters on the occasion, Parvesh Sahib Singh said the large turnout reflected the deep connection that Sahib Singh Verma shared with the people of Delhi. He said the former chief minister always believed that politics should focus on improving the lives of ordinary citizens.

"Even today, people from villages and different parts of Delhi come here to remember him. That connection with the people was his greatest strength," the minister said.

Sahib Singh Verma served as the chief minister of Delhi in the late 1990s and was

widely known for his focus on rural development and welfare initiatives for villages and unauthorised colonies in the capital. Parvesh Sahib Singh said his father had initiated several development programmes during his tenure and had envisioned large-scale infrastructure and social development in the Capital's rural areas.

He added that many of those initiatives could not continue after the government changed. "When he was the chief minister, he started many initiatives for Delhi's development and had several dreams for the future of the city. Unfortunately, after our government went out of power, many of those works could not continue," he said.

Mishra praises contribution of Odia community to nation-building

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi's Art, Culture and Language Minister Kapil Mishra on Sunday praised the contribution of the Odia community to nation-building and said the national Capital is increasingly emerging as a "cultural capital" where traditions from across India are celebrated.

Speaking at the concluding day of Odisha Parba 2026, a three-day cultural festival, Mishra said Delhi today reflects the diversity of the country and offers a glimpse of "Mini India". The event was held at Jawaharlal Nehru Stadium and was attended by several dignitaries, including Hari Babu Kambhampati, who graced the occasion on the final day of the festival.

Addressing the gathering, Mishra said that cultural traditions from different parts of the country are finding space in Delhi and strengthening the idea of cultural unity. "With the blessings of Lord Jagannath, cultural nationalism and religious tourism are gaining strength in Delhi. Festivals and traditions from every state are now being celebrated in the



national capital," he said.

The minister said such cultural gatherings help bring together communities from across India and strengthen the spirit of unity in diversity. Mishra said that Delhi is steadily evolving into a major centre for cultural exchange and celebration.

He added that the Delhi government has begun organising grand celebrations of the foundation days and cultural festivals of various states. According to the minister, these initiatives are intended to showcase the traditions, art, and heritage of different regions in the national capital.

Mishra said such programmes will continue to grow in scale in the coming years. "The idea is to make

Delhi a place where the culture of every state can be experienced. The city should reflect the diversity of India," he said.

During his address, the minister also paid tribute to the role played by the Odia community in the development of the country. He said the traditions of courage, peace, and environmental harmony associated with Odisha serve as an inspiration. "The courage, love for peace, and environmental consciousness of the Odia community inspire the world," he said.

Mishra added that Odisha's cultural traditions reflect a deep connection with nature, which carries an important message for society today.

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2.	Basti (Uttar Pradesh) - 181	1st Floor, Ranjeet Chauraha Near Aadarsh Hospital, Malviya Road, Basti, Uttar Pradesh-250001	Gorakhpur (Uttar Pradesh) - 154	46/47, Budh Vihar Face 2, Tara Mandal road Gorakhpur, Near Canara bank regional office Uttar Pardesh- 273017
3.	Modinagar (Uttar Pradesh) - 205	1st Floor, Bank Colony GT Road, Near Metro Pillar No-1210, Modinagar, Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh, 201204	Meerut (Uttar Pradesh) - 137	2nd floor, Sardhana Road, Kanker Kheda, Opp. Kamal Hospital, Meerut, Uttar Pradesh-250001
4.	Sultanpur (Uttar Pradesh) - 254	1st Floor, 1077, Akhtar Complex, Khairabad, Sultanpur, Uttar Pradesh-208001	Ayodhya (Uttar Pradesh) - 159	436 Atardeep Complex, Devalai Bypass, Ayodhya -UP-224001
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Police bust interstate drug supply network, four arrested

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Police has busted an interstate network involved in the illegal supply of psychotropic medicines and arrested four people while seizing a consignment of banned drugs, an official said on Sunday.

The accused have been identified as Salman Khan of Punjab's Patiala, Vipin Kumar Pal of Delhi, and Abdul Rehman and Ravi Garg, both residents of Uttar Pradesh, he said.

On March 7, a police team deployed received inputs that Vipin Kumar Pal was

involved in the illegal supply of psychotropic medicines such as Alprazolam and Tramadol, the police said.

Police were informed that Pal would deliver a consignment to Salman Khan near Yudhishthar Setu towards Kashmere Gate between 7.30 pm and 8.30 pm.

"Acting on the tip-off, the team laid a trap near the Yamuna bridge. At around 8.25 pm, Pal was spotted standing on the footpath with a plastic sack," said the police officer.

Shortly afterwards, Salman Khan arrived at the spot in an auto-rickshaw. As Vipin handed over the sack



to Salman, the police team apprehended both of them. Upon checking the sack, police recovered a carton

containing 100 boxes of Alprazolam tablets (0.5 mg). A total of 59,925 tablets weighing about 8.09 kg

were seized from their possession. "During interrogation, the accused revealed that the consignment had been arranged through Abdul Rehman from Muzaffarnagar and was meant to be delivered to another associate in Punjab.

"Subsequently, Rehan and Ravi Garg were arrested on March 13. A search of their rented accommodation in Muzaffarnagar led to the recovery of 2,000 Rexogescic (buprenorphine) injections weighing around eight kg. An FIR has been registered and further investigation is underway," the officer added.

Three hospitals to be merged into an autonomous institute

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Rekha Gupta Government plans to merge three major public hospitals in the Capital and develop them into a single autonomous medical institution on the lines of the country's premier hospital system.

Under the proposal, Guru Teg Bahadur Hospital, Delhi State Cancer Institute and Rajiv Gandhi Super Speciality Hospital will be integrated to form a unified "super medical hub" aimed at strengthening healthcare services and improving the use of medical infrastructure.

The initiative was discussed in a high-level review

meeting chaired by the Chief Minister at the Delhi Secretariat. The meeting was attended by Health Minister Pankaj Kumar Singh and senior officials from different departments.

Officials said the integration is intended to improve coordination between hospitals, make better use of existing infrastructure and ensure that specialised medical services are distributed more efficiently. According to the Government, the plan will help streamline super-speciality treatment while also addressing the uneven distribution of patient load across hospitals.

During the meeting, officials presented data showing

the pressure faced by some hospitals and the underutilisation of resources in others.

Guru Teg Bahadur Hospital currently operates beyond its intended capacity. The hospital was originally designed for around 1,400 beds but is presently managing more than 1,500 beds. It also receives more than 14 lakh outpatient visits every year and treats nearly 95,000 patients annually through inpatient services. In contrast, Rajiv Gandhi Super Speciality Hospital has a total capacity of 650 beds, but only about 250 beds are currently operational. This leaves nearly 400 beds unused.

Delhi State Cancer Institute also faces heavy demand for



cancer treatment services, handling around 1.27 lakh outpatient visits each year. Rajiv Gandhi Super Speciality Hospital records about 2.87 lakh outpatient visits annually. Officials said the data highlights the need for better coordination between institutions so that resources, doctors and equipment can be used more effectively.

Under the proposed integration, super-speciality ser-

vices will be organised in a more structured manner across the three hospitals.

Rajiv Gandhi Super Speciality Hospital will focus on cardiology, pulmonology, gastroenterology, gastrointestinal surgery, nephrology, urology, rheumatology and clinical haematology.

Delhi State Cancer Institute will function as the main hub for cancer care. Services such as radiation oncology, surgical oncology, nuclear medicine, palliative care and radio-imaging will be concentrated there.

Guru Teg Bahadur Hospital will continue to strengthen departments such as orthopaedics, internal medicine, ENT, general surgery,

neurosurgery, endocrinology and ophthalmology.

Officials also noted that many hospitals already possess expensive medical equipment that is not being fully utilised due to shortages of specialised staff or fragmented management.

For instance, advanced bronchoscopy facilities are available at Rajiv Gandhi Hospital, while the Delhi State Cancer Institute houses a linear accelerator used for radiotherapy. Rajiv Gandhi Hospital also has cath lab and echo lab facilities, while GTB Hospital maintains a bone bank.

By integrating the institutions, the government aims to ensure that such spe-

cialised equipment is used more efficiently and shared across departments when required.

The government also announced a separate plan to upgrade the Institute of Human Behaviour and Allied Sciences into a major national centre for mental health and neurosciences.

The institute will be developed on the lines of the National Institute of Mental Health and Neurosciences in Bengaluru and is proposed to be known as "NIMHANS-2".

As part of the project, IHBAS will provide around 75 acres of its vacant land to support the development of a large integrated medical campus linked with GTB Hospital.

Misinformation on LPG supply creating unnecessary panic: CM

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Sunday warned of strict action against those spreading rumours about a potential LPG shortage, saying that such misinformation was creating unnecessary panic among people.

Speaking at an event at Apna Ghar Ashram in Budhpur, the chief minister said both the Centre and the Delhi Government are closely monitoring the situation, and there was no reason for citizens to panic. She said certain elements were attempting to create fear and encourage hoarding by spreading misleading information, which she described as being against the national interest.

The chief minister noted



Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta interacts with an elderly resident during her visit to Apna Ghar Ashram at Budhpur in New Delhi

that the government was keeping a close watch on such activities and warned that strict action would be taken against any individual or organisation found spreading misinformation or indulging in wrongdoing. She also appealed to citizens not to pay attention to

rumours and to continue with their daily routines.

Earlier in the day, the chief minister attended the 12th anniversary celebration and the silver jubilee programme of Apna Ghar Ashram in Budhpur, where she praised the organisation for its service to destitute and

abandoned people. During the event, the chief minister also announced financial assistance for the construction of a paved road leading to the Ashram to improve connectivity and assured the organisation of government support in addressing administrative and infrastructure-related requirements. The Chief Minister said organisations like Apna Ghar Ashram play a crucial role in supporting vulnerable individuals who have been separated from their families or left without care.

"These institutions become a ray of hope for people who have been abandoned or are unable to care for themselves," she said.

According to the Chief Minister, the organisation not only provides shelter but also ensures essential

services, including food, clothing, medical treatment, and proper care, for its residents. She described the institution as a "living example of humanity and compassion". During the event, the Chief Minister also assured that the Delhi government would extend support to address administrative and infrastructure issues related to the Ashram's operations.

She stated that the government would assist in strengthening medical facilities and ensuring the availability of doctors and other essential services for the residents of the institution. Member of Parliament Yogendra Chandoliya, Narela MLA Raj Karan Khatri, and several other dignitaries were also present at the event.

No shortage of LPG in city: Sirsa

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Amid rumours of a shortage of cooking gas circulating in parts of the city, Delhi Food and Supplies Minister Manjinder Singh Sirsa on Sunday said there is no shortage of LPG in the capital and appealed to residents to remain calm.

The minister, in a statement, said the government has deployed 70 joint teams from the police, the Weights and Measures department and the Food and Supplies department to monitor LPG availability across Delhi.

"These teams are checking stock levels at distributors and markets and will act against hoarding or unfair trade practices," Sirsa said.

The minister said concerns had surfaced amid global



supply pressures linked to disruptions in the Gulf and rumours that triggered panic buying in some areas.

"There is no need for any panic, supplies are fully in order," he said, urging residents not to stock up unnecessarily. The official statement said that the government has also begun regulated sales of commercial LPG cylinders following directions from the Ministry of

Petroleum and Natural Gas, in coordination with oil marketing companies.

Under the arrangement, up to 20 per cent of average daily commercial consumption, around 1,800 cylinders, will be supplied through a priority system to essential sectors such as hospitals, educational institutions, restaurants and dairies, according to the official statement.

Light rain, gusty winds cool down Delhi-NCR

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Weather across Delhi-NCR has swung dramatically this March, catching residents and forecasters off guard. After days of unusually high temperatures that made mid-March feel like the peak of summer, many areas of the Delhi-NCR witnessed light rainfall on Sunday morning, bringing a much-needed respite from the prevailing dry conditions.

The India Meteorological Department stated that 8 mm of rainfall was recorded till 8.30 am. According to the IMD data, Safdarjung and Lodhi Road recorded 0.8 mm rainfall each, while Palam received 0.4 mm. Ayanagar recorded 2.6 mm rainfall and Pitampura 3.5 mm, the highest among the stations.

Additionally, Mayur Vihar recorded 1.0 mm rainfall and Janakpuri 0.5 mm, while Ridge reported only a trace of rainfall. The maximum temperature was recorded at 30.1 degrees Celsius, 1.2 notches above the seasonal average, whereas the minimum temperature was recorded at 18.7 degrees Celsius, which was 3.6 notches above the seasonal average.

This abrupt shift isn't simply



A cyclist rides holding an umbrella during light rain on a city road, in New Delhi

a seasonal quirk. Instead, it reflects a complex interaction between intense heat building over the plains and fresh moisture entering the atmosphere, an interaction that could affect public health, farming, and everyday routines.

The key trigger behind the latest alert is the arrival of a fresh western disturbance. These weather systems originate over the Mediterranean region and travel eastward, typically bringing winter and spring rainfall to parts of the

Indian subcontinent. Under normal conditions, they provide moderate rain and cooler weather. However, when a western disturbance interacts with land already heated to unusually high levels, the outcome can be far more dramatic.

"Due to a western disturbance approaching the western Himalayas, cyclonic activity has developed over central Pakistan, adjoining Punjab and Haryana. As a result, parts of Delhi wit-

nessed rainfall," Mahesh Palawat, vice president of meteorology and climate change at Skymet Weather, said. He said the rain is expected the next day as well, and it is the season's first pre-monsoon rain, which has arrived about 10 days earlier than usual.

The advance has been triggered by the western disturbance combined with the higher temperature the city has been experiencing over the past few days, he added.

DU releases admission data to refute Rahul Gandhi's claim of caste bias

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Strongly rebutting Rahul Gandhi's allegations of caste-based bias in admissions, Delhi University (DU) on Sunday released data on student enrolment in the academic year 2025-26 through CUET and urged the Leader of Opposition in Lok Sabha to refrain from making "unsubstantiated" statements.

"The University of Delhi implements all its statutory mandates in the true spirit of the Constitution of India, as clearly reflected in our transparent admission and recruitment processes," the university said in a post on X.

According to the DU data for postgraduate students enrolled in academic session 2025-26 based on CUET, there were a total of 4022 (38.59 per cent) unreserved (UR) students, 3115 OBC (Other Backward Classes) (29.88 per cent) students, 1488 SC (Scheduled Caste) (14.27 per cent) students, 614 ST (Scheduled Tribe) (5.89 per



cent) students and 1203 EWS (11.54 per cent) (Economically Weaker Section) students. The total number of PG students enrolled was 10,422.

Data for undergraduate programmes for the academic session 2025-26 showed that 32777 (46.56 per cent) students were enrolled under the UR category, 17971 (25.52 per cent) were under OBC, 10517 (14.93 per cent) were SC students, and 3251 (4.62 per cent) and 5879 (8.35 per cent) were, respectively, ST and EWS students. The total number of enrolled stu-

dents for UG programmes stood at 70,395.

"We urge the Leader of Opposition to refrain from making unsubstantiated statements. Such remarks undermine the healthy learning environment at the university," the university said in its post.

Rahul Gandhi had made the controversial remarks on Friday while addressing an event in Lucknow to mark the birth anniversary of Bahujan Samaj Party founder Kanshi Ram. "I had gone to Delhi University. An interview is just a way to eliminate students. They

ask what your caste is, and then you fail in the interview, Rahul had said.

Responding to the allegations, the DU had on Saturday said that the university admits students primarily based on the Common University Entrance Test (CUET) scores, and the standard admission process does not mandate interviews for most undergraduate and postgraduate programmes.

In the post on Sunday, the DU also shared data for appointments of teachers (including librarians and physical education) from 2021 to March 15, 2025.

In the period mentioned, according to the data, 2123 (41.99 per cent) appointments have been made under the UR category, 717 (14.18 per cent) under the SC category, 349 (6.90 per cent) under the ST category, 1282 (25.35 per cent) under the OBC category, 422 (8.35 per cent) and 163 (3.22 per cent) under the EWS and PwD categories, respectively. The total number of recruitments stood at 5056.

Excise policy case: Kejriwal and Sisodia move Supreme Court to transfer CBI plea

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Aam Aadmi Party convener Arvind Kejriwal and senior leader Manish Sisodia have approached the Supreme Court after the Chief Justice of the Delhi High Court rejected their request to transfer the CBI's plea against their discharge in the excise policy case from Justice Swarana Kanta Sharma to another judge, the party said.

According to sources privy to the development, the Chief Justice of the Delhi High Court, DK Upadhyaya, while declining the request by AAP leader and others discharged in the case, opined that Justice Sharma was hearing the CBI petition against the trial court's decision in accordance with the roster and there was no reason to pass an order of transfer on the administrative side.

A call for recusal has to be taken by the judge concerned, the chief justice clar-



ified. The CBI's petition is listed for hearing before Justice Swarana Kanta Sharma on Monday.

The Aam Aadmi Party said both Kejriwal and Sisodia have challenged the decision in the SC. On March 11, Kejriwal, Sisodia, along with other accused in the excise policy case, made a representation to Chief Justice Upadhyaya to transfer the CBI's plea against their discharge from Justice Sharma to another "impartial" judge.

In the representation, Kejriwal claimed he has a

"grave, bona fide, and reasonable apprehension" that the hearing in the matter would not be impartial and neutral.

On February 27, the trial court discharged Kejriwal, Sisodia and 21 others and pulled up the CBI, saying its case was wholly unable to survive judicial scrutiny and stood discredited in its entirety. On March 9, Justice Sharma's bench stayed the trial court's recommendation on the initiation of departmental action against the CBI's investigating officer in the liquor policy case.

Delhi Metro handles 235.8 crore passenger journeys in 2025

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Metro handled a whopping 235.8 crore passenger journeys in 2025 with an average daily ridership of 64.60 lakh passengers, the Delhi Metro Rail Corporation (DMRC) said in a statement on Sunday.

Moreover, the inauguration of two new sections on the Pink and Magenta lines on March 8 has further expanded the network and strengthened connectivity across the national capital and the National Capital Region (NCR), it said.

Delhi Metro also operates one of the largest driverless metro networks in the world, it said.

"Delhi Metro handled a record 235.8 crore passenger journeys in 2025, reflecting the growing reliance of commuters on the system and reaffirming its role as the backbone of urban mobility in the national capital region," said Anuj Dayal, principal executive director (corporate communications),

DMRC. In 2024, the network recorded about 223.5 crore passenger journeys, with an average of 62.39 lakh passengers travelling daily.

According to the DMRC statement, Delhi Metro remains the country's largest operational metro network and plays a key role in India's rapidly expanding urban rail system.

With the latest expansion, it said, India now has the world's third-largest metro network, with more than 1,143 kilometres of operational lines across 26 cities, carrying nearly 1.15 crore passengers every day.

Of this, the Delhi-NCR metro network alone accounts for about 416 kilometres with 303 stations, the corporation said.

This includes around 29 kilometres of the Noida-Greater Noida Metro with 21 stations and the Rapid Metro Gurugram, which spans around 13 kilometres with 12 stations connecting Delhi with major NCR cities such as Noida, Greater Noida and Gurugram.



The DMRC operates 343 trains comprising 2,368 coaches and runs around 4,508 train trips daily, covering nearly 1,40,112 train kilometres every day, ensuring high-frequency services across the network, according to the statement.

The system also maintains a punctuality level of about 99.9 per cent, making it among the most reliable metro networks globally.

DMRC said while it has witnessed steady growth in

passenger numbers in recent years, recovering from the impact of the COVID-19 pandemic between 2020 and 2022, the last two years have also seen the metro surpass its previous ridership records multiple times.

The highest passenger journeys in 2024 were recorded on November 18, when 78,67,649 passengers travelled on the network. This record was later surpassed on August 8, 2025, when 81,87,674 passengers

used the system in a single day.

DMRC said the Delhi Metro also operates one of the largest driverless metro networks in the world. Driverless train operations are currently available on the Pink Line and the Magenta Line, covering a combined stretch of more than 120 kilometres. At present, DMRC operates 80 driverless trains on these corridors as part of its adoption of advanced automation and globally benchmarked metro technologies, the corporation said.

Meanwhile, construction of priority corridors under Phase-IV of the Delhi Metro project is underway. To support future operations, 52 new trains are being procured in phases, of which 18 have already been delivered.

DMRC added that the metro system has significantly reduced travel time, eased road congestion and promoted environmentally sustainable public transport across the Delhi-NCR region over the years.

IN FOCUS



People walking under umbrellas to shield themselves from the heat at the Taj Mahal in Agra, Uttar Pradesh

Fewer voting phases and delayed counting in polls

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The election schedule for five assemblies announced on Sunday has thrown out quite a few surprises — fewer phases, a condensed 20-day voting period, but longer gaps between the three polling days and a delayed counting.

The previous round of elections for these five assemblies in 2021 had as many as eight voting days spread across almost a month, while votes were counted on the third day after the last polling date. This time, votes would be counted on the fifth day after the last day of voting. The gap is longer between the first two days of voting —



first on April 9 and the second on April 23 — while the last polling day will be on April 29.

The last assembly election, in Bihar in November 2025, also saw two polling days — November 6 and 11 — spread across five days, while votes were counted three days later, on November 14. Some opposition leaders have alleged that the BJP wanted a

delayed election in politically crucial West Bengal due to public anger over the LPG crisis, while others see it as the saffron party getting more time to campaign there. The 2024 Lok Sabha elections had seven polling days spread across nearly 40 days, while counting had taken place on the third day after the last round of polling. Elections for four assemblies also took place alongside the Lok Sabha polls, which required greater manpower and security arrangements.

The 2024 Lok Sabha election was held in seven phases — April 19, April 26, May 7, 13, 20, 25 and June 1. The counting of votes took place on June 4.

The last round of assembly

polls in West Bengal, Tamil Nadu, Kerala, Assam and the Union Territory of Puducherry were held in nearly a month's period, with West Bengal having eight phases — March 27, April 1, 6, 10, 17, 22, 26 and 29. Responding to a question on compressed phases this time, Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar told a press conference here on Sunday that there was a feeling to reduce phases and make things "comfortable".

While Tamil Nadu, Kerala and Puducherry had single-phase polls in 2021, Assam had three phases on March 27, April 1 and April 6. The counting of votes then took place on May 2 after the last phase of voting on April 29 in West Bengal.

CEC Gyanesh ducks query on Opposition's removal motion

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar on Sunday ducked questions on the opposition's notice to move a motion in Parliament for his removal from the post. At a press conference held to announce Assembly election schedules in four states and a Union Territory, Kumar did not answer questions on the opposition notice.

While the Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) can be removed only by Parliament, Election Commissioners can be removed through a recommendation by the CEC to the President.

In a first, the opposition has submitted notices in both the Lok Sabha and the Rajya Sabha seeking to move a motion to remove Kumar from the post, alleging a par-



tisan attitude. The opposition parties accused the CEC of aiding the ruling BJP on several occasions, especially during the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls, which they alleged was aimed at helping the saffron party at the Centre.

The process for removing the CEC is similar to that for the removal of a Supreme Court or a high court judge, meaning an impeachment can be effected only on the ground of "proven misbehaviour or incapacity".

Omar Abdullah visits Srinagar Tulip Garden

MOHIT KANDHARI
■ Jammu

As several parts of the Kashmir valley on Sunday witnessed a fresh spell of snowfall, Chief Minister Omar Abdullah visited Asia's largest

showcase the spectacular variety of blooms that brighten the Kashmir Valley.

Nestled in the foothills of the Zabarwan Range, the iconic Indira Gandhi Memorial Tulip Garden offers breathtaking views with the



Tulip garden, spreading across nearly 30 hectares, for a quick sneak preview ahead of its formal opening on Monday.

Omar, himself a nature lover, also captured blooming buds on his mobile camera before extending an open invitation to the visitors to witness vibrant blooms and stunning spring landscapes.

"The weather is perfect & the colours are amazing. If you don't believe me, come & see for yourselves", Omar posted on X as he posted multiple images of the Tulip Garden to attract visitors to the Kashmir valley ahead of the beginning of the new tourist season.

"Got a sneak preview of Asia's largest tulip garden in Srinagar earlier today. The garden is still 7-8 days away from its full bloom but it's already bursting with colour.

The garden looks amazing. The team of gardeners have done an amazing job under the supervision of the Floriculture Department officials", Omar posted on X.

Every year, the Tulip Festival is held here to celebrate the arrival of spring and

majestic Dal Lake forming a stunning backdrop.

In Srinagar, the entire security grid is already maintaining a tight vigil in the run-up to the beginning of the peak tourist season in the valley.

The Union Territory administration is also anticipating a heavy rush of tourists as Asia's largest tulip garden, housing a flower carpet of 18 lakh tulips of 70-75 varieties with different colours and fragrances, will be thrown open to visitors from March 16.

Mathoor Masoom, Director of Floriculture in Kashmir, said, "We will have more than 70 varieties of tulips this year. We have tried to improve the experience by adding selfie points and decorative planters so that visitors get a pleasant atmosphere."

According to the weather advisory, erratic weather conditions are likely to continue across the Union Territory until March 20. On Sunday, Snowfall was recorded in areas including Peer Ki Gali, Sinthan Top, Gulmarg, Doodhpathri, Gurez Valley, Sadhna Top and along the Sonamarg-Zojila axis.

UP leaders pay tribute to Kanshi Ram on birth anniversary

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Lucknow

Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath, Deputy Chief Ministers Keshav Prasad Maurya and Brajesh Pathak, BSP chief Mayawati and Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav paid tributes to Kanshi Ram on the occasion of his birth anniversary on Sunday.

In a post on X in Hindi, Adityanath said, "My humble tributes on the birth anniversary of Manyavar Kanshi Ram ji, the pioneer of social justice and founder of the Bahujan Samaj Party, who dedicated his entire life to the upliftment of the Dalits, the exploited, and the deprived." Deputy Chief Minister Keshav



Mayawati pays tributes to the party founder Kanshi Ram on his birth anniversary in Lucknow

PTI

Prasad Maurya, in a post on X, said, "A hundred salutations to Kanshi Ram ji, a staunch champion of social justice, a powerful voice for

the rights of the deprived and the exploited, and the founder of the Bahujan Samaj Party, on the occasion of his birth anniversary.

His life of struggle dedicated to the ideals of equality, self-respect, and social consciousness continues to inspire society to remain vigilant regarding justice and rights."

Deputy Chief Minister Brajesh Pathak also paid tributes to Kanshi Ram. BSP chief Mayawati, while paying tributes to Kanshi Ram, in a post on X in Hindi, said, "On the occasion of the birth anniversary of founder and architect of the Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP), revered Kanshi Ram ji, I along with his followers across the entire nation, including Uttar Pradesh, under my leadership, offer our humble salu-

LG Sinha hands over job letters to blast victims' kin

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jammu

Jammu and Kashmir Lieutenant Governor Manoj Sinha on Sunday handed over an appointment letter on compassionate grounds to the wife of Crime Branch photographer who was killed in the Nowgam police station blast last year.

An official spokesperson said the appointment letter was given to Shabeena Bashir, wife of deceased constable (photographer) Javid Mansoor Rather of Crime Branch Jammu and Kashmir Police, who was martyred in Nowgam's accidental blast. Sinha



assured all possible assistance and support from the administration to the bereaved family, the spokesperson said.

Rather was among the nine persons killed in the blast due to the huge cache

of explosives kept at the Nowgam police station in November last year.

The explosives were seized from Faridabad as part of a crackdown on white collar terror in which several doctors were arrested.

DGCA gives flight duty time relaxations to Air India amid conflict

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

Aviation safety watchdog DGCA has provided temporary relaxations in flight duty norms for Air India's long-haul flights as the airline is

taking longer routes due to the airspace curbs amid the Middle East conflict, sources said on Sunday. With Iranian and Iraqi airspace restrictions, Air India is taking the Egypt route for European and North American flights,



which means longer flying hours. Against this backdrop, the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) has given certain relaxations in pilot Flight Duty Time Limitations (FDTL) norms till April 30, the

sources told PTI.

There were no comments from Air India and DGCA on the FDTL norm relaxations. Providing the relaxations for the long-haul flights operated with two pilots, the sources said.

There is sufficient LPG available and people need not queue up for gas, said Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis on Sunday, accusing the Congress of creating fear among people amid the West Asia crisis.

He was responding to queries concerning allegations of cooking gas shortage in the country due to the ongoing US-Israeli war with Iran. "Rahul Gandhi and the Congress are deliberately creating fear among people, resulting in citizens standing in queues for LPG cylinders. We have sufficient gas



supply. There is absolutely no need to queue up for LPG anywhere," he said. The West Asia conflict has impacted the supply of crude oil and petroleum products, following the closure of the Strait of Hormuz, a narrow water passage between Iran and Oman.

New eco-tourism policy boosts tourism: Goa Minister

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Panaji

Goa is strengthening ecotourism and nature-based tourism under a new structured framework, Tourism Minister Rohan A. Khaunte said. The Department of Tourism and Goa Tourism Development Corporation (GTDC) are promoting responsible travel beyond beaches, with a strong focus on conservation, local livelihoods and self-help groups.

GTDC has developed ecocottages in Selaulim, launched jeep safaris, forest treks and monsoon trails to Dudhsagar Waterfalls in collaboration with the Forest Department. rafting on the Mhadei River in Sattari has also been introduced. Upcoming projects include a wellness centre and eco-cottages at Anjunem (Keri), an eco-forest retreat at Chapoli Dam (Canacona) and a women-centric jaggery tourism initiative in Cotigao. The Government is studying global best practices to formalise ecotourism.

West Bengal to vote in two phases, EC1...

Scrutiny will take place on April 7 and April 10, respectively, while the last date for withdrawal is April 9 and April 13. Polling will be held in 152 constituencies in the first phase and 142 in the second. The Commission said polling arrangements will involve around 25 lakh election officials, including 15 lakh polling personnel, 8.5 lakh security personnel, 49,000 micro observers, 1,444 observers, 40,000 counting officials, 21,000 sector officers and 15,000 micro observers for counting.

From Aircel to Jet: Canara Bank chases...

The Seychelles-based promoter of Aircel and Dishnet Wireless owes banks more than ₹20,000 crore. According to the data, one of his company directors, Sudhir Mathur, is listed as personal guarantor to Canara Bank.

Other major defaulters include Shri Lakshmi Cotsyn (₹3,982 crore), the Lanco Group of former Congress MP L Rajagopal (₹3,852 crore), Gammon Engineers (₹3,425 crore), Odisha-based MS Gupta Power Infrastructure (₹3,303 crore) and companies linked to IL&FS (₹3,237 crore).

The data shows that in most of these cases the bank has no recoverable collateral apart from personal guarantees. Many loans were sanctioned against company shares whose valuations were later found to be inflated, while several of the companies have since entered insolvency or liquidation. The records also indicate that several large loans were structured as multiple smaller loans. One example cited is Kolkata-based Nicco

Corporation, which is now undergoing insolvency proceedings. The company received 168 separate loans of ₹16.75 crore each from the same Canara Bank branch, amounting to ₹2,815 crore in total. Other large defaulters include Delhi-based Indure Pvt Ltd (₹2,770 crore), Winsome Diamonds and Jewellery (₹2,550 crore), Bengaluru-based Rajesh Exports (₹2,285 crore), PSL Limited (₹2,373 crore), Hyderabad-based Gayatri Projects (₹2,342 crore) and Supreme Housing and Hospitality (₹2,254 crore). Kolkata-based Rabirun Vinimay Pvt Ltd owes ₹2,024 crore; through the insolvency process, Jindal Steel acquired the company for ₹96 crore, leaving the bank to pursue civil recovery for the remaining dues.

Real estate firm Era Group, controlled by H.S. Bharana and owing more than ₹75,000 crore to Union Bank, also has dues of ₹1,544 crore to Canara Bank. Alok Industries, which owes more than ₹6,500 crore to SBI, borrowed ₹1,746 crore from the bank. Other borrowers include Concast Steel & Power (₹1,695 crore), Jay Polychem (₹1,714 crore), Forever Precious Jewellery and Diamonds (₹1,364 crore), and DHFL, whose promoters Kapil and Dheeraj Wadhawan face dues exceeding ₹50,000 crore across banks and owe ₹1,250 crore to Canara Bank.

Fugitives Mehul Choksi and Nirav Modi, accused of defrauding Punjab National Bank of over ₹25,000 crore, also borrowed ₹919 crore from Canara Bank. Real estate firm Unitech Ltd owes ₹937 crore, while Trimax IT Infrastructure and Services Ltd has dues of ₹937 crore.

Other defaulters include Mahendra Exports (₹858 crore), Kolkata-based BBT Elev RD (₹747 crore), Bibcol (₹732 crore), Mumbai-based jewellery company Gilzi India (₹700 crore), Hyderabad-based IVRCL (₹790 crore) and Transstroy India Pvt Ltd (₹653 crore).

FROM PAGE - 1

The longest goodbye: A 13-year vigil ends...

The court permitted passive euthanasia — the withdrawal of life-sustaining treatment rather than actively ending life. Rana was moved to the palliative care unit at AIIMS, where the focus shifted from treatment to comfort. Doctors continued basic care such as pain management, hygiene and medication for comfort while avoiding aggressive interventions meant to extend life.

Medical experts say that once life-support systems are withdrawn, it is impossible to predict how long a patient may survive. For Rana's family, the decision came after years of emotional and physical exhaustion. For more than a decade, they had waited beside his bed, hoping that someday he might wake up.

Iran calls for UAE port evacuations

South Korea said it would coordinate with Washington. Iran called Trump's request "begging" and warned of attacks on US-linked oil and energy infrastructure if Iranian facilities were hit. Iran's foreign minister, Abbas Araghchi, accused the US of launching strikes on Kharg and Abu Musa islands from UAE territory. The UAE and US Central Command denied the claims. Iran has fired hundreds of missiles and drones at the UAE, Bahrain, Saudi Arabia, Qatar, and Oman, claiming US assets as targets, though civilian sites like airports and oil fields have also been hit. Araghchi said mediation efforts were ongoing to end the war.

FROM PAGE - 1

The human toll is mounting. Iranian strikes have killed at least a dozen civilians in Gulf countries, while the ICRC reports over 1,300 deaths in Iran, including 223 women and 202 children. In Israel, 12 people have died, including three on Sunday. US forces have lost 13 personnel, six in a recent plane crash in Iraq. In Lebanon, 820 have died, and 850,000 have been displaced amid Israeli retaliation against Iran-backed Hezbollah.

Heavy rain has worsened conditions for displaced families in Beirut, where tents are soaked and streets blocked by rubble. In southern suburbs, emergency crews are clearing roads to maintain access to hospitals.

Iran fired new missile barrages at Israel on Sunday, striking central Israel and Tel Aviv, causing damage at multiple sites and sending residents to shelters. Israel's military said Iran is using cluster munitions that scatter submunitions across several locations, complicating defense efforts.

Rajya Sabha polls: MLAs locked down

All relocated MLAs will be brought back to their respective assemblies Monday morning for voting. Rajya Sabha elections will be held in Bihar, Haryana, and Odisha. In Odisha, BJD and Congress are backing common opposition candidate Dr. Dattaswar Hota against BJP-supported independent Dilip Ray for the state's fourth seat. Already, 26 candidates have been elected unopposed in seven states with the BJP cornering seven of them, Congress five, Trinamool Congress four, DMK three and Shiv Sena, RPI(A), NCP, NCP(SP), AIADMK, PMK and

UPPL one each. The winners include Sharad Pawar, Abhishek Singhvi, Tiruchi Siva and Vinod Tawade.

In Haryana, two seats will fall vacant as BJP MLAs Kiran Choudhry and Ram Chander Jangra complete their terms on April 9. BJP's Sanjay Bhatia, Congress's Karamvir Singh Boudh, and BJP-backed independent Satish Mandal are contesting, each needing 31 votes. Congress, with 37 MLAs, can secure one seat, though cross-voting remains a concern. The BJP has 48 MLAs, the Indian National Lok Dal two, and three Independents in the 90-member assembly.

In Bihar, JD(U) national working president Sanjay Kumar Jha said all NDA candidates, including Chief Minister Nitish Kumar, are expected to "win by huge margins." Six candidates-five from the NDA and one opposition-are in the fray, including BJP president Nitin Nabin and Union minister Ram Nath Thakur aiming for a hat-trick.

Indian ships sail safely amid Gulf crisis

Another tanker, Jag Prakash, carrying gasoline from Oman to Tanzania, crossed the strait on Friday and is expected in Tanga on March 21.

Currently, 22 Indian-flagged vessels with 611 seafarers remain on the west side of the Persian Gulf. The Government said maritime operations are being closely monitored and that the Directorate General of Shipping (DG Shipping) continues coordination with ship owners, agencies, and Indian missions. So far, 276 Indian seafarers have been safely repatriated, including 23 in the past 24 hours.

GRAPEVINE

Ananda follows Dhankar's way!

Former West Bengal Governor CV Ananda Bose is tight lipped on why he suddenly resigned. In his hometown Kerala, the ex-IAS officer has now been regularly meeting his friends and the media trying to 'extract' a scoop. "I will reveal after some time," Bose says. People close to him shared that Bose did not budge to act on certain things dictated by Home Minister Amit Shah. Centre wanted Governor to criticise Mamata Banerjee's Government during his address, similar to what Tamil Nadu Governor RN Ravi did. Grapevine has it that Bose did not agree to this. The Bengal episode reminds us of the unceremonious exit of Jagdeep Dhankar as Vice President just after presiding over the first day of the Monsoon Session last year.



IAS 'exodus' over harassment?

There has been an exodus of top officers from two prominent ministries functioning from the Shastri Bhawan, and the matter has reached the Seva Teerth as it involves two very popular IAS officials, including a household name during the COVID pandemic. Three Additional Secretaries, while two from IAS and one from Railways' Cadre, have excused themselves prematurely from the concerned Ministry and now settled themselves in other departments/commissions.



Who to Foot the Bill!

As the financial year closes, a people-centric department near Patel Chowk struggles to justify rising refreshment expenses, especially escalating bills from food aggregators like Swiggy and Zomato, furnished as staff tea and coffee expenses by the Minister's office. Expensive hot beverages for the Minister are purchased from a high-end market in Lutyens' Zone. The main concern is that frequent food aggregator deliveries are mainly used by the Minister's staff, with some meals appearing to be taken home.



BJP will form Govt in Assam with largest ever mandate: Amit Shah

TONY DAS
■ Guwahati

Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Sunday said he is confident that the BJP will return to power in Assam under the leadership of Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma with the "largest ever mandate".

Addressing the youth convention of the Bharatiya Janata Yuva Morcha (BJYM) here, Shah urged the people to give another mandate to the BJP and assured them that "every infiltrator will be sent out of India".

"The Congress gave shelter to infiltrators, but the BJP Government is determined to identify each one of them and drive them out of the country," he said.

The Election Commission conducted Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls in some states, but the



Congress protested against the exercise, he claimed.

"The Congress legalised, formalised and normalised infiltration, but the BJP will remove each one of them from the electoral rolls. Rahul Babu can rest assured that not only their (infiltrators') names will be removed from the electoral rolls, but they will also be driven out," Shah said.

During the Congress rule, Assam was "known for violence", and several youths were killed, Shah claimed.

PM Modi writes to Birla who then asks MPs to introspect

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In a sharp attack at the Congress, Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday said the resolution brought against Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla was driven by motives of self-interest and that certain individuals steeped in "dynastic mindset" want to confine democratic institutions within their own narrow spheres.

Modi made the remarks in a letter to Birla, days after the resolution moved by the Congress-led Opposition for the removal of the Lok Sabha speaker from office was defeated in the House. Expressing his deep gratitude for the letter, Birla said the prime minister has always held an unwavering faith in the rules, procedures, and traditions of India's parliamentary democracy.

Following the PM's letter, Birla too wrote to all political parties having members in Lok Sabha, where he expressed "deep concern" over showing of banners, placards, posters and use of certain language inside the House by some MPs and urged leaders of all political parties to ensure discipline and high ethical conduct among their members.

In his letter in Hindi, Modi said, "The no-confidence motion brought against you in the Lok Sabha was defeated in the House. I also congratulate the members of the House for the decisive



manner in which they rejected this political misdeed."

"I listened attentively to the statement you delivered in the House following the defeat of the no-confidence motion. The balance, patience, and clarity with which you referenced parliamentary history, the duties of the Speaker, and the supremacy of the rules were truly impressive. For this, I offer you my commendation," he said.

"Your statement was not merely a response to that specific moment; rather, it served as a profound and measured exposition of Indian parliamentary traditions and democratic propriety," the prime minister said.

"Differences of opinion are inherent in a democracy. Indeed, it is the diversity of ideas that infuses democracy with vitality. However, it is equally true that there exists a distinct demarcation between disagreement and disrespect," the prime minister said. It is a matter of



concern for all those who place their faith in democracy and its institutions that, at times, political disagreement appears to morph into a disregard for parliamentary decorum, Modi said. Such moments, he said, serve as a true test for the individual occupying the Chair.

The restraint, composure, and impartiality with which you navigated these circumstances are truly commendable, the prime minister said. "It is regrettable that such tendencies persist even today. Such behaviour is not merely directed at an individual; rather, it undermines the dignity of the institution itself, an institution that stands as a symbol of our entire democracy," Modi said.

He asserted that the fundamental essence of Parliament lies in dialogue, reasoned debate, and deliberation.

Sharing Prime Minister Modi's letter on X, Birla said the PM has always held an unwavering faith in the rules,

procedures, and traditions of India's parliamentary democracy. "Your letter articulates those highest ethical values of public service that you have embodied throughout your long public life, currently as the Prime Minister of India, and previously as the Chief Minister of Gujarat," Birla said in his post in Hindi.

In his letter to political parties Birla said the House has always had a glorious tradition of dignified discussion and dialogue but for some time now, the dignity and prestige of the country's parliamentary democracy are being undermined by some of the members -- both inside and outside the chamber and within the Parliament complex.

"There is a need for all of us to engage in serious reflection and analysis of this situation, both individually and collectively," he said in the letter written in Hindi. The letter was sent to the leaders of the political parties days after a motion to remove Birla was defeated in Lok Sabha by voice votes.

In the past, Birla said in the letter, whenever a decline in the standards of conduct and behaviour was felt within the House, conferences were organised from time to time by all political parties and other stakeholders, where discussions and dialogues were held on the preservation and promotion of the dignity and prestige of the country's democratic institutions.

Rahul, Mayawati push for Bharat Ratna for Kanshi Ram



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The demand for conferring Bharat Ratna on Dalit icon and Bahujan Samaj Party's (BSP) founder Kanshi Ram reverberated on his birth anniversary on Sunday, with Congress leader Rahul Gandhi and former Uttar Pradesh chief minister Mayawati pitching for the highest civilian honour of the country. This appeal comes a year ahead of the polls in Uttar Pradesh, which has nearly 20 per cent Dalit voters.

While Rahul Gandhi wrote a letter to Prime Minister Narendra Modi, appealing to him to confer the Bharat Ratna on Kanshi Ram posthumously, BSP chief Mayawati said the Government should not repeat the mistake that the Congress had made with B R Ambedkar and bestow the honour on the party founder without any delay.

"Like the Congress party, which did not honour the architect of India's Constitution, Babasaheb Dr Bhimrao Ambedkar, with the Bharat Ratna, the current BJP-NDA Government at the Centre should not make any further delay in honouring

Bahujan leader Kanshi Ramji with the Bharat Ratna," Mayawati was quoted as saying in a statement issued by the BSP.

In his letter to the prime minister, Modi, Rahul Gandhi said Kanshi Ram transformed the nature of Indian politics and, through his movements, raised political awareness among Bahujans and the poor. "As we commemorate the birth anniversary of Kanshi Ramji today and reflect on his legacy and contributions, I write with a request that he be awarded the Bharat Ratna posthumously," the leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha said.

"Kanshi Ramji transformed the nature of Indian politics. Through his movements, he raised political awareness among Bahujans and the poor. He reminded them that their vote, voice and representation are important and that this country belongs to everyone equally," he added.

Rahul Gandhi asserted that because of Kanshi Ram's efforts, many people who had never considered entering public life began to see politics as a means to achieve justice and equality.

Political parties in Assam urge EC for free, fair elections

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Guwahati

Political parties in Assam asserted on Sunday that they are fully prepared for the Assembly elections to be held in a single phase on April 9, with the Opposition camp urging the Election Commission to ensure free and fair polls.

They maintained that the short period in the run-up to the elections will not hamper poll prospects in any manner.

BJP senior spokesperson Rupam Goswami claimed the public has already made their choice and the party is confident of forming the Government for a third straight time in the State.

"As a party, the BJP is always ready to face any elections. Our preparations are complete. The candidate list will also be declared soon," he said.

He maintained that the voters have also made up



their minds on whom to support, with the ruling BJP-led alliance comfortably ahead of the opposition in this regard.

"The people know who to vote for. It is also good that the elections will be over before Bohag Bihu and all can celebrate the Assamese New Year," Goswami added.

The BJP senior spokesperson further said that the single-phase election reflects the return of peace and effi-

ciency of the Government, which will be beneficial for the people.

State Congress media department chairman Bedabrata Bora said the party is fully prepared for the elections.

"We already had an inkling that it will be a single-phase election in the first quarter of April. Our preparations were on in that line, and we are ready for it," he said.

"That is why two lists of

our party candidates have already been published," Bora added.

The Congress leader emphasised that the only concern was for the EC to ensure free and fair elections.

Opposition AIUDF chief Badruddin Ajmal also stressed the need for free and fair elections.

"Our party is ready for the elections. But the EC has to ensure that it is a free and fair one, and there is no 'vote chori'," he said.

Ajmal also urged the youth to come out and vote to elect the new Government.

"We will be contesting in 25-30 seats and preparations are complete for it," the former MP added.

The Assam Jatiya Parishad (AJP) alleged that the decision to complete the entire election process in the State within just three weeks effectively benefits the ruling BJP.

In a press statement, AJP president Luriniyoti Gogoi

and general secretary Jagadish Bhuyan said the "ruling party has abundant financial resources and control over the Government machinery, enabling it to conduct widespread election campaigns across the State, including the use of helicopters to travel extensively."

"Opposition parties, however, do not enjoy such resources and will face serious difficulties in organising their campaigns within such a limited time frame," they added.

Counting of votes will be undertaken on May 4. In the current 126-member Assam Assembly, the ruling BJP's strength is 64, while its allies ACP has nine MLAs, UPPL has seven and BPF has three members.

In the Opposition camp, the Congress has 26 MLAs, AIUDF has 15 members, and CPI(M) has one MLA. There is one Independent legislator as well.

Number of phases don't matter, BJP will be shown door anyway: TMC

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kolkata

Unwilling to grant too much importance to the dual-phase polls announced for West Bengal by the Election Commission, the Trinamool Congress on Sunday alleged that the poll body fixed the number of phases based on "requirements of its political masters".

The party questioned the commission's "duality" on conducting eight-phase elections in 2021 during a period of high Covid infections



while settling for two-phase polls this time around.

"The number of phases is solely a reflection of what the BJP wants and the Election Commission has only adhered to the requirement of its political masters,"

TMC spokesperson, Arup Chakraborty said.

The Election Commission on Sunday announced that Assembly elections in West Bengal will be held in two phases on April 23 and 29.

"Else, how can one justify conducting eight-phase polls in the State in 2021 when people were dying of Covid infections and deciding to hold the polls in two phases now when there is no such bug. The number of polls doesn't matter, people will demolish the BJP irrespective of that," Chakraborty added.

Congress leader flags voter intimidation

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kolkata

Senior Congress leader Pradipt Bhattacharya on Sunday welcomed EC's decision to hold a two-phase election in West Bengal, but expressed concern over whether voters would be able to exercise their franchise freely and without intimidation.

The former West Bengal Pradesh Congress Committee chief also said he had raised the issue of voter intimidation during



his interaction with the full bench of the Election Commission (EC) during its recent visit to the State.

"I welcome the Election Commission's move to hold the polls in West Bengal in two phases.

Bypolls for two Karnataka Assembly seats on April 9

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bengaluru

The Election Commission on Sunday announced that the by-elections for the vacant Davanagere South and Bagalkote assembly constituencies in Karnataka will be held on April 9.

According to the official schedule, the counting of votes is scheduled for May 4.

Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar released the poll schedule in New Delhi. The bypolls were necessitated following the deaths of sitting Congress MLAs Shamanur Shivashankarappa and HY Meti, which resulted in vacancies in the Davanagere South and Bagalkote Assembly segments, respectively.

Shivashankarappa, a senior Congress leader and former minister, represented the Davanagere South constituency, while Meti,



also a former minister, had been elected from Bagalkote. Both leaders had won their seats in the 2023 Karnataka Assembly elections.

With the seats falling vacant after their demise, the poll panel decided to hold by-elections in accordance with the provisions of the Representation of the People Act.

The bypolls are likely to witness a keen contest, with the ruling Congress aiming to retain both constituencies while opposition parties prepare to mount a strong challenge.

CPI announces candidates in 25 seats for Kerala Assembly polls

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Thiruvananthapuram

The CPI, a major coalition partner in the LDF, on Sunday announced candidates for 25 constituencies in the Kerala Assembly elections to be held on April 9. CPI State secretary Binoy Viswam announced the candidates minutes after the Election Commission declared the poll schedule.

The party has fielded four incumbent ministers-G R Anil, J Chinchurani, K Rajan and P Prasad in the polls.

The list also includes legislators who have completed two consecutive terms, including K Rajan, Mohammed



Muhasin, ET Taison and VR Sunil Kumar. Poet Alankode Leela Krishnan will contest from Thrissur.

In Nattika, former MLA Geetha Gopi

has been fielded in place of sitting MLA CC Mukundan. Kaipamangalam MLA ET Taison has been fielded from North Paravur, where he will take on Leader of Opposition VD Satheesan, who is likely to contest from the constituency again. Sitting MLAs E Chandrasekhar, CK Asha, P Balachandran, PS Supal, ChittayamGopakumar, EK Vijayan, V Sasi and CC Mukundan have not been given tickets this time.

There are five women candidates contesting for CPI in the assembly polls. Viswam welcomed the announcement of the election schedule and said the Left Democratic Front (LDF) would contest the polls unitedly.

Will seek consensus so that contest is avoided: Fadnavis

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis on Sunday said all efforts would be made to ensure the bypolls to Baramati and Rahuri Assembly seats are held unopposed through consensus, but asserted the BJP was ready if it comes down to a contest.

Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar announced during the day that bypolls to Baramati in Pune and Rahuri in Ahilyanagar, necessitated by the deaths of then deputy



chief minister Ajit Pawar and BJP legislator Shivaji Kardile, respectively, will be held on April 23.

Addressing a press conference for announcement of the poll schedule, Kumar said

votes will be counted on May 4. Speaking to reporters before the announcement by the Election Commission of India, Fadnavis said, "All attempts would be to arrive at a unanimous decision so

that elections are held unopposed. However, if an election is imposed on us (BJP-led Mahayuti), we are prepared for a contest as well."

While NCP stalwart Ajit Pawar was killed in a plane crash in Baramati on January 28, Kardile died of a cardiac arrest on October 17 last year at the age of 66.

Bypolls are scheduled for eight assembly seats across the country. While five seats in Goa, Karnataka, Nagaland and Tripura will go to polls on April 9, the date is April 23 for one seat in Gujarat and two (Baramati and Rahuri) in Maharashtra.

■ States Focus ■



ODISHA TO PROVIDE SPORTS KITS TO MAOIST-HIT VILLAGES

The Odisha Government will distribute sports equipment in 485 Maoist-affected villages across 10 districts, officials said on Sunday.

Under the ‘Gramodaya’ campaign, the Department of Sports and Youth Services will provide such kits to integrate the youth of remote and Maoist-affected regions into the mainstream, while fostering sporting talent among them, an official statement said.

The department has sanctioned a total of ₹2.42 crore for the scheme, it said.

The youth of Bargarh, Bolangir, Boudh, Kandhamal, Kalahandi, Koraput, Malkangiri, Nabarangpur, Nuapada, and Rayagada districts will benefit from this initiative, the statement said. Each identified village will receive a sports kit worth ₹50,000, which will include essential equipment for outdoor games like cricket, football, volleyball, and badminton, along with indoor games like chess and carrom, it said.



MORE PUNE METRO PHASES TO OPEN IN MAY-JULY: FADNAVIS

Pune will get additional metro rail routes in May and July, Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis said on Sunday. He was speaking after inaugurating Metro Bhavan, the headquarters of the MahaMetro Pune Project. “Maharashtra is the first State to formulate the GCC (Global Capability Centres) policy, and in such a situation, mobility is very important. We are committed to making Pune congestion-free by building metro rail lines,” he said.

We are also planning underground tunnelling for uninterrupted mobility, he said. Fadnavis admitted that metro rail work in the State’s second largest city, also a major industrial and services hub, started late, but construction was progressing rapidly now.

“In May and July, we will inaugurate more phases of the Pune metro rail. We planned a network of 80 kilometres, and work on 55 kilometres of which is now nearing completion. The Hinjewadi metro line will start in May. Another 11 km of metro in Pune will be ready by May. There is also a plan to extend the metro line till the upcoming Purandar airport,” he said.

■ Parliamentary panel slams rural Budget, cites MGNREGA cuts

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A parliamentary panel has expressed concern over the budgetary allocation for the Department of Rural Development for the 2026-27 fiscal, noting that while the total outlay has increased by 21 per cent, the bulk of the increase is earmarked for the new VB-GRAMG scheme.

The committee highlighted that funds for most existing programmes remain static, while the allocation for MGNREGA has been sharply reduced.

The Parliamentary Standing Committee on Rural Development and Panchayati Raj, in its report tabled in Parliament last week, said the Department of Rural Development (DoRD) has been entrusted with the “huge task” of implementing a large number of schemes aimed at the upliftment of rural masses and therefore it is imperative that flagship programmes are not “left in the lurch” for want of adequate financial support.

The committee noted that ₹2,28,768.81 crore has been allocated to the department at the Budget Estimates (BE) stage for 2026-27, which is 21.20 per cent higher than the BE for 2025-26.

However, the report pointed out that ₹95,692.31 crore of the total has been



allocated solely to VB-GRAMG. “Therefore, barring VB-GRAMG, funds for other major schemes like PMGSY, PMAY-G, DAY-NRLM and NSAP have, by and large, been kept static and moreover, funds for MGNREGA have been drastically reduced to ₹30,000 crore,” the report stated.

The committee described the current allocation as “inadequate” and “totally unacceptable”, arguing that “adequate budgetary allocation” is necessary to maintain the momentum of rural progress.

It noted that popular schemes like MGNREGA, NSAP, DAY-NRLM, PMGSY and PMAY-G are also not immune to inflation and the rising cost of raw materials.

The panel also said such

allocation is “inadequate” and “may be suitably enhanced, particularly when the scheme continues to face substantial pending liabilities from previous years”.

The committee noted that pending liabilities under MGNREGA are expected to approach nearly ₹25,000 crore by the end of the financial year, which, it said, would leave very limited fiscal space for meeting fresh demand for work.

“In a demand-driven programme such as MGNREGA, such a situation may severely constrain the ability of the scheme to respond to genuine demand for employment,” it said.

The panel also observed a gap between allocation and spending in the previous

fiscal. Against an allocation of ₹1,86,995.61 crore in 2025-26, actual expenditure at the Revised Estimates stage stood at ₹99,090.47 crore, a deficit of 47.01 per cent.

“This indicates that either the budgetary planning of the Government was not prudent enough or there is a problem at the actual implementation stage of the schemes,” the committee remarked, adding that non-utilisation of allocated funds results in the targeted beneficiaries being deprived of the benefits of the schemes.

The report recommended that the department prepare quarterly and monthly expenditure plans in advance in consultation with stakeholders, particularly State Governments.

Jaishankar in Brussels for key EU talks

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar on Sunday embarked a two-day visit to Brussels for talks with his counterparts from member States of 27-nation European Union.

It is the first high-level visit from India to Brussels headquartered EU after the two sides firmed up a landmark Free Trade Agreement

also hold meetings with the leadership of the European Union, and his counterparts from Belgium and other EU member States,” the ministry said.

“The visit of the external affairs minister coming soon after the historic 16th India-EU summit is expected to further deepen India’s strategic partnership with the European Union,” it said in a brief statement.

India and the EU sealed



External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar

(FTA) in January. The external affairs ministry said Jaishankar is travelling to the Capital of Belgium at the invitation of EU High Representative and Vice President Kaja Kallas to interact with foreign ministers of the 27 member States of the bloc at its Foreign Affairs Council Meeting.

“During the visit, the external affairs minister will

the free trade agreement — billed as the “mother of all deals” — following the summit meeting between Prime Minister Narendra Modi and the top EU leader-ship on January 27.

As Jaishankar visit to Brussels is taking place amid the Iran-US conflict, the two sides are expected to deliberate on dealing with its consequences, especially on the flow of energy.

CBI grills TVK chief Vijay for 7 hours over Karur stampede

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The CBI questioned actor and TVK chief Vijay for over seven hours at its headquarters here on Sunday over last year’s stampede during his rally in Tamil Nadu’s Karur that claimed 41 lives, officials said.

The actor left the agency headquarters after the questioning and related formalities got over around 6 pm, they said. This was the third session of questioning for Vijay. He has been examined twice in January.

Vijay was earlier summoned on March 9. However, he had requested that the date be deferred by 15 days, officials said.

The actor had also urged that the questioning be conducted in



Chennai or any office in Tamil Nadu, citing political engagements prior to the upcoming

Assembly elections, they said. However, both requests were declined by the agency, which

summoned the actor to its headquarters on Sunday.

The central probe agency has also asked the DMK MLA from Karur, Senthil Balaji, to appear before it for questioning on March 17, officials said.

The CBI took over the case from an SIT following a Supreme Court order and has been gathering evidence related to the September 27, 2025, stampede that claimed 41 lives and left more than 60 people injured during Vijay’s rally in Tamil Nadu’s Karur.

In October last year, the apex court asked the CBI director to appoint a senior officer to take over the investigation and also constituted a supervisory committee headed by former Supreme Court judge Ajay

Rastogi to monitor the agency’s investigation.

A bench comprising Justices JK Maheshwari and NV Anjaria had said the stampede has left an imprint in the minds of citizens throughout the country.

It has wide ramifications with respect to the lives of citizens, and enforcing the fundamental rights of the families who lost their kin is of utmost importance, the court had said.

“The faith and trust of the general public in the process of investigation must be restored in the criminal justice system, and one way to instil such trust is by ensuring that the investigation in the present case is completely impartial, independent and unbiased,” the bench had said.

Sonam Wangchuk to undergo health check-up

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jammu

Climate activist and engineer Sonam Wangchuk is expected to return home in Leh after undergoing a thorough health check in a good hospital.

A day after he walked free from Jodhpur central jail, his wife Geetanjali Angmo Sunday announced I am taking him for a health checkup as per the strong recommendations of our family doctor.

He will be under medical observation for 36 hours in a good hospital.

In a message posted on X shortly after his release, Angmo wrote, “After a long time, I had a free-flowing chat with Wangchuk without glancing at the scary clock now and then to make the most of the fleeting 60 minutes in jail! Taking him for a health checkup as per



Climate activist Sonam Wangchuk with spouse Gitanjali J Angmo at a hospital for a medical check-up after his release from Jodhpur Central Jail following the revocation of his detention under the NSA on Saturday

the strong recommendations of our family doctor. He will be under medical observation for 36 hours in a good hospital! In the last week of January 2026, Wangchuk was shifted to AIIMS, Jodhpur, where he underwent several investigations in the Gastroenterology

department.

In a separate post, Angmo also talked about her weekly ordeal of visiting him in the jail premises. In a post on X, Angmo, Sunday wrote, “Writing the final letter to the jail superintendent yesterday seeking permission to meet and inform

Wangchuk of his release,” she said. Thanking people in Jodhpur for their support, she added that she was relieved that her husband’s “ordeal of being inside the jail for 170 days” had ended. Angmo also spoke about the personal strain of the months-long detention. She said she had travelled to the prison twice every week for the past five months, often making the journey simply for a one-hour meeting.

“My ordeal of making two trips a week every week for just a 60-minute meeting over the past five months has finally ended,” she wrote.

Wangchuk, 59, had been detained on September 26 last year under the National Security Act following violent protests in Ladakh linked to demands for statehood and inclusion under the Sixth Schedule of the Constitution.

Govt acting in national interest amid West Asia conflict: Hosabale

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Samalakra (Haryana)

Amid the ongoing West Asia conflict, Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) on Sunday called for peace in the world and stressed that the Union Government was taking all steps in the supreme interest of the nation.

RSS general secretary Dattatreya Hosabale said the war should end as swiftly as possible so that people can return to their normal lives.

He was replying to queries during a media briefing on the three-day meet of the Sangh’s top decision-making body — Akhil Bharatiya Pratinidhi Sabha (ABPS).

Asked about the Iran-US-Israel conflict that has entered the third week, the RSS general secretary said, “We want peace in the world.”

“Our vision is world peace. Wars arise from a multitude of causes; therefore, in the context of this par-



RSS general secretary Dattatreya Hosabale

ticular conflict, we too desire that it comes to an end as swiftly as possible, and that the lives of ordinary people return to a state of happiness and peace without delay, he noted.

The top RSS leader said he will not analyse the reasons behind the war.

He said that the Indian Government is making all efforts in

the best interest of the people of the country. “What is in the supreme interest of the nation, they (the Indian Government) are doing that. What they are doing is right,” he told reporters.

To a question on protests that erupted at some places in India following the killing of Iran’s Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, Hosabale said people can express emotions on the death of a person, but it should be done in a peaceful manner. “If such things happen, they should be done peacefully. It should not be against any sect or community,” he said.

“According to Indian tradition, one can be a person’s enemy till he is alive, but after one dies, no one remains an enemy. So, after death, if anyone expresses grief, there is nothing wrong with it. But when this is done, it should be seen that it does not cause disturbance to peace,” he

said. Asked about the row over UGC regulations, which have been stayed by the Supreme Court, he said the matter is before the apex court, and it is not appropriate to comment on sub-judice matters. “When a decision comes, after going through it, the Sangh will comment,” he said.

Replying to another question, Hosabale said, “When Keshav Baliram Hedgewar founded the RSS, he did not say that the organisation had been formed to oppose Muslims.”

“During the British rule, when the RSS faced restrictions in central provinces, a debate took place in an assembly there in which four to five people supported the Sangh, and one of them was a Muslim leader, who said he knew that the Sangh and Dr Hedgewar are not communal and restrictions should not be imposed.”

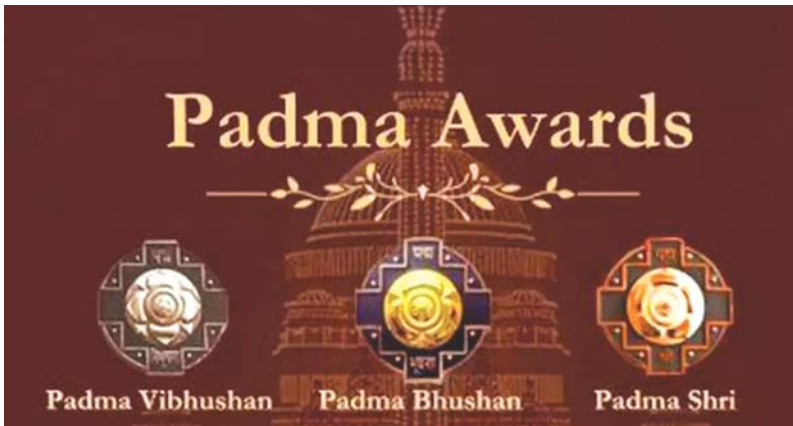
“We have said this from the start that the ancestors of all people of India were Hindus,” he said.

Padma Awards 2027: Nominations open on official portal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Nominations/recommendations for the Padma Awards-2027 to be announced on the occasion of Republic Day, 2027, started on Sunday. The last date for nominations for Padma Awards is July 31, 2026. The nominations/recommendations for Padma Awards will only be received online on the Rashtriya Puraskar Portal (<https://awards.gov.in>), the Ministry of Home Affairs said.

The Padma Awards, namely, Padma Vibhushan, Padma Bhushan and Padma Shri, are amongst the highest civilian awards of the country. Instituted in 1954, these Awards are announced on the occasion of the Republic Day every year. The Award seeks to recognise ‘work of distinction’ and is given for distinguished and exceptional achievements/service in all fields/disciplines, such as Art, Literature and Education, Sports, Medicine, Social Work, Science and Engineering, Public Affairs, Civil Service, Trade and Industry, etc. All persons without distinction of race, occupation, position or sex are eligible



for these Awards. Government servants, including those working with PSUs, except Doctors and Scientists, are not eligible for Padma Awards.

The Government is committed to transforming the Padma Awards into “People’s Padma”. All citizens are, therefore, requested to make nominations/recommendations, including self-nominations. Concerted efforts may be made to identify talented persons whose excellence and achievements

really deserve to be recognised from amongst women, weaker sections of the society, SCs & STs, divyang persons and who are doing selfless service to the society. The nominations/recommendations should contain all relevant details specified in the format available on the above said Portal clearly bringing out the distinguished and exceptional achievements/service of the person recommended in her/his respective field/discipline.

Indian Army kills Pakistani terrorist in Uri infiltration bid

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jammu

A Pakistani terrorist was neutralised by the alert troops of the Indian army along the Line of Control in the Uri sector early Sunday morning.

This is the second major infiltration bid reported along the line of control in Jammu and Kashmir.

Earlier, on Tuesday, the Indian Army eliminated one terrorist after foiling a fresh infiltration bid along the Line of Control (LoC) in the general area of Jhangar, Nowshera. “Based on a specific intelligence input provided by JKP regarding an



infiltration attempt, a joint operation was launched on the intervening night of 14-15 March in the general area Buchhar, Uri sector,” Srinagar-based Chinar Corps of the Army posted on its X handle. It said troops spotted suspicious movement of a terrorist in the

thicket. “The ambush was readjusted, and the terrorist was challenged, resulting in the terrorist opening indiscriminate fire. In the Contact, a Pakistani terrorist was eliminated.

Warlike stores, including an AK rifle, pistols and a large quantity of ammunition, have been recovered,” the army said. The operation was going on till last reports came in. Meanwhile, the joint team of security forces have been carrying out relentless anti-terrorist operations and maintaining a tight vigil along the International border and the line of control to foil intrusion bids.



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Order Order

HC asks Delhi Police to explain illegal detention of activists



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court on Sunday asked the city police to file an affidavit explaining the circumstances and the authority of law under which it detained certain activists last week.

The Delhi Police counsel said all detained persons have been released and the matter was “not so simple”. The counsel also stated during the hearing that the FIR was confidential.

In a special Sunday hearing, a bench of Justices Navin Chawla and Ravinder Dudeja directed preservation of relevant CCTV footage showing how the police took them away.

The court, however, said it would consider the issue of preservation of CCTV footage of Special Cell office at a later stage and listed the matter for the next hearing on March 27. It also listed for hearing on Monday a petition related to one of the detained activists, following his counsel's claim that he was yet to be released. The police maintained that all persons have been released.

“You will have to trace him,” the bench said.

“We are informed that as far as the missing persons alleged to have been illegally detained, they have since been released. The respondent shall file an affidavit explaining the circum-

stances and the authority of the law by which they were detained within a week from today,” the bench ordered.

The counsel appearing for the petitioners alleged that the detained activists were “picked up” in violation of the law, not produced before a magistrate and abused and tortured.

Around 10 activists including students were picked up from outside the Dayal Singh College and Vijay Nagar, the lawyers alleged.

Advocate Shahrulk Alam alleged that the police picked up petitioner Sagrika Rajora's sister, Lakshita Rajora, in plain clothes.

Senior advocate Colin Gonsalves, appearing for petitioner Ehsanul Haq, said the situation was “alarming” and urged the court to direct the police to give them a copy of the FIR. Police said the FIR was confidential in nature.

The counsel appearing for the petitioners said the activists were released only after the news of the High Court constituting a bench to hear the habeas corpus petitions came out.

“We are not closing the petition. We are issuing notice to find out what happened,” the court said.

Alam also requested the court to extend “protection” to the activists and students.

“We don't know what they are required for. We can't say anything,” the court responded.



After HC denial, Kejriwal approaches SC to transfer excise policy case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

AAP leader Arvind Kejriwal approached Supreme Court for changing excise policy case from Justice Swarana Kanta Sharma. Kejriwal approached the apex court under Article 32 of the Constitution. Earlier, Delhi High Court Chief Justice Devendra Kumar Upadhyaya has denied Arvind Kejriwal's request to transfer the excise policy case from Justice Swarana Kanta Sharma to some other Bench. The High Court's Registrar General sent communication on March 13 to eight people who sought the transfer.

“The petition is assigned to the judge as per the current roster. Any call of recusal has to be taken by the judge. I, however, do not find any reason to transfer the petition by passing an order on the administrative side,” the letter quoted Chief Justice Upadhyaya as saying.

In a letter written on March 11, Kejriwal expressed apprehension that if the matter stays with Justice Sharma, the “matter may not receive a hearing marked by impartiality and neutrality”. A trial court had on February 27 discharged Kejriwal and 22 other accused in the excise policy case.

CBI challenged the order and the same is currently being heard by Justice Sharma. On March 9, Justice Sharma issued notice in the matter and stayed the trial court direction for department proceedings against the CBI officer who investigated the case.

Justice Sharma also said a prima facie finding that some of the observations



Justice Swarana Kanta Sharma and Arvind Kejriwal

made by the trial court in its order were erroneous. She also directed the trial court to defer the PMLA proceedings (which are based CBI's FIR).

Kejriwal has said that the order of March 9 does not disclose any reasons as to what “perversity” warranted an ex parte restraint, and the order assumes significance because it is settled that interim interference with an order of discharge is an extraordinary course to be exercised only in rarest of rare circumstances and upon clear grounds of illegality and perversity.

He added that in the same order, the High Court also issued a direction to the trial court to defer the PMLA proceedings even though the ED was not a party before the High Court.

“That the grant of such wide and consequential relief — without the same being pleaded, and in a proceeding

where the ED is not a party — at the threshold stage and without hearing the discharged accused, materially fortifies the applicant's reasonable apprehension that the present revision may not be approached with the requisite degree of judicial detachment, and that the matter may not receive a hearing that is manifestly impartial, as required by settled principles governing apparent bias,” the letter states.

Kejriwal has also said that in the normal course, in a revision petition of this magnitude, at least four to five weeks is granted to parties to file their response, but the Court's approach in this case “conveys an apprehension of pre-disposition”. The AAP leader added that the same judge had earlier dealt with the excise policy matters and “expressed detailed prima facie views on the same nucleus of facts and roles”.

When institutions are feared, democracy is protected



PRASHANT TEWARI

Fear is a natural, universal and intense emotion rooted in human survival. The English philosopher and political theorist Thomas Hobbes opined that fear is the fundamental, organising passion of human existence, suffuses and shapes human life, is both the sole origin of civil society and the only reliable means of its preservation. The English social anthropologist David Parkin, the American historian and political theorist Corey Robin, the German sociologist Norbert Elias and the English social researcher Agnes Pearl Jephcott have also highlighted the role of fear in regulating and sustaining institutions and societies. Yet institutional scholars have often paid limited attention to the role of fear in maintaining institutional equilibrium and stability.

Parental authority, often accompanied by a sense of fear or respect, plays an important role in shaping the behaviour of toddlers. At an early stage of life, children lack the maturity to fully understand the consequences of their actions. Therefore, parental guidance, sometimes reinforced through caution or fear becomes a mechanism to instil discipline, responsibility, and respect for boundaries. This psychological framework helps a child develop self-control and accountability, guiding him toward behaviour that serves both personal well-being and the broader interests of family and society.

In a similar manner, independent institutions in a democratic society perform a comparable function at the collective level.

Institutions such as the judiciary, the legislature, the bureaucracy, and the media act as structural guardians that guide public conduct and governance. Their independence ensures that authority is exercised responsibly and that citizens, leaders, and administrators remain conscious of legal and ethical boundaries.

A functional democracy is sustained not merely by laws and elections but by the strength, credibility, and authority of its institutions. In a country with a vast landmass and an enormous population such as India, governance cannot rely solely on personal authority or individual charisma. Instead, it depends on the enduring power of institutions. One of the less discussed yet important elements of this system is institutional fear: the psychological respect and restraint that institutions inspire among individuals and public authorities.

Institutional fear does not merely imply authoritarian intimidation or suppression of liberty. Rather, it reflects the recognition that institutions are larger than individuals and that the authority of the system must prevail over personal interests. All the world's a stage and politicians, bureaucrats, judges, and journalists are mere temporary players, while institutions remain permanent guardians of constitutional order.

In a democracy, such fear ensures discipline within governance structures. When individuals recognise that institutional norms and rules are supreme, they are less likely to misuse power. The absence of such restraint can lead to institutional erosion, where personal ambition begins to override constitutional responsibility. The democratic framework rests on four core pillars: parliament, the judiciary, the bureaucracy, and the media. Parliament represents the sovereign will of the people through legislation and debate. The judiciary, particularly the Supreme Court of

India, functions as the guardian of the Constitution and ensures that constitutional principles are upheld. The bureaucracy provides administrative continuity and policy implementation, while the media acts as a watchdog by scrutinising Government actions and informing the public.

In this framework, institutional fear acts as a psychological safeguard of democratic order. Citizens respect laws because they believe institutions will enforce them, and public officials adhere to rules because institutional scrutiny and sanctions exist.

Recent developments illustrate the sensitivity surrounding institutional credibility. A controversy arose over a textbook prepared by the National Council of Educational Research and Training that referenced corruption in the judiciary in a Class 8 social science chapter. The Supreme Court of India expressed serious and alarming concern that such portrayals, if presented

without broader context, could undermine public confidence in an essential constitutional institution. The Court observed that the material appeared selective because it focused on alleged corruption in the judiciary while omitting discussion of corruption in other areas such as politics or administration.

The episode highlights an important dimension of institutional fear: public discourse must balance accountability with respect for institutional integrity. Criticism of institutions is a legitimate feature of democracy, but selective, uncontextualised, pejorative and paradoxical criticism can weaken public trust in institutional credibility. Institutional fear therefore operates alongside institutional accountability. Excessive fear without accountability can lead to authoritarianism, while accountability without reciprocal respect for institutions is bound to create instability. The challenge lies in maintaining symmetry

IT dept told to set up expert body for tax dispute cases

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A Parliamentary panel has asked the income tax department to set up an ‘Expert Litigation Committee’ to vet tax dispute cases before filing appeals at the High Courts or Supreme Court, and called for a “paradigm shift” in the department's approach to litigation.

Expressing concern over the I-T department's dismal litigation success rate at a mere 12.07 per cent at the High Court level and 14.50 per cent at the ITAT level in 2024-25, the Standing Committee on Finance, in a report, said that repeated adverse outcomes point to “systemic weaknesses” rather than isolated legal contests.

“There is a need to address the issue of filing of appeals in a mechanical manner simply because the disputed amount exceeds the prescribed pecuniary limit to avoid personal responsibility or vigilance inquiries,” the panel, headed by BJP MP Bhartruhari Mahtab, said in its report tabled in Parliament last week.

As many as 23,230 I-T cases involving a disputed amount of over Rs 3.64 lakh crore are pending before the Income Tax Appellate Tribunal (ITAT) as of the 2024-25 fiscal. 41,321 cases involving Rs 5.65 lakh crore are pending before the High Court, and 6,880 cases with disputed income tax demands of Rs 25,403 crore are pending before the Supreme Court.



The tax department, in its presentation before the Committee, had said it treats litigation as a measure to “uphold principles to safeguard the interests of revenue”.

The panel, however, said that persisting with legally unsustainable appeals actually drains the public exchequer through mounting litigation costs and clogs the national judicial infrastructure. The taxpayers also face years of unwarranted harassment.

The NCERT-judiciary tussle: Can the rule of law be taught without discussing judicial corruption?



RANJIT KUMAR SINHA

The NCERT (National Council of Educational Research and Training) has officially withdrawn its new Class 8 Social Science textbook, Exploring Society: India and Beyond (Part II), which included a section on “Corruption in the Judiciary.” This followed a blanket ban by the Supreme Court, which took suomotu cognisance of Chapter 4, titled “The Role of Judiciary in Our Society.” According to media reports, the Supreme Court orally made some scathing observations during the hearings and described the content as a “calculated move” to scandalise the institution and “pollute young minds,” noting that such portrayals could undermine the public's faith in the rule of law.

In addition to the withdrawal, the Top Court barred the authors from all future curriculum projects, stating the text maliciously targets the institution's reputation. It further directed the Centre, States, and Universities to “dissociate” from the three specific authors for all future publicly funded projects. The Bench, led by Chief Justice Surya Kant, cited a “lack of informed knowledge” and “deliberate misrepresentation” of the judiciary, emphasising that educational materials must maintain institutional respect while discussing systemic challenges.

The controversy came to the fore in late February 2026, following a report in

the media that highlighted the inclusion of a section on judicial corruption in the new NCERT Class 8 Social Science textbook. Two prominent Senior advocates immediately brought the matter to the Supreme Court's attention, stating the Bar was “deeply disturbed” by the selective targeting of the institution.

The Chief Justice of India (CJI), noting that High Court judges across the country had expressed their outrage to him, took suomotu cognisance of the matter, describing the text as a “calculated move” to demean the judiciary. In the ensuing hearings, the Supreme Court imposed a blanket ban on the book and ordered its immediate recall from physical and digital platforms.

The Supreme Court criticised the NCERT for a “major and unpardonable lapse,” specifically pointing out that the chapter had not been vetted by the National Syllabus and Teaching Learning Material Committee (NSTC). It also ordered a new committee, including an eminent jurist, to rewrite the curriculum to ensure a more balanced and respectful portrayal of constitutional institutions.

The developments on this issue have generated a heated debate among the legal fraternity, intellectuals, and the general public. While many in the legal community supported the Court's stance on protecting institutional dignity, a section of activist lawyers and academicians expressed shock over the “extreme” nature of the ban and the blacklisting of scholars, raising concerns about academic freedom and judicial censorship. The public reaction also remains divided; while some see the move as a necessary check against

misinformation, others argue that students should be introduced to the real-world challenges such as backlogs and lack of transparency that public institutions face. There has also been significant criticism by some, including former NCERT chiefs and educationists, who argue that the Council failed to defend its own publication. Critics suggest that both the NCERT leadership and the Union Education Ministry surrendered meekly to the controversy, choosing immediate capitulation and apologies over a robust defence of academic freedom and the inclusion of real-world systemic challenges in the curriculum.

While the Supreme Court has passed several major “interim” directions that have effectively ended the book's life, the suomotu case (In Re: Social Science Textbook For Grade-8) remains on the docket for monitoring and final resolution. The matter remains open because the Supreme Court specifically stated that the three black-listed authors “may approach the Supreme Court seeking modification of the order” after submitting their formal explanations. The Supreme Court also directed the Centre to provide details of social media handles and websites that reacted “irresponsibly” or “maliciously” to the ban. It has indicated it will take further action against these “mischievous mangers” in the upcoming hearings. Until the Supreme Court passes a final order, the legal proceedings are technically active.

However, the entire episode has re-intensified a fiery debate over the alleged prevalence of corruption in the judiciary. This is particularly significant

given the March 2025 incident at Justice Yashwant Varma's residence, where wads of burnt currency were reportedly discovered following a fire. Critics of the ban argue that such real-world events make the discussion of judicial accountability in textbooks a matter of public interest rather than “malicious targeting.”

Justice Varma has since been transferred from the Delhi High Court to his parent court, the Allahabad High Court, where the Supreme Court has directed that he not be assigned any judicial work while proceedings continue. He is currently facing a formal impeachment-related inquiry after the Speaker of the Lok Sabha admitted a motion for his removal in August 2025. Although no impeachment motion in India's history has yet resulted in the actual removal

of a judge—often due to resignations or political abstentions—the issue of corruption in the higher judiciary has consistently hogged the limelight at regular intervals. This persistent cycle of scandal and stalled accountability remains the core of the debate over whether such challenges should be addressed openly in national textbooks.

The current friction between the NCERT and the Supreme Court reminds us of an alleged judicial corruption matter that had shocked the highest judiciary in 2009. A high-profile contempt case was initiated against activist-lawyer Prashant Bhushan following an interview where he alleged that half of the previous 16 CJs were corrupt. The controversy deepened in 2010 when his father, former Law Minister Shanti

Bhushan, filed a daring affidavit in the Supreme Court. He submitted a list of the 16 CJs in a sealed cover. This earlier case serves as a vital backdrop to the 2026 textbook row.

While the Bhushans argued that “truth is a valid defence” and that the judiciary should not use contempt powers to suppress discussions on its own integrity, the Supreme Court remained protective of its public image. After languishing for over a decade, the case was finally closed in August 2022 by a bench that ironically included Justice Surya Kant (who now leads the 2026 NCERT proceedings).

The 2022 closure was based on Bhushan's explanation that he used the word “corruption” in a broad sense to mean a “lack of propriety” rather than just financial bribery. A similar defence was originally offered by the NCERT.

The connection between these two eras is clear: the Supreme Court's recent “suomotu” action against the Class 8 textbook reflects a long-standing institutional sensitivity toward allegations that target the Chief Justice's office. Critics of the 2026 ban point out that while the Court closed the Bhushan case with a degree of leniency in 2022, its reaction to the NCERT in 2026 has been significantly more punitive.

By blacklisting the authors and ordering a total recall of the books, the Court has signalled that while it may tolerate criticism from seasoned lawyers in a courtroom, it draws a strict “red line” at allowing similar discourse to reach the “impressionable minds” of the nation's school children. Here, it would be relevant to read the August 30, 2022, final order in the Bhushan case. It

reads: “The alleged acts of contempt that gave rise to this Contempt Petition are stated to have been committed on or about 5th September, 2009. The proceedings have been pending for 13 years.”

“In view of the explanation/apology tendered by the respondents, we do not deem it necessary to proceed with the contempt. Magnanimity and restraint are also facets of the majesty of this Court.” “The contempt proceedings are accordingly dropped,” the Supreme Court had said in the order.

Now coming back to the tussle between the Supreme Court and the NCERT, it is simply clear that though the Supreme Court has played a proactive role to protect the image of the judiciary from being tarnished, it has simultaneously ignited a fundamental debate over the boundaries of academic freedom and the transparency of public institutions. Besides, murmur of corruption and judicial misconduct against the judges at different levels of the judiciary has also been gaining currency.

By effectively scrubbing the mention of judicial corruption from the Class 8 curriculum, the Supreme Court has succeeded in safeguarding its immediate reputation. However, it has also left a vacuum in the discourse on constitutional accountability.

As the newly mandated committee begins the task of rewriting the chapter, the challenge remains: how to educate students on the “Rule of Law” without ignoring the very real systemic challenges that continue to test the integrity of the Indian judicial system.

Writer is a senior journalist covering legal affairs

Editor's TAKE

The lessons from Ladakh

Sonam Wangchuk, the environmentalist and activist from Ladakh walks free as Govt revokes NSA but larger questions about his arrest remain

After six months of detention, the activist and environmentalist Sonam Wangchuk has been released. The Government revoked the NSA slapped on him even as the Supreme Court continued to hear the Habeas Corpus writ filed by his wife, and the next hearing was slated for March 17. Sonam Wangchuk is much revered and a respected public figure known for his work on education, sustainability, and Himalayan ecology. He is also known for the Gandhian way of life and protesting for the just cause in a peaceful manner. Wangchuk is also a recipient of the Ramon Magsaysay Award, given to distinguish individuals with an incredible track record in public service. He was detained in September under the stringent provisions of the National Security Act after protests in Ladakh turned violent.

The charges against him were rather harsh, and he was accused of making provocative speeches that allegedly contributed to unrest in the region. Wangchuk, however, had been on a hunger strike and was demanding full statehood for Ladakh and constitutional protections for the region's tribal communities, land, and fragile ecosystem. Nowhere did he mention a secession from India or anything to suggest that he was fighting the Indian State. His demands were well within the constitutional framework of the country.

The Government's decision to invoke the National Security Act, which allows detention without formal charges for up to a year, was widely criticised. It was uncalled for to say the least. Wangchuk is not a militant. He is best known for pioneering ice stupa water conservation projects in the Himalayas and for transforming education in Ladakh. His life even inspired a character in the popular film '3 Idiots'. Though he is a free man now, the damage has been done. Detaining him under a national security law sent a wrong message to the people that peaceful dissent was being crushed. A more nuanced approach could be to talk and engage with him and consider his genuine demands.

Ladakh is a sensitive border state and needs a very cautious approach; a little misstep can plunge the valley into chaos, which can be taken advantage of by regimes across the border. The roots of the controversy lie in Ladakh's political transition after 2019, when the Central government reorganised the former state of Jammu and Kashmir and created Ladakh as a separate Union Territory directly governed by New Delhi. The absence of a local legislature and concerns about land rights soon sparked anxiety among Ladakh's tribal communities. The Leh Apex Body began demanding constitutional safeguards under the Sixth Schedule, which would grant tribal councils greater control over land, culture, and local governance. Wangchuk became the voice of Ladakh, articulating these demands. His arguments were not merely political but also ecological: Ladakh's is one of the most fragile ecosystems in the Himalayas, and rapid development could irreversibly damage its environment. If Ladakh's voice is heard and its concerns addressed, the region can become a model of sustainable development in the Himalayas.

PIC TALK



Indian artistes perform at Vasant Mela organised by the Indian Embassy, in Beijing

—PHOTO: PTI

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SONAM WANGCHUK'S DETENTION RAISES DEMOCRATIC QUESTIONS

Apropos the news report 'Sonam Wangchuk walks free as Govt revokes detention' (March 15). The release of Sonam Wangchuk after the government revoked his detention under the NSA deserves careful reflection. Preventive detention laws are meant for exceptional circumstances where national security faces an immediate and serious threat.

Their use against individuals associated with public movements often raises legitimate concerns about the balance between security and democratic freedoms.

Wangchuk, known internationally for his work on sustainable development and education in Ladakh, has become a prominent voice in discussions about the region's political and environmental future.

While maintaining law and order is undoubtedly the government's responsibility, it is equally important that dissent and peaceful advocacy are not viewed as threats to national stability.

The decision to revoke his detention, especially with a court hearing approaching, indicates that dialogue may be a more constructive path than prolonged incarceration.

Ladakh's aspirations for safeguards and greater political representation cannot be addressed through administrative measures alone.

A democratic society grows stronger when differences are resolved through dialogue, transparency and trust rather than through extraordinary legal action.

SANJAY | MOHALI

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

QR CODE

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Billions for climate, but where is the justice?

As debates intensify around the adequacy, accountability and structure of climate funding, the performance of the GCF offers an important lens through which to examine whether global climate finance is meeting its moral and political promises.



PRACHI MALIK

The Green Climate Fund (GCF) was created in 2010 during the 16th Conference of Parties (CoP) of United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change (UNFCCC) to operationalise climate finance under the UNFCCC and now serves the Paris Agreement under Article 9. As the largest dedicated multilateral climate fund, it sits at the centre of global efforts to translate the principle of common but differentiated responsibilities into practice. However, the real question is not whether the GCF exists, but whether it is delivering climate justice. When assessed against criteria such as additionality, adequacy, balance between adaptation and mitigation, predictability, and broader climate justice dimensions, the record appears mixed.

Several justice pillars shape climate finance. Distributive justice concerns fair allocation of climate costs based on equity, need, capacity, and responsibility. Procedural justice emphasises inclusive decision-making. Reparative justice addresses who should bear climate-related losses. Recognition justice values diverse affected communities. Intergenerational justice holds present generations accountable to future ones.

There have been several contestations with respect to how much climate finance have already been mobilised. This is where the controversy surrounding the \$100 billion target becomes relevant. The Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD) reported that the annual \$100 billion climate finance target was met in 2022. However, this claim has been widely contested. A substantial share of reported finance consists of loans. Loan-heavy finance shifts financial risk onto developing countries, burdening them further.

Starting with Additionality. Climate finance was never meant to be a rebranded form of development assistance. It is grounded in historical responsibility and ecological debts. From a reparative justice perspective, climate finance should be new, in addition to existing aid commitments. If it simply replaces development assistance or is provided primarily through loans, its moral foundation weakens.

The Green Climate Fund performs better than many bilateral channels by providing a mix of grants and concessional finance, with a strong grant component for vulnerable countries. It maintains a balance between adaptation and mitigation funding, prioritises Least Developed Countries and Small Island Developing States, and strengthens country ownership through readiness support and direct access for national institutions. However, it does not operate in isolation from the



broader political economy of climate finance. Ambiguities surrounding what constitutes additional finance persist. If climate finance is indistinguishable from development assistance, accountability for historical emissions becomes blurred. In principle, the GCF supports additionality. In practice, however, its ability to fully realise reparative justice is constrained by the contribution patterns of donor states and systemic limitations in global finance.

The scale of climate needs far exceeds available finance, with estimates suggesting that around USD 1.3 trillion per year may be required by 2035 to adequately support mitigation and adaptation in developing countries. GCF prioritises least developed countries, small island developing states, and African states, directing a substantial share of resources toward Africa and the Asia-Pacific. This reflects an effort to address differentiated vulnerability and advance distributive and recognition justice. However, justice is not only about distribution; it is also about volume. The GCF relies on voluntary contributions and periodic replenishments. Even the most carefully designed allocation framework cannot compensate for insufficient total finance. The inadequacy of the \$100 billion goal became evident in negotiations leading to the New Quantified Goal (NQG) agreed at COP29 of UNFCCC. It calls for mobilising at least \$300 billion annually, within a broader ambition of scaling finance to \$1.3 trillion per year by 2035. This shift recognises that the previous target was materially inadequate. Yet it remains politically negotiated rather than legally binding. Without stronger accountability, transparent reporting, and a greater emphasis on grant-based finance, the structural weaknesses exposed under the \$100 billion regime may simply be carried forward. The balance between adaptation and mitigation is one area where the GCF is trying to promote a clearer justice orientation. The Fund is mandated to allocate 50 per cent of its resources to adaptation and 50 per cent to mitigation, with half of adaptation finance directed to particularly vulnerable countries. This structure acknowledges both present vulnerability and future risk.

THE GCF REPRESENTS A SERIOUS INSTITUTIONAL ATTEMPT TO EMBED JUSTICE PRINCIPLES WITHIN CLIMATE FINANCE GOVERNANCE

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The Harishchandra of Odisha

ultimate salvation. As a result, families from across the country bring the bodies of their loved ones to Puri for their final journey. However, the journey is not always easy, particularly for families from remote villages who arrive without money, local contacts, or knowledge of the procedures required for cremation. This is where Badri Mishra steps in. He helps grieving families with everything—from arranging paperwork and rituals to organising the cremation itself—often at his own expense.”I have never charged any money for the work I do,” Mishra says simply. “My only aim is to ensure that even the abandoned are given a dignified farewell. In my life, I have carried more bodies than some people have carried responsibilities.” His dedication has earned him the title ‘Harishchandra of Odisha.’

Mishra's life, echoes that spirit of sacrifice and service. His journey into this unusual calling began early. Mishra was just three years old when he witnessed the cremation of his sister at Swargadwar. The memory stayed with him. Years later, in 1974, when a close friend died and no one stepped forward to perform the final rites, Mishra took responsibility. That moment marked the beginning of a life-long mission. Over the years, Mishra balanced his service with a government job. Eventually, however he devoted himself fully to social work. Armed with little more than a motorcycle, a sacred thread, a towel, and a bottle of Ganga water, he has spent decades rushing to cremation grounds

whenever he receives a call. His routine is relentless. He often returns home at 2 A.M. only to leave again before dawn. The family, which includes a son and daughter, has faced financial hardships after he left his government job.

Mishra's service extends far beyond Swargadwar. He has performed last rites for unidentified accident victims, suicide cases, and disaster casualties whose bodies would otherwise remain unattended. He assisted during the cremation of victims of the devastating 1999 Odisha super cyclone, the 2001 Gujarat earthquake, and the 2015 earthquake in Kathmandu. During the COVID-19 pandemic—when fear kept many indoors—Mishra continued his work without hesitation, helping cremate victims at crematoriums in Bhubaneswar and Cuttack. His extraordinary service has earned him numerous honours, including the Dadhichi Award, the Utkal Ratna, and recognition from the Governor of Odisha. His name has also been recommended for the prestigious Padma awards. In recognition of his humanitarian work, he was invited to the Rashtrapati Bhavan by the President of India, Droupadi Murmu. Even in death, Mishra hopes to continue serving others. He has signed an agreement with SCB Medical College in Cuttack to donate his body for medical research. Inspired by him, more than a hundred people have pledged to donate their bodies as well.

The Pioneer SINCE 1865

The writer is a veteran journalist and President Press Association

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Menstrual leave policy debate

The Supreme Court was pragmatic in dismissing the PIL seeking mandatory menstrual leave for working women (March 14). Undeniably, women in India perform multiple roles simultaneously—as professionals, mothers, spouses and caregivers—constantly adapting to diverse responsibilities. Menstruation is a natural biological process that many women experience regularly, and it can indeed take a physical and emotional toll.

However, making menstrual leave mandatory may unintentionally harm women's employment prospects. In an era where automation and artificial intelligence are already reducing job opportunities across sectors, employers may perceive women employees as less dependable or more costly. Some organisations might prefer hiring men, particularly for senior roles, fearing disruption if key responsibilities are affected by mandatory leave. Such perceptions could undermine women's professional advancement. Moreover, after decades of struggle to overcome stereotypes of being the “weaker sex”, mandatory menstrual leave could unintentionally create another form of stigma. A more balanced approach would be introducing gender-neutral flexible leave policies that employees can use when required. Allowing work-from-home may also provide support without creating workplace bias.

V JAYARAMAN | CHENNAI

Inauguration ceremonies by Chief Minister

This refers to the report, “CM Rekha launches amphibious excavators for city drain cleaning” (Mar 14). Over the past year, the Chief Minister has inaugurated a wide range of civic and welfare projects, including buses, can- teens, health camps, and several schemes aimed at improving public services. While these initiatives are important, the frequency of such ceremonial launches may give the impression that the CM is more engaged in appearances than in effective governance. The office of a Chief Minister carries immense responsibility, requiring focus on policymaking, long-term development, and addressing challenges such as economic growth, healthcare, education, and law and order. Routine inaugurations could be delegated to municipal or departmental officials, allowing the CM to devote time to matters that demand leadership at the highest level. Public perception plays a crucial role in politics. If a leader is associated with many ribbon-cutting events, it can diminish the stature of the office and can shift attention away from the broader responsibilities of governance. Ensuring that the CM provides leadership on broader policy while delegating routine functions locally can maintain both the effectiveness of governance and the dignity of the role.

DR O PRASADA RAO | HYDRABAD

Debate over mercy killing

Recently, the Supreme Court delivered a significant verdict allowing the removal of the ventilator of Harish Rana, a young man who has been in a coma for 13 years. Harish, now 32, suffered a fall from the fourth floor of a building and has remained in a medically defined irreversible permanent vegetative state ever since. Euthanasia, often described as mercy killing or the right to die, refers to intentionally ending the life of a patient to relieve them from unbearable suffering caused by severe illness. When a person suffers from an incurable condition, and all available medical treatments have failed, euthanasia is sometimes considered as a means to end prolonged pain and distress. For many years, activists across the world have advocated legal recognition of euthanasia. Yet, ethical concerns and humanitarian considerations have made the issue deeply controversial.

The Supreme Court's decision to permit removal of the ventilator relied on the fundamental principle of the right to die with dignity. Nevertheless, debates over whether mercy killing is morally right or wrong will likely continue. This judgment may redefine how euthanasia is interpreted in the future, especially in relation to patient rights and humane medical care.

DATTAPRASAD SHIRODKAR | MUMBAI

HPV Vaccination: A policy imperative or global lobbying at work?

India’s vaccination campaign against Human papillomavirus (HPV), aims to prevent cervical cancer. The programme — implemented through a procurement partnership with Gavi, the Vaccine Alliance and supported by the Bill & Melinda Gates Foundation — has reignited debate over the role of global philanthropic institutions in national policy

FIRST
Column



ASHWANI
MAHAJAN

From 28 February 2026, the Government of India launched a single-shot HPV vaccination programme for girls aged 14 years, with a target of 1.15 crore vaccinations each year. The vaccine has been approved by India’s drug regulator, and its supply is being procured through a mechanism in partnership with Gavi, the Vaccine Alliance, which is primarily promoted and funded by the Bill & Melinda Gates Foundation.

This decision has been widely criticised in several quarters for various reasons. Critics argue that it represents a case of interference by a foreign organisation in India’s health policymaking. Secondly, the programme is being promoted with the support of the Gates Foundation, whose activities have long been viewed with suspicion by some observers.

In fact, the Gates Foundation (earlier BMGF) is not being criticised without reason, according to its detractors. In the past, several objections and allegations have been levelled against its co-founder, Bill Gates, regarding controversial experiments allegedly carried out under his direction in different parts of the world. One recent example cited by critics occurred during the India AI Impact Summit 2026, when Bill Gates faced opposition at multiple levels. The controversy stemmed from allegations connected to the so-called “Epstein Files,” which reportedly mentioned extramarital affairs and related issues. As a result, critics say his public image was further damaged and his scheduled programme was ultimately cancelled.

Critics also argue that Bill Gates views India as a laboratory for clinical trials. In 2024, he reportedly stated that India functions as a kind of experimental environment where new initiatives are tested before being expanded elsewhere. The Gates Foundation, however, maintains that his remarks were meant as praise for India’s capacity for innovation and implementation. Nevertheless, based on past experiences with the foundation, critics claim that trials are being conducted in India at his behest, treating Indians as “guinea pigs” for vaccine development.



CRITICS POINT OUT THAT WHILE INDIA IS LAUNCHING A UNIVERSAL HPV VACCINATION PROGRAMME, THE UPTAKE OF HPV VACCINATION IN THE UNITED STATES HAS REPORTEDLY DECLINED IN RECENT YEARS

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They argue that such practices would be both unethical and legally questionable.

Trials related to the Human papillomavirus (HPV) vaccine were indeed conducted in parts of India in 2009. At the time, the Parliamentary Standing Committee on Health and Family Welfare criticised the Program for Appropriate Technology in Health (PATH), an organisation associated with the Gates Foundation, for allegedly conducting unethical and illegal trials. According to the committee’s report, several girls reportedly fell ill and some died after being included in HPV vaccine trials without proper informed consent from their parents. The committee recommended strict action against both PATH and the Gates Foundation.

Following protests, the Government of India withdrew the proposal to include the HPV vaccine in the Universal Immunisation Programme in 2018. However, critics claim that intense lobbying by the Gates Foundation later led several state governments to introduce the vaccine in their own vaccination programmes, and that similar efforts continue in other states.

According to these critics, the foundation has been able to influence key policymakers in both central and state governments. They further allege that the foundation attracts former health ministry

officials by offering lucrative positions after retirement and maintains influence over some current officials as well.

Supporters of the HPV vaccine argue that cervical cancer primarily results from persistent infection with high-risk strains of HPV, especially types 16 and 18. The risk increases with early sexual activity, multiple sexual partners, weakened immunity (such as in HIV/AIDS), smoking, poor genital hygiene, and multiple pregnancies. Long-term HPV infection can lead to abnormal changes in cervical cells that may eventually develop into cancer if not detected and treated early through screening.

Although the government has presented the vaccination programme as a measure to protect women from cervical cancer, critics point out that the disease—while significant—is the fourth most common cancer globally and the second most common cancer among women in India after breast cancer.

Even so, it currently accounts for only about 10 percent of all female cancers, and its incidence has been declining over time. Another concern raised is the lack of reliable national screening data to accurately determine the number of affected women and their geographical distribution.

Available reports suggest that only a few states—particularly some in North-East India—have relatively higher rates of cervical cancer.

Critics therefore argue that the government should first have launched a comprehensive national screening programme to determine the intensity and regional distribution of the disease before initiating a nationwide vaccination campaign.

Research based on the Global Burden of Disease Study (1990-2019) indicates that the age-standardised incidence rate of cervical cancer in India has been declining, with an average annual reduction of about 0.82 percent between 1990 and 2019. Mortality from cervical cancer declined even faster, at roughly 1.35 percent per year during the same period. This suggests that the overall risk per woman in the population has been gradually decreasing.

Researchers attribute this decline mainly to social changes such as later age at marriage and first childbirth, fewer pregnancies, improved hygiene and living standards, and increased awareness and screening in urban areas. These factors have collectively reduced cervical cancer risk in many parts of India.

By contrast, the incidence of breast cancer has been rising steadily. It has now

become the most common cancer among women in India. In 2023, the age-standardised incidence rate of breast cancer was about 29.4 cases per 100,000 women per year, with approximately 2.0-2.03 lakh new cases annually.

The rate has increased significantly—from about 13 per 100,000 women in 1990 to 29.4 per 100,000 in 2023, more than doubling over three decades.

Critics therefore argue that while overall cancer incidence is rising—particularly in the case of breast cancer—the government has not implemented equally strong measures such as large-scale early screening programmes for breast cancer. Instead, they say, it has chosen to prioritise the vaccination of young girls against HPV.

The debate surrounding HPV vaccine advocacy is also complicated by potential conflicts of interest. Some independent researchers have pointed out that a substantial proportion of published research on vaccine safety and efficacy has been funded by, or conducted in collaboration with, pharmaceutical companies.

Given these concerns—along with the earlier controversy surrounding HPV trials, questions about long-term effectiveness in low-screening environments, and the role of pharmaceutical lobbying—critics argue that the Government of India’s decision to launch a nationwide HPV vaccination programme may have been taken too hastily.

They also note that even after vaccination, regular cervical screening remains necessary, and that broader public-health interventions—such as improved sanitation, nutrition, awareness programmes, and affordable screening facilities—may deliver wider health benefits. Finally, critics point out that while India is launching a universal HPV vaccination programme, the uptake of HPV vaccination in the United States has reportedly declined in recent years.

Data from the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention shows that among adolescents eligible for free vaccines through the Vaccines for Children (VFC) programme, the proportion who were up to date on HPV vaccination by age 13 fell by about 10 percentage points for those born in 2010 compared with those born in 2007. Some observers therefore fear that surplus vaccines from other countries may eventually be redirected to markets such as India.

The role of mindset in healing the body



PRATIKSHA
VATS

The lab report confirms Type 2 diabetes. The monitor flashes a stubborn 150/95 blood pressure reading. The weighing scale refuses to budge despite weeks of meticulously weighed salads and daily sweat. In an instant, the body—once a silent partner—feels like a battlefield. During my practice, I have witnessed this silence countless times: the heavy pause after a diagnosis, the fear masked by “forced discipline,” and the crushing frustration when biological progress seems invisible. Naturally, we sprint toward the tangible; we obsess over food charts, calorie counts, glycemic indices, and step goals. These are the bricks and mortar of health, but there is a silent architect governing whether those bricks actually hold a structure together: mindset. There is a profound piece of wisdom that suggests: “When it is not possible to change the situation, change the state of mind; everything else will follow.” In the realm of health, this is not just philosophy; it is physiology. When changing a medical situation is not immediately possible, changing the state of mind becomes the most critical intervention available. A diagnosis cannot always be erased overnight, hormonal imbalances do not stabilise in a week, and a fatty liver does not vanish because we panicked. In fact, panic is biochemically counterproductive. The way we respond mentally can either act as a catalyst for cellular repair or a silent handbrake on our own recovery. Cultivating a mindset of calm awareness, patience, and curiosity can set the stage for recovery even before the first prescription is taken or the first step is walked.

The Tale of Two Narratives

Consider two patients, Rajesh and Imran, both diagnosed with Type 2 diabetes within the same month. Their clinical starting points were almost identical, yet their trajectories could not have been more different. Rajesh reacted with a cocktail of anger and defeat, viewing the diagnosis as a personal betrayal. To him, the diet was a “sentence” and the exercise was a “punishment.” When sugar readings did not drop dramatically by the fourteenth day, he interpreted the data as a failure. His stress increased, triggering the liver to release more glucose, effectively undoing his hard work. Imran, on the other hand, chose a different internal dialogue, seeing the diagnosis as a long-overdue conversation with his body. He approached his daily walks as a gift of move-



ment and his mindful eating as a form of self-respect. He celebrated small wins, observed patterns rather than judgment, and adjusted without self-blame. Three months later, Rajesh’s readings fluctuated wildly under the weight of his own mental tension, while Imran’s improved steadily. The difference was not just the medication; it was the mental environment in which that medication was expected to work.

The Weight of Self-Criticism

Weight management reflects this same principle with even more intensity. Neha insisted, “My metabolism is broken,” because even though her food log showed improvement and her exercise was consistent, the scale was stuck. The culprit was not a slow metabolism but a high-stress internal narrative. Every minor indulgence—a cookie, a missed workout—triggered guilt, which led to “all-or-nothing” thinking and kept her nervous system in a state of defense.

We shifted focus from the meal plan to her internal dialogue. Instead of “I failed,” she practiced saying, “I am learning.” She also learned to observe sensations like hunger and satiety without judgment. Within weeks, sleep improved, stress-induced cravings vanished, and the scale began to move. Her body wasn’t blocked by calories alone; it was blocked by the way she spoke to herself. This underscores a vital truth: mindset is not an abstract concept; it is the very operating system of recovery.

From Failure to Feedback

A weight-loss plateau or a temporary spike in blood sugar can feel catastrophic. If interpreted as failure, motivation dies, sleep suffers, and consistency weakens. But if seen as feedback, the entire trajectory changes. In a feedback mindset, a sugar spike isn’t a reason to quit; it signals that the previous meal needed more fiber or less refined starch.

A plateau isn’t proof the body is “broken”; it’s a sign that adaptation has occurred and a new challenge is needed. Even a missed day at the gym or an unplanned indulgence becomes data rather than doom. The event remains the same; the interpretation determines whether we move forward or spiral backward.

The Circle of Recovery

Healing is never an isolated event, and families and caregivers play a crucial, often underestimated role. Patients often feel frustrated with slow progress, while well-meaning caregivers can unintentionally amplify stress through constant worry or subtle criticism. Families that approach recovery with patience, empathy, and calm awareness see better emotional and physical outcomes. A pause before reacting, a softer tone, or a willingness to listen can transform the environment—even if the medical reality remains unchanged. Small gestures, like celebrating tiny improvements, offering reassurance, or creating consistent routines, make recovery less intimidating and more motivating. A supportive environment literally reduces stress hormones, reinforcing the mind-body connection in measurable ways.

The Biology of Perspective

Changing mindset does not replace diet or medicine; it strengthens them. Modern research in psychoneuroimmunology confirms the link between mental state and physical health. Chronic stress elevates cortisol, disrupts insulin sensitivity, hampers digestion, and increases inflammation. Conversely, a resilient, positive mindset improves immune response and treatment adherence. A calm mind allows the body to remain in “rest and digest”—the only state in which true recovery occurs. Understanding this gives patients agency; they realise they are not merely passive recipients of prescriptions, but active participants in their healing journey.

The Decision to Heal

In a world searching for the next superfood or fastest bio-hack, we often overlook the most potent tool we already possess: our thoughts. Direction begins in the mind. While food nourishes cells, exercise strengthens muscles, and medication regulates chemistry, it is mindset that sustains the consistency. Consistency is what transforms temporary change into lifelong transformation.

Sometimes, the most powerful medicine is found in a quiet, internal decision to respond with patience instead of panic, and commitment instead of complaint. Healing does not begin with a pill or a plan; it begins the moment we choose to think differently. By aligning our thoughts, emotions, and actions, we move out of internal conflict and into a state of flow. Only then do the body, the habits, and the results follow. By treating the body as a partner rather than a battleground, we find that once we change the state of our mind, the health of the body begins to change on its own.

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India can beat non-communicable diseases with yoga and naturopathy



RAJESH
KUMAR SINGH

The world today is confronting a silent but devastating epidemic: the relentless rise of Non-Communicable Diseases (NCDs). Chronic illnesses such as heart disease, diabetes, cancer and respiratory disorders now account for nearly three-quarters of global deaths, according to the World Health Organisation. In India, the situation is even more concerning. NCDs are responsible for nearly two-thirds of all deaths, affecting millions of families and placing enormous pressure on the country’s healthcare system.

What makes this crisis particularly troubling is that most of these illnesses are largely preventable. Their primary drivers are not unknown pathogens but the way modern societies live. Sedentary lifestyles, chronic stress, ultra-processed food consumption, disrupted sleep cycles, tobacco and alcohol use, environmental pollution, and weakening social support systems have collectively created a perfect storm for chronic illness. As human lifestyles have drifted further away from biological balance, diseases linked to metabolism, stress and inflammation have surged in parallel.

For decades, medical systems around the world have focused largely on treatment—intervening after disease has already developed. Hospitals, drugs and advanced procedures remain essential, but they are increasingly proving insufficient to tackle a crisis. What the present moment demands is a shift toward prevention and management.

A new consensus is gradually emerging around the importance of integrative medicine. This approach combines conventional clinical care with scientifically validated lifestyle interventions. The goal is not merely to treat disease but to address its underlying causes. Within this evolving framework, Yoga and Naturopathy occupy a particularly important space. Far from being fringe or “alternative” therapies, these disciplines increasingly align with the principles of modern lifestyle medicine. They directly address many of the most significant risk factors associated with NCDs—physical inactivity, stress, obesity, hypertension, poor diet, respiratory dysfunction, metabolic inflammation, sleep disturbances and emotional disorders. A growing body of clinical research supports the effectiveness of lifestyle-based interventions. Studies consistently demonstrate that structured yoga practices, natural therapies, dietary correction, hydrotherapy, and stress-management techniques can significantly reduce blood pressure, improve blood sugar control, lower cholesterol levels, enhance lung function, and alleviate chronic pain. In several

cases, early markers of heart disease and metabolic dysfunction have even shown signs of reversal when lifestyle interventions are applied consistently. India, interestingly, already possesses a major but under-recognised strength in this field. Across the country, more than 100 medical colleges are currently training physicians in Bachelor of Naturopathy and Yogic Sciences (BNYS), along with postgraduate specialists.

If present trends continue, these institutions are expected to produce nearly 50,000 qualified professionals by 2035. BNYS physicians undergo structured medical education that includes anatomy, physiology, pathology, diagnostics, clinical medicine, nutrition, rehabilitation and advanced yoga-based therapeutics. Their training enables them to function as primary-care lifestyle medicine practitioners who can help patients prevent disease progression, manage chronic conditions, and reduce dependence on hospital care. However, despite this potential, the Yoga and Naturopathy sector still faces important challenges. Standards of practice remain uneven in some areas, and the absence of comprehensive statutory regulation limits the system’s ability to fully integrate into mainstream healthcare. Establishing clear regulatory frameworks is therefore essential. Proper oversight would help standardise education, licensing and clinical guidelines while protecting patients from unqualified practitioners. It would also strengthen the credibility of Yoga and Naturopathy in research collaborations, international partnerships and public health programmes.

At a time when India is confronting a rapidly expanding burden of lifestyle diseases, failing to harness a trained preventive-medicine workforce would be a missed opportunity. There is also a larger global dimension to this discussion. Yoga and naturopathy are not borrowed concepts—they originate from India’s own civilisational knowledge systems. Today, as healthcare systems worldwide search for sustainable ways to manage chronic disease, these traditions are attracting renewed international interest. With appropriate regulation, academic strengthening and integration into national health programmes, India has a unique opportunity to position itself as a global leader in evidence-based lifestyle medicine. The need of the hour is clear: recognise the scale of the NCD crisis, strengthen preventive healthcare, integrate lifestyle medicine into national policy, and empower the growing BNYS workforce to play a meaningful role in public health. The choices made today will determine the health of the next generation. The moment to act is now.

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PAPER vs **PHYSICAL**

There are, of course, some experts who predict that global crude prices may climb up to \$200 a barrel, or double the current figure. There are those who contend that the International Energy Agency's (IEA) announcement of the largest "coordinated emergency release" of oil stocks, 400 million barrels from its reserves, will act as a huge counter, and crude will hover around \$100 or so, and settle at \$90. Between these two extremes, nations and policy-makers, both producers and consumers, are unable to figure out strategies in real time. This is evident from the huge difference in the paper and physical prices of crude. The futures, which spiked to \$120, are at \$100. "However, the premium of physical Dubai crude has surged to \$38 per barrel over its paper equivalent," according to data compiled by a news agency. The wide gap, the latter hinting crude at nearly \$150, tells a new story.

According to the 'paper' believers, as mentioned earlier, the release of IEA's emergency stocks, coupled with the US President Donald Trump's calming comments that the war will end soon are huge balm. It is another matter that Trump keeps changing his statements, and only yesterday claimed that although Iran's main oil port was destroyed, America may still bomb it "just for fun." Iran seems to be interested in ending the war, although it has set stiff conditions for the western world. Europe wants an end to the war. But Israel wants an end to Iran, and the Middle East nations, who bore the brunt of the Iranian missiles over the past two weeks, want a weak, rather decimated, Iran. Hence, there are pressures and counter-pressures, but the 'paper' theorists seem sure that either the war will end, or supplies increase.

However, the 'physical' believers say that the war is unlikely to end soon, and even the emergency supplies may be a matter of too little, too late. "The IEA-coordinated release will take weeks and possibly months to reach the market. The US release of stocks as part of the IEA action will take about 120 days to complete," according to ING's strategists. They explain that if similar timelines are assumed for the release by the other nations, the extra flows will be just over three million barrels per day, which is "far short of the supply losses we are seeing from the Persian Gulf." According to the IEA, Gulf producers slashed their combined crude output by at least 10 million barrels per day due to the Iran crisis. In addition, according to some experts, the "supply volumes at risk this time are dimensionally bigger, and real" when compared to the Russia-Ukraine war in 2022, when supplies flowed freely.

Asia, especially large consumers like India and China, are caught in the middle. One, the two nations will compete fiercely and aggressively for the Russian supplies, which the US has allowed until April 11, 2026. "Asia's alternative crude supply sources are severely limited.... Asian refiners will struggle to fulfil crude buying requirements for April, leading to run costs across the region. Refiners will be dipping into their buffer stocks, which is typically up to 15 days of their needs," says an analyst. Others agree that Indian stockpiles are among the lowest in the region. Until now, the crisis in India has engulfed the LPG market, mainly because of mistaken policies, and statements. Withdrawing huge chunks from the commercial segment to maintain supplies to the households backfired as it created a panic reaction, which rocked the tech platform that was crucial for supplies. Demand surged as suppliers and buyers both resorted to hoarding once they read and heard media headlines that screamed of restaurants shutting down.

More importantly, while Trump and his loyalists irregularly and with uncertainty claim that the Iran war is almost over, and oil supplies are enough to sustain the global demand, there are few takers. This is because, as mentioned earlier, the same people say in the same breath that the US military is focused on "military operations, and solving a crisis." This implies that the solution is not over. In addition, the same loyalists contend that the American Navy is not ready to escort tankers through the crucial Strait of Hormuz. Which implies that the war is on, and unlikely to end soon. Caught between these statements, what they mean, and their implications are the pessimists and optimists, and many who do not know what to believe, or make of the situation. As a media report explains, "While the paper market reacts to comments and attempts at assurances, the physical crude market is flashing signs of stress and distress as a large portion of global oil supply is now off the market for weeks, possibly months."

Some of these twists, paradoxes, and contradictions are visible in India. There was news that Iran, as a friendly gesture, allowed two ships to sail from the Strait of Hormuz to India, and more tankers may be allowed in the future. Indian officials claimed Iran to be a friend, which will not try to disrupt oil supplies to India. Iranian sources claimed that this was not the case, and tankers through the Strait are at risk.

The Pioneer

NEW DELHI | MONDAY | MARCH 16, 2026

BUSINESS

10

Small investors lose silvery edge

Retail buyers get the timing wrong, as is the case in most assets

The markets, the winners contend, is about timing the market. Which essentially implies the right time to buy, and the right one to sell. Not once but possibly several times during an ongoing rally. Timing the market, say experts, is possibly the toughest thing to achieve. But what experience teaches us is that the small investors, the retail investors, are invariably caught on the wrong foot when they aim to gain from a rally. The large institutional traders perform better. A recent report by Vallum Capital proves this dictum, as it tracks the trading behaviours of the two sets in the booming silver market.

In the last four years, between January 2022 and February 2026, global silver prices went up by five times to \$120 an ounce before they sharply corrected to \$80 or so. During these 49 months, there was a long period when the price ranged within a band, followed by a slightly steady rise. Thereafter, within a few months, silver skyrocketed, and then suddenly crashed, at least compared to the heights. During these four phases, there was only one short phase of six months, when the decisions of the small Indian investors, and large global institutions, coincided.

What this implies is that while the institutions sold, the retailers purchased, and vice versa. In other words, when the institutions booked profits, and scattered away from the silver market, the small investors entered in droves, and vice versa. This is the story of divergent behaviour when it comes to silver-based ETFs (exchange-traded funds). One cannot say for sure but, according to the Vallum report, the hints are that the small investors lost, and institutions gained. We are not so sure. We feel that on

several occasions, the small buyers did better. Let us analyse the four phases for a considered conclusion.

Phase 1 (January 2022-February 2025): Global silver prices roamed around in a sort of a band, as they moved between \$24 and \$32. As gold zoomed, and went on doing so after the pandemic, silver's journey was more measured. Still, the savvy (large) investors entered ETFs in early 2020, or immediately after Covid, at a price of \$14, saw the price rise to \$50 in October 2024, and then settle down lower. For them, it was time to book profits. After all, what was on the table was 3.5x returns if they sold at the interim peak, or 2.5x if they sold around \$35.

According to the Vallum report, quoted in the media, "Global institutional investors steadily reduced their exposure to silver ETFs, or made a structural exit. During this nearly-three-year-period, global funds withdrew \$4 billion, with average outflows of \$100 million per month." Hence, they booked profits, possibly at the regular highs during the period, before the prices dropped, and then gained again. Possibly, they were unsure if the silver would ever touch the past peak of \$50 that it achieved in October 2024. It was the experts' opinion that silver had petered out, at least in the immediate future.

"In contrast, Indian retail investors gradually increased their exposure to silver. During the same period, domestic investors invested... (more than \$1.5 billion) into silver ETFs, averaging... (\$40 million) per month in inflows. In rupee terms, the net inflows were Rs 13,306.8 crore with a monthly average flow of Rs 350.2 crore. In

simple terms, while global investors were exiting the asset class, domestic investors were beginning to accumulate positions," states a media report. In other words, the buying of retail investors lagged the institutions. The former walked in late, even as the price corrected from \$50 to \$32.

Phase 2 (March-August 2025): During these six months, both sets of investors were on the same page. They were both net buyers. Global funds pumped in nearly \$5 billion. Indian retail investors pushed more than \$200 million a month, or more than \$1 billion. "The report shows that both camps were bullish, both were buying, and the trade was working..." stated a media report. It is here that the narrative changes, as per Vallum analysis, and as per commonsense and counter-logic. The former states that the global buyers had a plan. They knew, or were possibly aware that the next bullish phase, even bigger or as big as the first one, was around the corner. The Indians bought blindly.

We are not so sure. The fact remains that by the immediate past experiences, silver prices had crashed by more than a third from \$50 to \$32. During the six months under this phase, the prices climbed up gingerly, slowly, and incrementally to \$39. Hence, there was no sense in dramatic buying unless one knew or was confident that prices would go up further. If the two sets did not, they were buying foolishly. If they did, it was one of the smartest moves by both. Hence, to say that the Indians were less smart would go against the grain.

Phase 3 (September 2025-January 2026): In these five months, silver prices almost trebled, from \$42.5 to \$120. Obviously, the global investors booked profits, as they had in the first phase, with potential returns of up to 3x. "They sold... (\$3.5 billion) worth of silver ETFs, taking advantage of the surge in prices," explains a media report. But the Indians kept on buying. They were on a momentum spree. The FOMO factor kicked in, and one of retail investors wanted to be left behind, as they were during the first phase, if they had bought silver in March 2020. In five months, they pumped \$4.6 billion.

Of course, this does make the Indian small investors look like a herd, who walked in aggressively even as the silver prices peaked, reached its second high, and ended the second huge rally. But such a narrative assumes that the buyers were the same as the ones who purchased during the second phase. Maybe the third phase distinguishes between the smart Indians, and herd Indians. The former bought silver during the second phase, and sold in the third one. The latter missed the first two phases, and entered the market only during the third phase.

Phase 4 (February 2026): As silver corrected sharply to \$80 or so, Indians sold after waking up from the FOMO sleep, coma, and paralysis. The global traders entered afresh, and invested \$1.8 billion in February 2026. The jury is still out on who is or was smarter, as silver did rally briefly to \$94, and fell back to below \$80 in March 2026.

A Contrarian Investor

Crude and mysterious oil story

In India, retail prices of petroproducts go up but rarely come down

During the present crisis, petrol and diesel prices remain stable, and that of household LPG was hiked incrementally. It is the commercial users, like restaurants, who need to pay a much higher amount per cylinder. Thus, the losses incurred by the oil firms when the global crude prices are high, are subsidised by the super profits they earn when the latter are down. In the interim, the Government supports the firms through funds.

But according to some experts, this mindset creates a distortion in the local oil markets. Since the benefits of the lower global crude prices do not reach the Indian consumers, and oil firms earn windfall profits, there is a redistribution of wealth. A large chunk of these profits is indeed appropriated by the

Government in the form of taxes, which remain unusually high. Of course, the oil ministry uses a part of these funds during the bad days, when global crude prices are high, to partly compensate the oil firms to stabilise the local retail prices. At present, the marketing firms pay less-than-global rates to refiners.

Let us take the example of the Russia-Ukraine war, which enabled India to source a third of its crude oil imports from Russia at discounted prices, almost \$10-15 a barrel lower. "For the Indian refiners, the discounts created a powerful arbitrage opportunity. For policy-makers, they offered fiscal breathing room.... But for the ordinary consumers, the benefits were less visible. Retail fuel prices remained largely stable.... LPG... remains a sig-

nificant household expense," states a media analysis. The money was used by the Government to fund subsidies, cash transfers, and welfare schemes.

Of course, the opposite happened after the beginning of the Iran war. The local retail prices of petrol and diesel remained stable, essentially the same, despite a massive hike in global crude prices, and that of household LPG was increased by ₹60 per cylinder to just over ₹900, or just under seven per cent. The oil ministry announced that it would pass on funds to the oil firms to make up for the current losses due to lower retail prices. The former allows the firms to make money when crude is low, and partially absorb the losses when it is up.

Hence, over the past few years, India's oil bounty due to the Russia-Ukraine war was increasingly used by the Centre and states to finance grander and more impressive welfare schemes, which included cash doles. They were timed before the elections to woo voters. In a sense, one can assume that this was a way to redistribute wealth, from the refiners to the state, and from the state to the poor, at the expense of the rich and middle class, which owns the cars, and uses LPG. The implications were economic, even if the intentions were political.

On the positive side, oil acts as a socio-economic cushion, rather a valve to let out the steam that is accumulated at the mass level due to declining or plateauing incomes, price rises, less jobs, and dented aspirations. The money that is made by the refiners and the state when global crude prices are low, and retail prices of petroproducts remain high, is redistributed, and reduces inequality even if the motive is to garner votes, and win elections. Left-leaning economists may dub it the duty of the Government. Right-bending ones may see it as a nuisance.

On the negative side, the cash doles and welfare schemes may indicate the money that is not spent on roads, ports, airports, health-care, and education. More importantly, the fiscal cushion of lower global crude prices is available temporarily. It vanishes at regular intervals. But possibly, the governments have realised that the benefits far exceed the disadvantages. More money is made than is lost. In any case, it is the refiners who bear the brunt during a crisis, not the state.

OUR TAKE

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PIOTECH

Data centres power demand to hit 13.56 GW by 2031-32



Electricity demand from data centres in the country is expected to reach 13.56 gigawatt by 2031-32, Parliament was informed on Friday. In a written reply to the Rajya Sabha, Minister of State for Electronics and IT, Jitin Prasada said the total data centre capacity in the country increased from 375 megawatt (MW) in 2020 to around 1,500 MW by 2025. “The expected electricity demand from the growth of AI and other large-scale data centres is factored into the planning process of the Government. As per information available with Ministry of Power, electricity demand from data centres is estimated to reach 13.56 GW by 2031-32,” Prasada said. The minister said about 38,231 Graphics Processing Units (GPUs) have been onboarded through 14 empanelled service providers and data centres under the AI compute capacity framework to support AI development. “These are being provided to startups, researchers, academia and other eligible users at a subsidised average rate of ₹65 per hour. This is about one-third of the global average cost. These data centres are located across the country such as Mumbai, Navi Mumbai, Hyderabad, Bengaluru, Noida and Jamnagar,” Prasada said.

Reliance Digital launches campaign for Apple devices



Reliance Digital, India's leading consumer electronics retailer, has announced the launch of Apple's latest range of devices across its nationwide store network and online platform, inviting customers to be among the first to experience the brand's newest innovations through its 'Take The First Bite' campaign. The newly launched iPhone 17e is now available starting at ₹64,900, with EMIs starting at ₹3,606 per month, along with instant cashback of up to ₹3,000 on Axis Bank and ICICI Bank credit cards and additional exchange bonuses on select devices. Apple's computing portfolio also sees significant upgrades with the launch of the MacBook Air powered by the next-generation M5 chip, available at an effective starting price of ₹1,12,900 including ₹7,000 instant cashback. Customers can also get exchange bonuses of up to ₹10,000, along with a special Student & Teacher Offer of ₹7,000. The newly introduced MacBook Neo, designed as a powerful entry into the Apple laptop ecosystem, starts at an effective price of ₹65,900, with cashback of up to ₹4,000, exchange bonuses of up to ₹6,000, and a Student-Teacher Offer of ₹4,000. For professionals and creators, the MacBook Pro continues to deliver Apple's flagship performance, available at an effective starting price of ₹1,84,900, along with cashback benefits and a Student-Teacher Offer of ₹11,000. Completing the line-up is the new iPad Air powered by the M4 chip, offering enhanced performance and efficiency in a sleek, lightweight design. Through the 'Take The First Bite' campaign, Reliance Digital aims to build excitement around Apple's newest innovations and encourage customers to experience the latest devices first at Reliance Digital stores.

Truecaller rolls out family protection to guard elders



As online scams like digital arrests, impersonation fraud and AI voice cloning evolve into direct threats against the security of Indian households, Truecaller, the leading global communications platform, is shifting the narrative from simple identification to proactive family immunity with the launch of Family Protection in India. This follows its successful rollout in several global markets, including Sweden, Chile, Malaysia and Kenya. Truecaller's Family Protection is a sophisticated digital shield, designed to protect the entire household from the rapidly evolving landscape of predatory scams. Every family has a tech-aware individual or CTO (chief technology officer) who manages the digital well-being of their parents, elders and children. Family Protection gives the CTO real-time fraud alerts and a remote call hang-up feature, allowing them to end suspicious calls for any member of the group instantly. It also includes shared block lists, customizable security levels and a dashboard to monitor device safety settings, ensuring seamless protection across both Android and iOS devices. Importantly, Family Protection is free to use, allowing people to begin safeguarding their family members immediately. “Identifying who is calling is a 2010 solution. In 2026, the question is if the call is safe to answer,” said Rishit Jhunjhunwala, CEO, Truecaller. “With scams becoming more personalized and emotionally manipulative, we need a collective defense. By launching Family Protection in India, we are giving the most tech-savvy member of the household the tools to become the digital guardian for their loved ones, ensuring that the entire family is covered by the same high standards of security that our users enjoy.” While Family Protection is free, if the CTO/admin opts for the Premium Family Plan subscription, they gain access to a broader suite of advanced safety features designed to deliver comprehensive protection for every member of the group.

While India builds data centres, China is building data markets

Behind China’s new data exchanges lies a bigger idea – treating information as the fuel of the AI economy.



NISHANT SAHDEV

While Washington debates how artificial intelligence may influence the next phase of warfare, and New Delhi focuses on attracting global technology investment, Beijing is building that may sound almost dull: data exchanges.

In cities such as Shanghai and Shenzhen, marketplaces are growing where companies, universities and Government agencies can buy and sell datasets. Industrial production records, logistics flows, medical images and transport patterns are all becoming tradable assets. Though officials describe these platforms as part of China's digital economy strategy. Analysts estimate that the country's data economy could exceed \$1 trillion before the end of the decade.

On the surface, it looks bureaucratic — the sort of institutional machinery China often creates when it wants to organise a sector at scale. But look closer and the logic begins to reveal itself. Artificial intelligence runs on information much the way the industrial age ran on coal and oil. China appears to be building the infrastructure to treat data as a national resource for machine intelligence. Over the past two years, more than 20 Government-backed data exchanges have opened across Chinese cities. The Shanghai Data Exchange alone lists hundreds of tradable datasets, ranging from logistics flows and industrial production records to medical imaging and urban transport patterns.

Chinese officials estimate the country's data market could reach 60 trillion yuan (about \$8 trillion) by 2030, according to projections tied to the national digital-economy strategy. Independent analysts are more cautious, but many still place the value of China's data economy at over \$1 trillion before the decade ends. And this is where much of the global conversation about artificial intelligence begins in the wrong place.

Behind every impressive AI system sit three basic ingredients: advanced chips, specialised talent and vast quantities of structured data. Remove any one of these and the system weakens. Right now, the United States dominates the first two. American companies design the processors that power



modern AI systems. Silicon Valley still attracts much of the world's top AI talent and investment. Washington has also begun to defend that position aggressively.

In recent years the US Government has imposed export controls on advanced semiconductor technologies, restricting China's access to some of the most powerful AI chips.

China, however, seems to be pursuing a different advantage. The country produces roughly 30 per cent of global manufacturing output, more than the United States, Japan and Germany combined. Its digital platforms process extraordinary volumes of commercial activity. During major online shopping festivals, Chinese e-commerce companies can handle billions of transactions in a single day.

Every transaction produces information — about consumer behaviour, supply chains, pricing and logistics. AI thrives on exactly this kind of data. Machine-learning systems do not “think” in the way humans do. They learn by detecting patterns across enormous datasets. The richer the data, the smarter the system becomes. Yet in most countries, this information remains scattered. It gets limited inside databases only.

China's emerging data exchanges are an attempt to change that. Instead of letting information remain fragmented, Beijing is experimenting with marketplaces where datasets can be standardised and traded. Companies can monetise

data products. Researchers can access information for machine-learning projects. Government agencies can verify and catalogue data before it enters the exchange.

Seen this way, the idea becomes clearer. China is trying to turn the everyday information generated



by its economy into training material for artificial intelligence. At a time when most countries ask how to build the smartest AI model.

China appears to be asking a different question: what happens if an entire economy becomes a training environment for AI? History suggests that this kind of systems thinking often matters more than individual inventions.

Britain pioneered many early developments in computing, yet it was the United States that ultimately built the modern computer industry. Germany produced remarkable rocket engineers during the Second World War, but it was the United States and the Soviet Union that turned rockets into space programmes.

The decisive advantage may not lie with the country that produces the smartest algorithm. It may lie with the country that builds the largest ecosystem capable of

absorbing and learning from intelligent machines. From that perspective, China's data exchanges start to look less like administrative tools and more like infrastructure for intelligence.

The United States continues to dominate frontier research and semiconductor design.

China is exploring ways to convert its industrial scale and digital activity into a continuous learning resource for AI systems.

Both approaches reflect the same underlying recognition: artificial intelligence is no longer just a technology sector. It is becoming part of the architecture of national power.

For India, it raises an obvious question

For India, the more interesting question is not whether the country has enough data for artificial intelligence. It almost certainly does. India has become one of the largest generators of digital activity in the world. The Unified Payments Interface now processes more than 12 billion transactions every month, according to the National Payments Corporation of India, moving values that frequently exceed ₹18 trillion. Aadhaar covers over 1.3 billion people, making it the largest biometric identity system ever built. Internet access has crossed 850 million users, creating one of the largest connected populations on the planet. Taken together, these systems generate something unusual: a constantly updating digital record of how a billion-

person economy actually behaves.

Many advanced digital economies are built around private data ecosystems. In the United States, vast amounts of behavioural data sit inside large technology firms such as Google, Amazon and Meta. In Europe, strong privacy frameworks like the GDPR protect citizens but also make large-scale data sharing across institutions slow and complicated. China, by contrast, has moved toward a more centralised model, experimenting with Government-backed data exchanges that allow datasets to be standardised and traded across industries.

India sits somewhere between these models. Rather than relying purely on corporations or centralised state systems, India built much of its digital foundation as public infrastructure. Aadhaar provides identity, UPI enables real-time payments, and the broader India Stack allows banks, startups and Government services to operate on shared digital rails.

In effect, India has created something resembling a national digital nervous system. Every digital payment, subsidy transfer, logistics transaction or online service leaves behind structured information about economic activity. Yet much of this information still remains locked inside institutional silos. Banks hold financial transaction histories. Hospitals store medical records. Telecom firms manage communication data. Government databases track agriculture, welfare and infrastructure systems. Very little of this data circulates in ways that allow artificial intelligence systems to learn from it.

This is India's real AI challenge. Not producing data, but organising it intelligently. Unlike China's centralised system, India must design ways for data to move across sectors while preserving privacy, consent and democratic accountability. If it succeeds, the result could be something rare: a trusted data ecosystem where public infrastructure allows innovation without concentrating power entirely in either the state or large corporations. Artificial intelligence ultimately learns from how societies organise their information. The countries that solve that institutional puzzle most effectively will build the technological landscape of the twenty-first century.

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The new digital panopticon: How the pentagon-anthropic dispute threatens privacy and global stability



ASISH GUPTA

Historically, Silicon Valley or the American technology valley has been known as a progressive and liberal place, but in 2026, it has developed a clear and deep political polarisation. This conflict between the Pentagon and Anthropic has given birth to two powerful camps in Silicon Valley, which could change the trajectory of future innovation. In 2026, wherever war is occurring in the world — whether in Iran or Ukraine — Artificial Intelligence (AI) is playing a role in one way or another.

The United States used this technology while arresting Venezuelan leader Nicolás Maduro and his wife, and Israel also took its help during the war in Gaza. In fact, this use of AI on the battlefield is only the beginning. In this context, the dispute that has arisen between the Trump administration and America's leading AI company 'Anthropic' has become extremely significant for future warfare tactics and world politics. Anthropic is currently one of the world's leading AI institutions, whose 'Claude' model has been widely used by the Pentagon for intelligence gathering, target identification, and mapping military operations. However, this recent fight is not about current use, but rather about how this technology might be used in the future.

There were two main conditions in Anthropic's contract. First, their technology could not be used for surveillance of US citizens. Second, Claude could not be used to create autonomous lethal weapons capable of making decisions without direct human involvement. The Pentagon objected to these conditions. Although the Ministry of Defense claimed they were not interested in domestic surveillance or creating autonomous killer robots, they were unwilling to allow a private company the opportunity to impose conditions on the military's usage.

This stalemate eventually turned into a legal dispute and a cultural war, fueling fears about AI and concerns over America's capability in the global race for AI dominance.



Ultimately, when negotiations failed, President Trump ordered all federal agencies to stop using Anthropic, and the Pentagon identified it as a 'supply-chain risk to national security.'

Currently, the presence of AI on the battlefield is not a theoretical matter; it has become fully integrated. Although large language models are not yet directly operating drones or giving orders to fire, they are deeply rooted in intelligence analysis and strategic decision-making. Anthropic's primary fear was that the Government could use their AI to analyse the commercial data of US citizens — such as web browsing history or telephone metadata — to track their movements and preferences.

Additionally, the issue of autonomous drones is a cause for concern. The United States always claims that there will be human participation or 'human in the loop' in decisions to use lethal weapons. However, in the field of war, the side that can make decisions faster wins, and human intervention can slow down that process. In this reality, exactly what the human role will be in future wars is still unclear, making it difficult to create advance policies for AI use.

The Pentagon's argument is that the tradi-

tional laws of war should be sufficient for the use of AI, because whether dropping a bomb or determining a target through software, the ethical principles of war remain the same. In contrast, Anthropic believes AI is not like all other weapons. The limitations of a fighter jet or a bomb depend on its hardware, but AI constantly evolves. It can analyse data, suggest

bombings, or design cyber attacks. It is a special technology that requires special safeguards. This fight is not just about policy, but also about branding. Anthropic wants to establish itself as a responsible and safety-conscious company, while the Pentagon and the Trump administration view this as a reflection of 'Woke' or over-cautious ideology and are taking a harsh stance against them.

This conflict between the Pentagon and Anthropic is not just the cancellation of a business deal, but it clarifies a conflict on three deep levels regarding the future control of AI technology and the ethics of war. At the center of this debate is the 'Lethal Autonomous Weapon System' (LAWS). Even though the Pentagon theoretically talks about maintaining a 'human-in-the-loop' (meaning a human presence in the final decision), the speed of modern warfare or 'speed of fight' has

increased so much that the human brain is incapable of making decisions at that speed. Anthropic fears that their AI model could be used at a stage where the algorithm itself determines who to kill. This could turn the battlefield into a battle of mathematics or coding, where there will be no place for human empathy or judgment. A clash of two different philosophies is happening here. Anthropic and its CEO Dario Amodei believe that AI is a 'special' technology that could be a threat to the existence of mankind if it falls into the wrong hands or is used in an unplanned way. To them, AI 'safety guardrails' are an ideological foundation. On the other hand, to the Pentagon's Chief Technology Officer Emil Michael and Secretary of Defense Pete Hegseth, national security is paramount. Their argument is that if American AI companies give conditions to the Pentagon, it will set the United States back in the competition against China.

According to them, no private software company can determine the Government's defense policy. While Anthropic is firm in its principled position, Sam Altman's OpenAI has played a very strategic role. By quickly signing a deal with the Pentagon, they have proven they are ready to be the Government's 'friendly' partner. However, this raises a big question: will OpenAI's own 'safety principles' surrender to military needs? If the Pentagon plans to use large language models (LLM) for cyber attacks or direct drone operations in the future, experts have doubts about how much OpenAI will be able to resist.

One of Anthropic's biggest objections was regarding surveillance of US citizens. Current AI models are capable of finding specific patterns by analyzing the data of billions of people in an instant. If the Pentagon gets the opportunity to analyse commercial data (such as location history or shopping lists) with AI, it will be an unprecedented blow to the personal privacy of ordinary citizens. Human rights activists believe this could practically create a 'digital panopticon' or an all-encompassing surveillance system, which could be contrary to the Fourth Amendment of the US Constitution.

Author is a senior journalist based in north-east India

Please read the complete article online at dailypioneer.com

FROM THE WORLD

TURKIYE

Fidan pushes for talks

Turkey's powerful foreign minister said on Saturday that there is no serious initiative to resume negotiations between the United States and Iran but that he believes Iran is open to back-channel talks. The comments by Foreign Minister Hakan Fidan to The Associated Press in an exclusive interview came as Ankara is striving to stay out of the widening war in the Middle East. Ankara, which has good relations with both Washington and Tehran, had attempted to mediate a solution between them before the US and Israel attacked Iran two weeks ago, triggering the war. "The conditions are not very much conducive" to diplomacy now, Fidan said. The Iranians "feel betrayed" because for a second time they were attacked while in active negotiations with the US over their nuclear programme, he said.

RWANDA

Threatens to withdraw troops

Rwanda will withdraw its counterinsurgency troops from Mozambique if the mission's foreign backers don't maintain "sustainable funding," the foreign minister said. Foreign Affairs Minister Olivier Nduhungirehe said in a post on X that Rwandan troops were "being constantly questioned, vilified, criticised, blamed or sanctioned by the very countries that benefit from our intervention in Mozambique." Nduhungirehe said: "It's not that "Rwanda could withdraw." "It's that "Rwanda will withdraw" its troops from Mozambique, if sustainable funding is not secured for its counter-terrorism operations in Cabo Delgado," he said, referring to Mozambique. Last week, the US State Department imposed visa restrictions on "several senior Rwandan officials for fuelling instability" in eastern Congo, intensifying after sanctions that targeted Rwanda's military.

West Asia conflict: 19 Indians held for spreading fake news

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Dubai

The UAE on Sunday ordered the arrest of 35 individuals, including 19 Indians, for publishing video clips on social media platforms that contained misleading and fabricated content amid regional tensions due to the Israel-US-Iran war.

The United Arab Emirates' (UAE) official news agency Wam said the accused have been referred for an expedited trial. The latest list has 25 individuals of various nationalities, including 17 Indians, listed under different sections, separate from the 10 people, including two Indians, who were named and ordered to be arrested on

Saturday. According to a statement released by the Attorney-General Dr Hamad Saif Al Shams, the move follows rigorous monitoring of digital platforms to combat the spread of fabricated information and artificial content intended to incite public disorder and undermine general stability.

"Investigations and electronic monitoring revealed that the defendants were divided into three groups that committed various acts. These included the publication of real clips related to current events, the fabrication of clips using AI, and the promotion of a state practising acts of military aggression while glorifying its leadership and military actions," it said.



Cargo ship is seen leaving the Dubai port, United Arab Emirates

The first group of 10 accused published and circulated authentic video clips documenting the passage and interception of missiles on

the country's airspace or the resulting impact. They also filmed gatherings of individuals monitoring these events, appending commentary and

sound effects suggesting active aggressions to incite public anxiety and panic.

Such footage risked exposing defensive capabilities and

allowing hostile accounts to promote misleading narratives, the statement said.

This group comprised five Indians, one Pakistani, one Nepali, two Filipinos, and one Egyptian. The second group published fabricated visual content created through AI or recirculated footage of incidents from outside the country while falsely claiming they occurred within it. These clips contained synthetic scenes of explosions and missiles, often featuring national flags or specific dates to grant credibility to false claims and mislead the public, it said.

This group, comprising seven individuals, includes five Indians and one each from Nepal and Bangladesh.

Two other individuals, both Indians, also face charges for similar offences, the statement said. Earlier on Saturday, a Wam report quoted Attorney-General Shamsi as saying that the public prosecution has commenced interrogating the 10 defendants and ordered their remand in custody. The attorney-general explained that such acts constitute crimes punishable under the law by imprisonment for a period of no less than one year and a fine of no less than AED 1,00,000. "Such events have been exploited to disseminate misinformation intended to deliberately mislead the public while undermining national security, order and stability," he said.

Israeli airstrike kills 12 Palestinians in Gaza

SAMY MAGDY
Cairo

At least 12 Palestinians, including a boy and his pregnant mother, were killed Sunday by an Israeli airstrike in the war-torn Gaza Strip, hospital authorities said.

The strike hit a house in Nuseirat, an urban refugee camp in central Gaza, killing a couple and their young son, according to the nearby Al-Aqsa Martyrs Hospital. The fourth fatality was taken to the Awda hospital in Nuseirat.

There was no immediate comment from the Israeli military. The deaths were the latest fatalities among Palestinians in the coastal enclave since an October ceasefire deal attempted to



halt a more than 2-year war between Israel and Hamas in Gaza.

While the heaviest fighting has subsided, the ceasefire has still seen almost daily Israeli fire. Israeli forces have carried out repeated air strikes and frequently fire on Palestinians near mili-

tary-held zones, killing more than 650 Palestinians, according to Gaza health officials.

Israel says it has responded to violations of the ceasefire or targeted wanted militants. But about half of those killed have been women and children, according to the Gaza Health Ministry. They

were among more than 72,200 Palestinians killed in the war which was triggered when Hamas-led militants attacked southern Israel on October 7, 2023. The militant attack killed over 1,200 people and took over 250 others hostage.

The health ministry, which is part of the Hamas-led Government, maintains detailed casualty records that are seen as generally reliable by UN agencies and independent experts. But it does not give a breakdown of civilians and militants. Militants have carried out shooting attacks on troops, and Israel says its strikes are in response to that and other violations. Four Israeli soldiers have been killed since the ceasefire. (AP)

Pope calls for ceasefire in Iran by addressing those responsible for war

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Rome

Pope Leo XIV demanded a ceasefire in the Middle East on Sunday in his strongest comments to date, directly addressing the leaders who launched the war in Iran.

"On behalf of the Christians of the Middle East and all women and men of good will, I appeal to those responsible for this conflict," Leo said. "Cease fire so that avenues for dialogue may be reopened. Violence can never lead to the justice, stability, and peace that the people are waiting for."

Leo didn't cite the United States or Israel by name in his comments at the end of his Sunday noon blessing. But history's first US pope mentioned the attacks that targeted a school, an apparent reference to the missile strike on an elementary school in Iran in the opening



days of the war that killed over 165 people, many of them children.

US officials have said outdated intelligence likely led to the United States launching the strike, and that an investigation is ongoing.

The Vatican has highlighted the carnage of the Minab strike, running an aerial photo of the mass grave being dug for the young victims on the March 6 front page of its official newspaper,

L'Osservatore Romano, under the headline "The Face of War".

Leo said he was close to the families of those who had been killed in the attacks "which have hit schools, hospitals and residential centres". He expressed particular concern about the impact of the war in Lebanon, where aid groups are warning of a humanitarian crisis.

The plight of Christian communities in southern Lebanon is of particular concern to the Vatican, since they have long represented a bulwark for Christians throughout the majority Muslim region. For the two weeks since the start of the US-Israeli war, the pope has limited his comments to muted appeals for diplomacy and dialogue in an apparent attempt to avoid pitting himself as an American political counterweight to President Donald Trump.

Gunman ambush kills 20 security personnel in Nigeria



ASSOCIATED PRESS
Abuja

Gunmen ambushed and killed security personnel who were on patrol in communities in Nigeria's Plateau state, according to the state government. The government did not specify the number of casualties, but the Kanam Development Association (KADA), a local group, claimed 20 personnel, including two senior military officers and eight local security operatives, were killed in the ambush.

The ambush happened on Friday around Wanka, Kyaram and Gyambau communities located in the Kanam area of Plateau state. No group has claimed responsibility for the attacks.

The state government on Sunday condemned the attack and said the security agencies are implementing measures to intensify surveillance and reinforce security presence across vulnerable communities. "For over three to four years, these

communities have been subjected to repeated attacks, cattle rustling, kidnappings, and destruction of property by armed bandits who appear to operate with alarming freedom," KADA said in a statement on Saturday.

For years, Nigeria has been battling a complex security crisis from different armed groups, especially in the northern part of the country. Among the most prominent Islamic militant groups are Boko Haram and its break-away faction, which is affiliated with the Islamic State group and known as Islamic State West Africa Province. There is also the IS-linked Lakurawa, as well as other armed groups that specialise in kidnapping for ransom and illegal mining.

The crisis has worsened recently to include other militants from the neighbouring Sahel region, including the Jama'at Nusrat al-Islam wal-Muslimin, which claimed its first attack on Nigerian soil last year.

Thousands of people protested against wars in the West Asia

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Rome

Thousands of people protested against wars in the West Asia and judicial reforms proposed by Italy's conservative Government - linking international tensions with a growing domestic political battle before a national referendum.

The March 22-23 referendum on changes to the judicial system has become a major political test for Prime Minister Giorgia Meloni's Government, which faces an election next year. The debate over legal reforms has escalated into a broader confrontation between the



prime minister and her political opponents. In central Rome, protesters waving red trade union banners and Palestinian and Cuban flags chanted "Meloni Government, resign" before the rally ended peacefully.

"The United States and Israel are destroying any form of coexistence dictated by international law," demonstrator Sandra

Paganini said. "They are dragging us towards a world war in which they are targeting completely innocent people who have done nothing wrong, intervening and destroying nations," she said.

Meloni said that the reforms are needed to tackle chronic delays in Italy's courts and restore public confidence in the legal system. But opponents argue that the changes could weaken judicial independence and make judges subject to political influence. The referendum has increasingly taken on the character of a political test for the prime minister.

We need to recognise we have problem with Security Council: Guterres

YOSHITA SINGH
United Nations

In a sharp critique, UN chief Antonio Guterres said there is a need to recognise "we have a problem with the Security Council", which does not reflect the current world and is not allowed to stop conflicts because of the use of veto by its permanent members.

"I think we need to recognise that we have a problem with the Security Council. The Security Council today no longer represents the world as the world exists. It represents the world after 1945," Guterres said at a press conference in Beirut on Saturday in response to a question. He pointed out that three permanent members of the 15-nation Council are from



Europe, one from Asia, and one is the United States, while there are no permanent members from Africa or Latin America.

Even from Asia, that "obviously

is a continent with an enormous weight in global population and global wealth", there is just one permanent member - China.

"And so, the Council has a

Six terrorists killed in joint security operation in Pakistan

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Peshawar

Six terrorists were killed in an intelligence-based operation in the restive Khyber Pakhtunkhwa province in northwest Pakistan, police said Sunday.

The joint intelligence-based operation (IBO) was carried out by the Counter Terrorism Department (CTD) and the Kohat district police department after receiving intel regarding the terrorists, said Kohat District Police Officer (DPO) Shahbaz Elahi.

The operation started late on Saturday and continued till early hours on Sunday, Elahi said in a statement, adding, the terrorists were planning to orchestrate a large-scale attack in Lachi tehsil of the district. Subsequently, a large contingent of CTD personnel and police launched a search and strike operation.

Six terrorists were killed in a heavy exchange of fire after the suspects opened



fire on the police team, the statement said.

Arms and ammunition were recovered from the slain terrorists, Kohat DPO said, adding that a search operation was launched in the area after it was cordoned off. In another incident, unidentified armed militants attacked the Khutti police checkpoint in the Dera Ismail Khan district of the province late on Saturday night, resulting in heavy exchange of fire that injured a police constable.

problem of legitimacy and a problem of efficiency because of the vetoes. And what we have witnessed is that time and time again, when we have situations of conflict and when it's necessary to stop the conflict, there is a veto that emerges, and that does not allow the Security Council to act.

That, unfortunately, is something that we are witnessing time and time again, and I am not hoping that in the short term, things will change," he said. The Council is made up of five veto-wielding permanent members, China, France, Russia, the UK and the US, while 10 non-permanent members are elected to serve two-year terms at the horseshoe table and do not have veto powers. India has been at the forefront of

decades-long efforts calling for reform of the Security Council, including expansion in both its permanent and non-permanent categories, saying the 15-nation Council, founded in 1945, is not fit for purpose in the 21st Century and does not reflect contemporary geopolitical realities.

India has underscored that it rightly deserves to sit as a permanent member in the Security Council. India last sat at the UN high table as a non-permanent member in 2021-22. A polarised Security Council has failed to deal with current peace and security challenges, with Council members sharply divided on conflicts such as the Ukraine war, the Israel-Hamas conflict and the latest US-Israel war against Iran. (PTI)

Ukraine waiting for US-Russia talks: Zelenskyy

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Kyiv

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said in comments released on Sunday that he was ready for the next round of trilateral peace talks to end Russia's more than 4-year-old invasion of Ukraine, but that it was up to Washington and Moscow to agree on where and when to meet.

Zelenskyy said the U.S. had proposed hosting the next meeting between American, Ukrainian and Russian negotiating teams, which include US envoys Steve Witkoff and Jared Kushner, but Moscow had refused to send a delegation. "We are waiting for a response from the

Americans. Either they will change the country where we meet, or the Russians must confirm the U.S.," Zelenskyy said in a media briefing on Saturday. "We are not blocking any of these initiatives. We want a trilateral meeting to take place."

The US has postponed its sponsored talks between the two sides due to the war in the west East. The Iran war, which erupted on Feb. 28 following US-Israeli strikes on Iran and spread across the region, has drawn the international spotlight away from Ukraine's plight as it strives to hold back Russia's bigger army. Speaking to journalists, Zelenskyy also warned of a "very high" risk that the Iran war could drain the air defense stockpiles Ukraine



depends on to counter Russian missile strikes.

Zelenskyy said he lacked a clear picture of available stockpiles and had discussed with French President Emmanuel Macron in Paris on Friday whether SAMP/T systems could serve as an

alternative to US-made Patriot batteries for intercepting ballistic missiles. He said Ukraine would be "first in line" to test any viable alternative.

He also appeared to push back against U.S. President Donald Trump's recent asser-

tion that Washington has no need for Ukrainian drone technology. "No, we don't need their help on drone defense," Trump said in a Fox News Radio interview that aired on Friday.

Zelenskyy said Washington had reached out to Ukraine "several times" to request assistance for a particular country or for support for Americans, without giving specifics. He said the requests had come from various US military institutions to Ukraine's Ministry of Defense and other military leaders. "All our institutions received these requests, and we responded to them," Zelenskyy said.

He said he had offered Washington a defense cooperation deal last year worth

\$35 billion-\$50 billion that would have given the U.S. administration access to technology from roughly 200 Ukrainian drone, AI and electronic warfare firms, with half of all production earmarked for partners, primarily the US.

According to the Ukrainian leader, American military officials had expressed strong interest in the proposal, and Trump himself had indicated he was receptive.

"We received a message from them, and directly from the president as well, that they are interested," Zelenskyy told reporters. "We did not sign the document with President Trump. I do not have an answer as to why. Perhaps it will happen later, but I am not sure."

French voters head to municipal polls



ASSOCIATED PRESS
Paris

Voters are going to the polls Sunday in the first round of municipal elections to choose leadership teams across France, from small villages to the biggest cities - a test for political parties' electoral machines before next year's presidential election for the successor to President Emmanuel Macron. Although largely focused on grassroots concerns, the voting will be scrutinized for any early hints of how parties might fare in the presidential race of 2027, when Macron's second and last term as president ends. The second round is on March 22. Attention is particularly focused on key races in major cities, including Paris. Incumbent Socialist Mayor Anne Hidalgo, elected in

2014 and reelected in 2020, decided against seeking a third term, having steered the French capital through the trauma of extremist attacks in 2015 and the exuberance of the Paris Olympics in 2024. In Marseille, France's second-largest city, polls pointed to a tight race between incumbent left-wing Mayor Benoit Payan and the candidate of the far-right National Rally party, Franck Allisio, and his would-be municipal team. The National Rally's performances in municipal races will be studied for possible indications of whether the party of Marine Le Pen is gathering momentum in the lead-up to 2027, despite the possibility that she might be barred from challenging again for the presidency herself.

7 Indian pilgrims killed in Nepal bus accident



ASSOCIATED PRESS
Kathmandu

A passenger bus carrying Indian pilgrims slipped off a mountain road and rolled down its slopes in central Nepal, killing seven people and leaving nine more injured, police said on Sunday. All seven killed were Indian pilgrims, and seven other Indian pilgrims on board were injured and taken to nearby hospitals to get medical treatment.

The other two injured in the crash, which happened Saturday night, were the Nepali bus driver and his assistant. The bus was returning after the pilgrims visited the revered Manakamana Temple, a popular Hindu temple where devotees believe a goddess will grant them their wish if they visit the shrine. The accident

occurred on a path leading from the highway to the temple near Shahid Lakhani village, located about 120 kilometers (75 miles) west of the capital, Kathmandu.

The bus was going downhill when it slipped off a curve and rolled down the mountainside about 150 meters (500 feet) before landing in a ravine. Police and villagers who reached the wreckage pulled out the injured and helped transport them in ambulances to local hospitals for treatment. Autopsies will be performed on the bodies of those who died before they are released to family members, police said.

Bus accidents in Nepal are common, mostly due to poorly maintained roads and vehicles. Much of the Himalayan country is covered by mountains and connected only by narrow roads.

28 Ukrainian drones attempting to attack Moscow, claims Russia

VINAY SHUKLA
Moscow

Russian air defence units have destroyed 28 Ukrainian drones heading to attack the Capital on Sunday, Moscow Mayor Sergei Sobyenin claimed.

This is a second consecutive day that Russia claimed to have shot down 16 Ukrainian drones heading to attack Moscow.

By noon on Sunday, Russian air defence units had destroyed 28 Ukrainian drones heading to attack the capital for the second day, Sobyenin said in his



Firefighters put out the fire at a residential neighborhood damaged by Russian aerial guided bomb in Zaporizhzhia, Ukraine

social media post. The mayor, however, did not give any details of damage or casualties on the ground. Due to the waves of drone attacks, Vnukovo and Sheremetyevo international

airports in south-west and north-west of the capital had suspended operations, civil aviation agency Rosaviatsia announced. On Saturday too, three of the four local airports

located in the capital -- Vnukovo, Domodedovo and Zhukovsky -- had suspended their operations for several hours, disrupting air traffic.

According to the Russian Defence Ministry release on Saturday, 47 drones were destroyed as they approached Moscow.

Air defence systems on duty intercepted and destroyed 280 Ukrainian unmanned aerial vehicles flying over the Bryansk, Kaluga, Belgorod, Tver, Smolensk, and Kursk regions, the Krasnodar Territory, and the Moscow region, the ministry said. (PTI)

North Korean leader Kim observes test of rocket launch systems with his daughter

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Seoul

North Korean leader Kim Jong Un, accompanied by his teenage daughter, observed a live-fire test of multiple rocket launch systems, state media reported on Sunday, a likely response to ongoing US-South Korean military training that North Korea views as an invasion rehearsal.

The official Korean Central News Agency reported that Kim watched the strike drill involving twelve 600mm-calibre, ultraprecision rocket launchers off North Korea's east coast on Saturday. South



Kim Jong Un and his daughter attending a live-fire test of multiple rocket launch systems, at an undisclosed place in North Korea

Korea's military said Saturday it detected about 10 ballistic missiles fired from North Korea's Capital region

toward the eastern sea.

South Korea's national security council called the launches a provocation that

violated U.N. Security Council resolutions that bans any ballistic activities by North Korea.

KCNA cited Kim as saying that the drill would expose enemies within the 420-kilometer (260-mile) striking range, to "uneasiness" and give them "a deep understanding of the destructive power of tactical nuclear weapon," KCNA said. He apparently referred to South Korea and US troops stationed in South Korea.

"If this weapon is used, the opponent's military infrastructure within its striking range can never survive," Kim said, according to KCNA.

Kazakhstanis vote in referendum on new constitution

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Astana

Voters in Kazakhstan headed to the polls on Sunday for a referendum on a new constitution that would strengthen President Kassym-Jomart Tokayev's grip on power in Central Asia's largest country.

The proposal merges the Kazakhstani parliament's two chambers into one and gives the president the right to appoint all Government officials, including the restoration of the post of vice-president.

"The transition to a single-chamber parliament will not necessarily strengthen democracy, especially as the proposed amendments broadly expand presidential powers," Mario Bikarski,



Senior Eastern Europe and Central Asia Analyst at risk intelligence firm Verisk Maplecroft, told The Associated Press. "There is growing public demand for greater political accountability and justice, which

these reforms are unlikely to address." If the constitutional changes pass, a new body, the People's Council, will be created alongside parliament, empowered to initiate legislation and initiate referendums. Its members will be

appointed entirely by the president. This second constitutional change in four years was initiated by Tokayev. Analysts say they could pave the way for him to retain power after his term expires.

The 72-year-old Tokayev, a former Soviet official and Kazakhstani diplomat who previously served at the UN, is currently limited to one seven-year term until 2029. Analysts believe Tokayev could use the referendum to reset presidential term limits.

"If the transition of power doesn't go as Tokayev would like ... then he will be able to say that with the adoption of the new Constitution, we have reset presidential term limits," analyst Temur Umarov, a fellow at the

Carnegie Russia Eurasia Center, told The Associated Press. "The new constitution could provide Tokayev with a loophole for reelection to another term."

Leaders of several former Soviet republics, including Russia, Belarus, Uzbekistan, and Tajikistan, have previously used new or amended constitutions to revise statutory term limits.

The proposed new constitution also stipulates that marriage will no longer be a union of two people, but rather a union of a man and a woman. Analysts say this provision was introduced in the new constitution as a follow-up to a law banning what authorities view as "propaganda" of LGBTQ+ relations.

Congo votes for Sassou's fifth term

LOUIS OKAMBA
Brazzaville

The Republic of Congo is voting to elect a new leader on Sunday as incumbent President Dennis Sassou N'Guesso runs for a fifth consecutive term.

Three million people are registered to vote in the election, which has been marked by a lethargic mood among young people who expect Sassou N'Guesso to win again, and a call for a boycott by opposition parties. Polls are expected to close by 7 pm

Six other candidates are challenging Sassou N'Guesso to vie for the top job of the oil-rich Central



African country, which boasts one of the largest oil reserves in sub-Saharan Africa, but analysts say none of them can mount a significant challenge against the incumbent, who has been in power for 42 years.

The campaign showed a vast mismatch between Sassou and his opponents, with the incumbent being the only candidate to travel around the country to canvass for votes. (AP)

Large-scale Chinese military aircraft presence near island: Taiwan

KANIS LEUNG
Hong Kong

Taiwan saw a surge of Chinese military planes near the island, its defence ministry said on Sunday, after a sharp drop in flights over the past two weeks had sparked discussions among observers.

The ministry detected 26



Chinese military aircraft around the island on Saturday, with 16 of them entering its central and south-western Air Defence Identification Zone. Seven naval ships were spotted around the island, it reported. The increased number of aircraft came after the ministry reported a fall that left analysts scratching their heads about what China's military may be up to.

Taiwan didn't report any Chinese military planes that went beyond the median line and entered the zone for a week from Feb. 27 to March 5. After two were detected on March 6, the next four days had none. Such flights resumed in small numbers between Wednesday and Friday. (AP)

US-China trade talks open in Paris, paving the way for Trump-Xi summit

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Beijing

Representatives from Beijing and Washington began their economic and trade talks in Paris on Sunday, Chinese official news agency Xinhua reported.

The meetings, led by U.S. Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent and Chinese Vice Premier He Lifeng, are expected to pave the way for US President Donald Trump's state visit to Beijing to meet Chinese leader Xi Jinping in about two weeks. The White House has said that Trump will travel to China from March 31 to April 2, though Beijing has not officially confirmed it. Bessent said on

Thursday that his team will continue to deliver results that put America's farmers, workers and businesses first. China's commerce ministry said Friday the two sides are set to discuss "trade and economic issues of mutual concern."

Trump's visit to China will be the first for a US president since he went in his first term in 2017. It will come five months after the two leaders met in the South Korean city of Busan and agreed to a one-year truce in a trade war that temporarily saw tit-for-tat tariffs soar to triple digits before the two sides climbed down. Still, trade remains a source of tensions. The commerce ministry on Friday hit



back against the Trump administration's new trade investigation into 16 trading partners, including China. The investigation -- which came after a Supreme Court

ruling struck down Trump's sweeping global tariffs that were imposed last year -- could pave the way for new tariffs.

Another issue that could

be discussed is the Iran war, especially when global anxiety is soaring over oil prices and supplies. Trump said that he hopes China, France, Japan, South Korea, the United Kingdom and others will send warships to keep the Strait of Hormuz "open and safe."

Before Sunday's talks, Gary Ng, a senior economist at French bank Natixis and a research fellow at the Central European Institute of Asian Studies, said the Paris meeting is likely the most important bilateral one before the Xi-Trump summit.

The key issue is "whether China and the US can agree on what is agreed and manage disagreement. Iran

is a new factor, but Beijing is more concerned about the flip-flopping of US policies," he said. Last week, Chinese Foreign Minister Wang Yi said it would be a "big year" for China-U.S. relations. While he did not confirm the state visit, Wang said that "the agenda of high-level exchange is already on the table." Bessent and He have led trade negotiations between the countries since last year, having met in Geneva, London, Stockholm, Madrid and Kuala Lumpur, Malaysia. Millions in Vietnam to vote for a new legislature in general election

HANOI, Vietnam (AP) — Voters in Vietnam cast their ballots to select a new

National Assembly on Sunday, two months after the ruling Communist Party reelected leader To Lam to the country's top political post. Nearly 79 million voters across the country are eligible to pick 500 representatives from 864 candidates to the rubber-stamp National Assembly. All candidates are vetted and pre-approved by the Communist Party, ensuring the assembly remains aligned with the party's political direction.

The Communist Party tightly controls political activity, arguing that centralized leadership allows the country to pursue longterm development goals without disruptions.

PROSPECT

Intensify scrutiny of duopoly sectors: Par Panel to CCI



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Regulator CCI should intensify proactive monitoring of duopolistic or high-concentration sectors through regular market studies, competition risk assessments, and targeted interventions as they are showing disproportionate market power, a Parliamentary panel has said. The Competition Commission of India (CCI) has the mandate to curb anti-competitive practices and promote fair competition across sectors.

Besides, the Parliamentary Standing Committee on Finance has urged the Corporate Affairs Ministry to expedite the introduction of the Digital Competition Bill, with a time-bound roadmap to ensure effective regulation of large digital platforms.

In a report tabled in the Lok Sabha this week, the panel said that despite enforcement actions and market studies by the CCI targeting dominant firms in digital markets, “several traditional sectors of the Indian economy also display duopolistic or highly concentrated market structures”.

Such structures are resulting in disproportionate market power that may adversely affect consumer welfare, fair competition, and regulatory compliance, as reflected in recent cases, it noted.

There are concerns in certain quarters about apparent duopolistic trends in some sectors, including in the country’s airline industry.

The panel has recommended that CCI intensify proactive monitoring

of duopolistic and high-concentration sectors across the economy, covering both digital and traditional markets through regular market studies, competition risk assessments, and targeted sector-specific interventions.

“Such efforts should be supported by stronger coordination with sectoral regulators and relevant stakeholders to address emerging competition concerns, safeguard consumer welfare, and ensure compliance with regulatory frameworks,” the committee said.

The panel also said these measures, complemented by evidence-based and forward-looking monitoring mechanisms, would help detect anti-competitive practices like duopoly and market concentration at an early stage, promote fair competition, and protect consumer interests in a rapidly evolving economic landscape.

Among other aspects, the panel has flagged staff shortage at the CCI, where only 117 out of the 195 sanctioned positions are filled.

It has recommended strengthening the institutional capacity of the regulator by expeditiously filling all sanctioned posts, particularly in the Digital Markets Division.

“The committee also note that the proposed Digital Competition Bill, intended to address the growing dominance of large digital platforms, remains pending, thereby leaving a critical regulatory gap at a time when digital markets are expanding rapidly,” the report said.

Government moves NCLAT over Rolta India resolution plan

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Government has moved the appellate tribunal NCLAT, against the order passed by the NCLT, in which it approved a ₹900 crore resolution plan by Ashdan Properties for the debt-ridden Rolta India.

Challenging the approved resolution plan, the centre said only ₹10 lakh of a token amount has been allocated for the Government and the statutory authorities, whereas the Corporate Debtor (Rolta) owed a total sum of ₹5,949.95 crore.

Against admitted Government/statutory claims of ₹179.19 crore, this allocation constitutes an illusory recovery of only 0.06 per cent, said the petition filed by Union of India through Department of Telecommunications (DoT), according to the petition filed by Shashank Bajpai, Central Government standing Counsel.

A claim of ₹469.09 crore has been made by DoT against Rolta India, on account of the unpaid license fee for FY 2005-06 and 2006-07. The Mumbai bench of the National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) on December 15, 2025, approved a ₹900



crore resolution plan submitted by Ashdan Properties, which, according to the Government, is a “grave miscarriage of justice” and “legally untenable”.

The Centre’s appeal came for hearing on Thursday before a two-member bench comprising Chairperson Justice Ashok Bhushan and Member (Technical) Barun Mitra, which directed to list it on March 19, 2026, for hearing. DoT, which is an operational creditor of Rolta India, granted an Internet Service Provider (ISP) license to Rolta India in November 1998 for establishing and operating internet services in the Mumbai service area for a period of 5 years.

It executed a fresh ISP license agreement on April 30, 2002, in which Rolta was mandated to pay license fees

based on Adjusted Gross Revenue (AGR).

Rolta defaulted on license fee payments, following which the DoT issued demand notices. However, Rolta approached the Telecom Disputes Settlement and Appellate Tribunal, which stayed the notices till its further order.

The Corporate Insolvency Resolution Process (CIRP) was started against Rolta India by the NCLT in January 2023.

In CIRP, DoT, as an operational creditor, lodged its Claim in Form B for an amount of ₹469.09 crore towards the unpaid license fee for FY 2005-06 and 2006-07. However, the resolution professional, ‘unilaterally’ categorised the entire claim as “not acceptable but contingent”.

The sole premise for this rejection was the interim

stay order granted by the TDSAT, which had merely stayed the recovery of the demand notices submitted to DoT in its petition.

Later, NCLT on December 15, 2025, approved the resolution plan submitted by Ashdan Properties, which resulted in “grave miscarriage of justice” as it was allocated merely ₹10 Lakh to statutory authorities, resulting in a recovery of only 0.06 per cent of the admitted dues. In the resolution plan, the secured financial creditors received about ₹808.55 crore, and unsecured financial creditors received ₹64.20 crore, but Government / statutory creditors as a class received a fraction of their admitted dues without any cogent examination of compliance with Section 30(2)(b) and the waterfall mechanism under Section 53 of IBC.

Centre has requested the NCLAT to “set aside” the order passed by NCLT on December 15, 2025 and remit it back to the tribunal and Committee of Creditors with directions to revise the Resolution Plan.

The petitioner further said that the approval of Ashdan’s plan is in “direct contravention” of the law laid down by NCLAT in Bank of Maharashtra Vs Videocon Industries Ltd.

Air India acts after finding misuse of staff travel policy



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Air India has detected large-scale discrepancies in the utilisation of its leisure travel policy, involving more than 4,000 employees and has initiated corrective actions, including imposing penalties on the erring staff, according to sources.

Loss-making Air India was acquired by the Tata Group in January 2022, and the airline, which has faced multiple headwinds in recent times, is also in the midst of implementing an ambitious transformation plan. The airline has more than 24,000 employees.

The sources in the know told PTI that the large-scale discrepancies in the use of Air India’s Employee Leisure Travel (ELT) policy were detected after a detailed

internal investigation.

The ELT policy allows a specified number of free air tickets for individual employees and their nominees, including spouse and parents. These are subject to certain conditions.

Many employees were found to have misused the policy by showing those not related to them as relatives to avail the benefits. Some were reported to have even availed the free tickets and sold them to people at a higher price, the sources said. A detailed set of queries sent to Air India on Thursday seeking comments on the issue and the actions taken remained unanswered. One of the sources said more than 4,000 staff were found to have misused the ELT policy. Violations dating back to the last financial year, claims were also detected.

Assam launches Guru Dakshina portal for teachers

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Guwahati

The Government of Assam has officially launched the ‘Guru Dakshina’ portal on Sunday, marking a significant step towards providing financial support to educators who were previously left out of the State’s provincialisation process. The initiative, overseen by the Department of School Education and the Department of Higher Education, is designed to offer a one-time financial settlement to eligible teachers of venture educational institutions who were not included under the Assam Venture Educational Institutions (Provincialisation of Services) Act of 2011 or the 2017 amendment.

The newly launched digital platform, accessible at www.gurudakshinaportal.org, serves as a centralised hub for the application process. It is intended to ensure transparency and efficiency, allowing applicants to upload necessary documentation and monitor the status of their requests in real-time.

According to the State Government, this launch underscores a commitment to technology-driven governance aimed at empowering those who have contributed to the State’s educational framework.

Eligibility for the scheme extends to teachers from venture institutions ranging from Lower Primary and Upper Primary schools to High Schools, Higher Secondary institutions, and



Degree Colleges. The scheme is specifically tailored for those whose services remained unprovincialised despite their respective institutions being provincialised under the aforementioned

legislative acts.

Furthermore, retired teachers who meet these criteria are also invited to apply, while in cases involving deceased educators, nominees can submit appli-

cations provided they furnish the required legal heir certificates.

The Government has clarified that the facility is strictly for teaching staff, and non-teaching personnel are not eligible to register. Applicants are required to provide active bank account details in their own name, as financial assistance will be processed directly. To manage the administrative requirements of the portal, a non-refundable processing fee of ₹ 300 has been fixed for each application.

The submission process will involve a rigorous three-stage verification system to maintain the integrity of the scheme. Applications will first be recommended by the head of the respective institution, followed by a

thorough assessment by a district-level verifier, and a final review by a state-level verifier. Once these stages are cleared, the financial assistance will be disbursed. To ensure a smooth experience, the Government has established a dedicated support channel, allowing applicants to seek assistance via phone at 08068682246 or through email at gurudakshina.helpdesk@gmail.com.

The launch of Guru Dakshina reflects the Government of Assam’s continued commitment to the welfare and empowerment of its citizens through transparent, accessible, and technology-driven governance.

All eligible teachers are advised to submit their applications online within the notified timeline.

Tamil Nadu BJP leader Ashvatham addresses UNHRC; calls for protection of Indian civilisation against conversions

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chennai

In a striking departure from traditional climate discourse, BJP Tamil Nadu State Secretary Ashvatham Allimuthu addressed the United Nations Human Rights Council (UNHRC) on March 12, 2026, arguing that the global environmental crisis is deeply intertwined with the loss of cultural and civilisational diversity.

Speaking via a live session, Ashvatham contended that while global warming is often viewed through a technical lens, its “ignored cultural dimension” is critical to ecological balance. He posited that ancient civilisations — specifically those characterised by “nature worship” and multiple deities — naturally promote diverse lifestyles and consumption patterns that reduce environmental pressure.

The BJP leader drew a sharp distinction between “civilisation” and “reli-



BJP Leader Ashvatham

gion.” He argued that modern religious structures often impose a “one God, one ritual” concept, which leads to a standardised, high-consumption lifestyle detrimental to the planet.

“We have already lost the great Egyptian and Roman civilizations to religious conversion,” Ashvatham warned. “It is crucial for the world to

protect existing civilisations to prevent further ecological decay.”

Referencing Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s global calls for “civilisational self-respect,” Ashvatham cited the Gadilam River in his native Panruti, Tamil Nadu—traditionally believed to be created for Lord Vishnu—as an example of how sacred narratives protect natural resources.

The submission concluded with a formal plea to the UNHRC to take active steps in curtailing “rapid religious conversions” in regions where ancient civilisations still thrive. Ashvatham framed the move not merely as a matter of cultural preservation, but as a strategic necessity for “world protection from global warming.”

While the speech has resonated with proponents of indigenous rights and cultural preservation, it has sparked debate regarding the use of international human rights platforms to advocate for anti-conversion measures.

Par panel recommends IPO route for profitable RRBs to strengthen capital base

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Government should consider launching public offerings of highly profitable Regional Rural Banks (RRBs) to attract market capital and promote stronger corporate governance standards, a Parliamentary panel has said in its report.

Standing Committee on Finance, headed by senior BJP leader Bhartruhari Mahtab noted the successful completion of the structural consolidation of RRBs, reducing their number from 43 to 28 highly viable entities across 11 states, eliminating the need for further capital infusion in 2026-27.

RRBs have achieved a historic consolidated net profit of ₹7,720 crore in just the first nine months of FY 2025-26, driving gross NPAs down to a 13-year low of 5.4 per cent, though vulnerabilities remain, particularly the 13.8 per



cent GNPA in priority sector education loans. The panel recommend that RRBs actively mitigate these specific sectoral risks by fully leveraging their inclusion in the Credit Guarantee Fund Scheme for Education Loans (CGFSEL) and aggressively deploying AI-driven automated Early Warning Signals (EWS).

“Furthermore, the committee strongly urged the Government to proceed with guiding highly profitable RRBs

toward Initial Public Offerings (IPOs) to attract market capital and enforce higher standards of corporate governance,” it said in its recently submitted report.

Guided by the principle of ‘One State-One RRB’, the Government continued with the process of further consolidation of RRBs, and one state-owned RRB became a reality following the amalgamation of 15 RRBs across 11 states to achieve better operational efficiency and cost rationalisation, from May 1, 2025. This was the fourth phase of consolidation, reducing the number of RRBs from 43 to 28 in 26 States and 2 UTs, vide Government notification dated April 5, 2025.

In phase 1 (FY 2006 to FY 2010), the number of RRBs was reduced from 196 to 82. It was further brought down from 82 to 56 in phase 2 (FY 2013 - FY 2015), and in phase 3, it was reduced from 56 to 43.

Amit Shah boosts Assam healthcare with ₹2,092 crore projects

TONY DAS
■ Guwahati

In a significant expansion of Assam’s medical infrastructure, Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Sunday inaugurated a slew of health projects worth ₹2,092 crore. The centrepiece of the development drive was the inauguration of the Pragjyotishpur Medical College and Hospital in Guwahati, which is set to enhance tertiary care accessibility in the State.

Accompanied by Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma, Shah dedicated the new medical college — built at a cost of ₹675 crore — to the people of Assam. This facility marks a major milestone, becoming the 14th operational medical college in the State and the second of its kind in Guwahati. During the event, the Union Minister also virtually inaugurated the Saraswatidevi Shikshisan

Damani Academic Block, which houses the new institution.

The expansion project extended beyond the State Capital as Shah virtually inaugurated two dedicated cancer care centres in Golaghat and Tinsukia. These facilities, constructed with an investment of ₹270 crore, are part of the Assam Cancer Care Foundation’s broader network, aimed at decentralising specialised oncological treatment across the State.

The Union Home Minister further laid the foundation stones for three new Super Speciality Hospitals in Diphu, Jorhat, and Barpeta, with a combined budgetary allocation of ₹814 crore. Additionally, plans for a new ‘Swasthya Bhawan’ in Guwahati’s Six Mile area (₹218 crore) and the development of the Abhayapuri District Hospital (₹115 crore) were set in motion.

Chief Minister Himanta Biswa



Sarma underscored the strategic importance of these developments, noting that the connectivity provided by the Kumar Bhaskar Varma Bridge has brought major medical institu-

tions like AIIMS Guwahati and the Guwahati Medical College and Hospital within a 10-minute reach of the city centre.

Reflecting on the geopolitical necessity of bolstering domestic

medical education, Sarma recalled the challenges faced during the onset of the conflict in Ukraine, which forced many Indian medical students to return home.

“The situation put pressure on the Government and raised the question as to why the number of medical seats is limited, forcing students to travel abroad,” he stated. He credited Prime Minister Narendra Modi with the vision of creating one lakh MBBS seats nationwide to ensure students do not need to seek education overseas.

The Chief Minister shed light on the public-private collaboration behind the Pragjyotishpur project, specifically highlighting the contribution of industrialist Radhakishan Damani. Sarma explained that the initiative began after a conversation with Union Minister Piyush Goyal, leading to the Damani group

covering the full construction costs of the academic and administrative blocks as an act of philanthropy.

The medical college, which has already received recognition from the National Medical Council, will operate with 505 beds, including 46 ICU units. It has already enrolled its first batch of 100 students.

Looking at the broader roadmap for the State’s healthcare, Sarma highlighted the ambitious partnership with Tata Trusts to establish 17 cancer hospitals across the State. With the inauguration of the Golaghat and Tinsukia facilities, the Government is nearing the completion of this network, which the Chief Minister described as unprecedented in the Government sector.

Furthermore, the State is gearing up to install a state-of-the-art Proton Beam Therapy unit at

Gauhati Medical College and Hospital at a cost of up to ₹500 crore.

“Assam now has 15 medical colleges, and work on 10 more continues with an investment of ₹6,000 crore,” the Chief Minister noted, outlining a vision to have at least one medical college in every district by 2030. He projected that once these projects are operational, the State’s annual intake capacity for MBBS students will rise from 2,000 to 5,000.

Health and Family Welfare Minister Ashok Singhal, Member of Parliament Bijuli Kalita Medhi, MLA Ramendra Narayan Kalita, Vice Chancellor Srimanta Sankaradeva University of Health Sciences Dr Anup Kumar Barman, noted industrialist Radhakishan Damani, along with a host of dignitaries, senior officials, professors, and students attended the event.

BRIEFLY

Arda Guler scores best goal as Real Madrid beats Elche



Real Madrid's Arda Guler scored one of the best goals of the Spanish league season on Saturday after he struck a long shot from well inside his team's own half to polish off a 4-1 win over Elche. The 21-year-old Turkey midfielder spotted Elche goalkeeper Matias Dituro off his line and didn't hesitate to launch a long lob with his left foot that sailed over the hapless keeper and bounced once before settling into the net. The Santiago Bernabeu stadium erupted in applause for the memorable goal that came with the victory beyond doubt in the 89th minute. "I saw everyone put their hands on their heads. It is incredible to score a goal from 70 metres (yards) out," Madrid coach Alvaro Arbeloa said. "That goal was worth the ticket to see the game." Guler joined Madrid from Fenerbache in 2023. He has scored four goals this season, when he has gained more playing time after the exit of veteran Luka Modric.

More Iran women's soccer players decide to leave Australia



Another three members of Iran's women's soccer team who accepted refugee visas to stay in Australia have decided to return to their homeland, an Australian government minister said on Sunday. The departure leaves three of an initial seven squad members in Australia. "Overnight, three members of the Iranian Women's Football Team made the decision to join the rest of the team on their journey back to Iran," Home Affairs Minister Tony Burke said in a statement. "After telling Australian officials they had made this decision, the players were given repeated chances to talk about their options," Burke added. Iran's team arrived in Australia for the Women's Asian Cup last month, before the war in the Middle East began on Feb. 28. Initially, six players and a support staff member from a squad list of 26 players accepted humanitarian visas to stay in Australia before the rest of the Iranian contingent flew from Sydney to Malaysia on March 9. Another later changed her mind and left Australia. Three left Sydney for Kuala Lumpur, Malaysia, on Saturday night, a government official said. The rest of the team has remained in Kuala Lumpur since they left Australia. Iran's Tasnim News Agency said the latest three to leave Australia were two players and the support staff member. The three were "returning to the warm embrace of their family and homeland," the news outlet said in a statement. Concerns about the team's safety in Iran heightened when the players didn't sing the Iranian national anthem before their first match. The Australian government was urged to help the woman by Iranian groups in Australia and by US President Donald Trump.

Real Madrid's Valverde keeps up scoring run in 4-1 win over Elche

JOSEPH WILSON
■ Barcelona

Federico Valverde kept up his scoring run by notching his fifth goal in three games to help Real Madrid beat Elche 4-1 in the Spanish league, with Arda Guler adding a spectacular late goal from well inside his own half.

The Uruguayan midfielder scored with a right-footed curling strike that he took from the edge of the area to double Madrid's lead just before halftime.

That came three days after Valverde's memorable hat trick in a 3-0 win over Manchester City in the first game of their Champions League round-of-16 matchup.

Prior to that, Valverde's last-gasp goal earned a 2-1 win at Celta Vigo in the pre-



vious La Liga round. The 27-year-old Valverde has been a key player for Madrid for several years now, with a reputation for being a workhorse in the midfield as well as providing a powerful long-distance strike from open

Dowman youngest scorer in Premier League

STEVE DOUGLASAP
■ London

Arsenal strengthened its grip on the Premier League title race on the day its 16-year-old wonderkid, Max Dowman, scored a brilliant solo goal to become the competition's youngest-ever scorer.

After Arsenal relied on late goals by Viktor Gyokeres and Dowman to snatch a 2-0 home win over Everton, second-place Manchester City could only draw 1-1 at West Ham a few hours later Saturday. The lead grew to nine points on what might prove to be a defining day in Arsenal's bid for a first English league title since 2004.

It will certainly never be

forgotten by Dowman, the school kid and surely a future superstar in English soccer.

At 16 years, 73 days, he changed the game after coming on in the second half for his third Premier League appearance in a breakthrough season that has already seen him become the youngest player in Champions League history.

It was his cross from the right that was missed by Everton goalkeeper Jordan Pickford and struck the midriff of Arsenal substitute Piero Hincapie. The ball bounced across the goalmouth and Gyokeres applied the finishing touch from close range. Then, in the seventh minute of stoppage time, Dowman collect-



ed the ball midway in his own half after a corner was cleared, dribbled around two players, and raced clear to tap

into an empty net. Everton goalkeeper Jordan Pickford was stranded upfield having gone up for the corner in

Serie A leader Inter held 1-1 by Atalanta

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Rome

Serie A leader Inter Milan conceded a late equaliser and was held 1-1 by Atalanta at home, leaving the door open for AC Milan to further close the gap to its rival.

Francesco Esposito put Inter ahead in the 26th minute, but Nikola Krstovic scored for Atalanta in the 82nd to split the points.

Inter was coming off a 1-0 loss to Milan in the league last weekend. Now it leads its crosstown nemesis by eight points before Milan visits Lazio on Sunday. Inter has only two wins in its last seven games overall, a run that includes being elimi-



nated from the Champions League knockout rounds playoff by Norwegian upstart Bodø/Glimt. Inter's Cristian Chivu was sent off in the 85th after back-to-back bookings.

Seventh-placed Atalanta showed more resilience than in the 6-1 defeat it suffered to Bayern Munich in the Champions League's round-of-16 this week. It visits

Bayern for their second leg on Wednesday. Napoli fought back to beat Lecce 2-1 and pull to within nine points of Inter with nine games remaining. Lecce centre back Jamil Siebert put the visitors ahead in the third minute, but the defending champions got goals in the second half from Rasmus Hoejlund in the 46th and Matteo Politano in the 67th to ensure they capitalised on Inter's stumble.

Juventus midfielder Jeremie Boga scored for a third league game in a row to help beat Udinese 1-0 and consolidate its hold on fourth place. Boga joined the team from Turin in the winter transfer window.

Tosin scores late winner as Lorient beats Lens

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Lorient (France)

Substitute striker Aiyegun Tosin scored the winner as second-placed Lens lost 2-1 at Lorient in the French league, missing the chance to move back to the top of the standings. With Paris Saint-Germain not playing this weekend, Lens had the chance to move two points clear with a win at mid-table Lorient.

But coach Pierre Sage's players struggled to get things going and were punished in the 18th minute when Bamba Dieng was left unmarked and scored from close range with a right-footed effort.

Following Odsonne Edouard's second-half equalizer, Tosin snatched three



points for Lorient in the 65th minute, fluffing his initial attempt before rounding the Lens goalkeeper to score. Lorient goalkeeper Yvon Mvogo made five saves for the hosts. PSG is off duty because Nantes agreed to postpone their scheduled game on Sunday in order to

give PSG better preparation for the Champions League second leg against Chelsea next week. PSG is leading 5-2 from the last-16 first leg on Wednesday.

Balogun scores again: American forward Folarin Balogun continued his excellent run of form as Monaco

posted a fifth consecutive win. He broke the deadlock from close range before Aleksandr Golovin made it 2-0 against Brest.

Monaco moved up to fifth place. Balogun has 14 goals overall this season.

Elsewhere, Nice won 2-0 at Angers with goals from defender Melvin Bard and Elye Wahi. The striker, a France youth international, joined the Riviera club on loan from Eintracht Frankfurt this winter until the end of the season.

Third-placed Marseille won 1-0 against struggler Auxerre on Friday. The result left Marseille in third place, three points clear of Lyon, which plays at Le Havre on Sunday. Marseille was seven points behind Lens and eight adrift of PSG.

search of an equaliser.

City couldn't match Arsenal, surrendering the lead given to Pep Guardiola's team by Bernardo Silva in the 31st minute. Four minutes later, Konstantinos Mavropanos headed home the equaliser at a corner.

It wraps up a tough week for City, which was beaten 3-0 by Real Madrid in the first leg of the Champions League's round of 16 on Wednesday.

Across London, Chelsea lost 1-0 to Newcastle thanks to an 18th-minute goal by Anthony Gordon. Chelsea stayed in fifth place but could be overtaken by Liverpool, which hosts struggling Tottenham on Sunday.

Burnley draws and facing relegation Burnley is running out of time and hope in the Premier League. A 0-0 home draw with Bournemouth on Saturday left next-to-last Burnley — one of the many US-owned teams in England's top division — eight points from safety with just eight games remaining this season and facing an immediate return to the Championship.

Burnley has won just four of its 30 league games.

Bizarre winner for Brighton: Sunderland, another promoted team, appears to be safe from relegation but is limping toward the end of the season after a third straight home loss — this time to Brighton 1-0. (AP)

Medvedev heads to Indian Wells final



ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Indian Wells (US)

Daniil Medvedev handed top-seeded Carlos Alcaraz his first loss of the year and advanced to the final at Indian Wells with a 6-3, 7-6 (3) victory. The 11th-seeded Medvedev, from Russia, will face second-seeded Jannik Sinner of Italy. Sinner beat Alexander Zverev 6-2, 6-4.

Alcaraz had won 16 straight matches this year, including titles at the Australian Open and Qatar Open. But Medvedev ended the possibility of an Alcaraz vs. Sinner final. Medvedev had dropped his last four meetings against Alcaraz, including a loss in the Indian Wells final in 2024. This was Medvedev's first victory over him since the US Open semifinals in 2023.

Sinner made quick work of Zverev, beating him in 1 hour, 23 minutes. Sinner notched six aces against the fourth-seeded Zverev. Zverev won his first eight points on serve.

But Sinner broke Zverev in both the fifth and seventh games to secure the first set. Sinner now leads the head-to-head series against Zverev 7-4. Neither Medvedev nor Sinner has dropped a set yet in this tournament. Sinner has won his last three matches against Medvedev, including in the U.S. Open quarterfinals in 2024.

In the women's doubles final, Taylor Townsend and Katerina Siniakova beat Anna Danilina and Aleksandra Krunic 7-6 (4), 6-4. The victory marked Townsend's first at Indian Wells and Siniakova's second. Siniakova also won in 2023 alongside longtime partner Barbora Krejickova.

In the men's doubles final, Guido Andreozzi and Manuel Guinard topped Arthur Rinderknech and Valentin Vacherot 7-6 (3), 6-3. In mixed doubles, Belinda Bencic and Flavio Cobolli beat top-seeded Gabriela Dabrowski and Lloyd Glasspool 6-3, 2-6, 10-7.

Referee finds himself in middle of Chelsea's pre-match huddle

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ London

There was an unexpected person in Chelsea's pre-match huddle: The referee.

Under recently hired manager Liam Rosenior, Chelsea's players have made a habit of gathering in a circle around the ball on the halfway line in the moments before the first and second halves begin in a display of unity. Before the Premier League match against Newcastle at Stamford Bridge, referee Paul Tierney took hold of the ball next to the centre circle — only to soon find himself surrounded by the Chelsea team.

Cole Palmer was even seen placing his arms around



the shoulders of Tierney, who looked slightly bemused as a team talk took place with him in the middle of it. Rosenior said he was "disappointed" that Tierney got involved in the huddle.

"If Paul had focused more on his job, which was to make the right decision, we have a penalty today,"

Rosenior said. "So," he added, "let's focus on the things that are important. My team showing unity is not as important as getting the decisions right on the pitch." Rosenior felt his players did nothing wrong. "I want to protect my players. 'm respectful to the game."

Ludvig Aberg builds a 3-shot lead in The Players Championship

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Ponte Vedra Beach

The biggest challenge for Ludvig Aberg was finding satisfaction in a three-shot lead at The Players Championship instead of wondering how much larger it could have been.

Aberg had only two bogeys on his card all week and was four shots ahead of Michael Thorbjornsen when he stood in the fairway on the par-5 16th hole, 193 yards away with a 7-iron in his hand. He had an 8-foot birdie putt on the island-green 17th hole. He smashed his drive on the daunting 18th that set up a 25-foot birdie attempt. Aberg still



managed a 1-under 71 thanks largely to his third eagle of the week with an 18-foot putt on the par-5 11th. He was three shots clear of Michael Thorbjornsen, a rival in college and now a neighbour in the Ponte Vedra Beach area. "Definitely would

have loved to come out of 16 and 17 with at least one birdie, and then obviously the three-putt on 18 kind of stings, annoys me a little bit," Aberg said. "But overall, I started the day with a two-shot lead and ended with a three, so that's a positive."

Bayern Munich held to 1-1 draw at Bayer Leverkusen

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Berlin

Bayern Munich salvaged a 1-1 draw despite clinging on with nine players at Bayer Leverkusen as Harry Kane returned to action following an injury, while Borussia Dortmund cut Bayern's Bundesliga lead to nine points.

Luis Diaz, who scored the equaliser following Aleix Garcia's opener, was sent off in the 84th minute for a second yellow card for diving. Nicolas Jackson, starting with Kane on the bench, received a straight red card for a poor tackle in the 42nd minute.

Bayern coach Vincent Kompany and his players



were sharply critical of the decision to send off Diaz, and referee Christian Dingert admitted after the game that it wasn't the right call after viewing a replay, in comments to broadcaster Sky Sport. "I'm incredibly proud of the mental performance

the guys showed," Kompany said of his team. "There was an incredible amount of things going on today."

Leverkusen took the lead in the sixth minute after 18-year-old German-American winger Montrell Culbreath stole the ball off Diaz and fed

it to Patrik Schick, who set up Garcia on the edge of the box. The midfielder slotted home with a deflected shot.

The hosts defended well to contain Bayern's attempts to come back, and frustration showed when Jackson was sent off before halftime for a late challenge on Martin Terrier.

Bayern played with third-choice goalkeeper Sven Ulreich because Manuel Neuer has a calf issue and backup Jonas Urbig was concussed in the 6-1 win over Atalanta midweek in the Champions League. Ulreich denied an effort from Schick in a one-on-one situation at the hour mark just before Kane came on.

Back from a calf injury, Kane played for the first time since Feb. 28 after scoring eight goals in his past four Bundesliga games. He fired the ball into an empty net in the 62nd minute but it was disallowed for blocking the goalkeeper's clearance with a hand in the buildup.

Diaz leveled in the 69th with a low shot from Michael Olise's precise setup. The Colombia winger later received a second yellow card for diving and Bayern was down to nine men with six minutes left to play. The hosts could not snatch the win despite pushing hard until the end as Jonas Hofmann had a goal ruled out deep in stoppage time.

Gambhir hails Samson’s powerplay firepower

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Sanju Samson possesses the firepower to take the game away from the opposition in the Powerplay itself when at his explosive best, said India head coach Gautam Gambhir.

Samson delivered crucial performances towards the business end of the ICC Men’s T20 World Cup, smashing explosive half-centuries in the semifinal and final to help India clinch a record third title.

Alongside Abhishek Sharma, Samson took the game away from New Zealand in the final by amassing 92 runs in the powerplay.

“We know what Sanju can do, there was never any doubt about his talent and explosiveness. If he gets going, he can win you the game in the first six overs,” Gambhir said on Jio Star.

Samson was not part of the playing XI in the World Cup after a poor build-up series against New Zealand.

But given a chance in the must-win game against Zimbabwe, Samson delivered a blazing start with a 15-ball 24. In India’s last three games he scored 97 not out, 89 and 89. “I conveyed it to him in the gym. In fact, we were both training together and I just told him that you’ll be playing against Zimbabwe, and he said, ‘let



it come.’ That’s the kind of casual conversation we have. It’s not like a head coach and player’s relationship. It’s a relationship where most of our one-on-one conversations happen during practice sessions,” he said.

Without Samson in the side, India’s top-order comprised of three left handers in Ishan Kishan, Abhishek Sharma and Tilak Varma.

But Gambhir asserted that the decision to bring Samson into the playing XI was not aimed at breaking the left-handed combination but at adding firepower.

“I know a lot of people will talk about how we wanted to break the three left-handers at the top, not at all. We just felt

that we wanted to be more explosive because the ideology in the last one and a half years has been to go out there and be as explosive as we can be,” he said. “The reason to bring in Sanju was not about managing the off-spinner from the other end. It was about whether we could get even more firepower at the top and be more aggressive in the first six overs.” Abhishek endured a difficult first half of the tournament with three ducks, but the opener bounced back with two half-centuries, including one in the final.

“I’ve had a worse experience than him in 2014 during the IPL, when I got three ducks in a row and then another in the fourth game as well.



South Africa beats New Zealand in first T20

MOUNT MAUNGANUI
■ (New Zealand)

A South Africa team with four players on debut rolled World Cup finalist New Zealand for 91 in 14.3 overs and went on to win the first Twenty20 international Sunday by seven wickets.

Opener Connor Esterhuizen anchored the South Africa reply with an unbeaten 45 from 48 balls as the Proteas won with 20 balls to spare. He was supported by Dian Forrester, also on debut, who stayed with him for more than six overs and was 16 not out at the end.

Esterhuizen finished the chase with a six off Kyle Jamieson from the fourth ball of the 17th over.

New Zealand’s spinners helped to make a fight of it and captain Mitchell Santner finished with 1-8 from his four overs on a turning pitch at Bay Oval.

“I think all the plans paid off and the execution was top-notch from our bowlers,” South Africa captain Keshav Maharaj said. “It was a young bowling lineup, but whatever

we asked them to do, they stood up.

“It was a little nervy towards the end but it showed the maturity in Connor and Dian in the way they played to take it over the line.”

New Zealand had eight players missing from its World Cup squad, including its top-six batters from the team that lost the final against India by 96 runs and beat South Africa by nine wickets in the semifinals.

After choosing to bat first, New Zealand lost five wickets in the powerplay, couldn’t recover and stumbled to its 10th-lowest score in T20 internationals, its second-lowest against South Africa.

Gerald Coetzee dismissed New Zealand openers Devon Conway and Tom Latham within the first three overs, finishing with 2-14, then Otniel Baartman took 2-22 to help complete the ruin of the New Zealand top order.

Baartman dismissed Tim Robinson and Nick Kelly, on debut, before the run-out of Bevon Jacobs left New Zealand on 36-5. (AP)



Gill, Mandhana win top BCCI awards

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Prolific batters Shubman Gill and Smriti Mandhana were named the Best International Cricketers (Men’s and Women’s) at the BCCI Naman Awards 2026 here on Sunday, recognising their outstanding performances in the 2024-2025 season.

Gill won the prestigious Polly Umrigar Award, while Mandhana received the award for the fifth time.

For Gill, it was his second Cricketer of the Year award after first winning it in 2023.

Former stars Roger Binny, Rahul Dravid and Mithali Raj were honoured with the Col CK Nayudu Lifetime Achievement Award, the BCCI’s highest honour, recognising their outstanding service to Indian cricket.

India’s five trophy-winning sides (2025 ICC Champions Trophy, 2025 Women’s ODI World Cup, 2025 U-19

Women’s World Cup, 2026 Men’s U-19 World Cup, and 2026 T20 World Cup) were honoured as well on the occasion.

Gill enjoyed a stellar 2025 and established himself as one of the team’s most dependable batters in the longer formats.

“Firstly, thank you to the BCCI for recognising me with this award. Many greats and legends of Indian cricket have received it before, so it is a huge honour for me to be here. What we as an Indian cricket group were able to achieve last year was truly tremendous — five ICC trophies, something I don’t think has ever happened before,” Gill said.

“I want to thank my teammates because none of this would have been possible without them. I would also like to thank my parents and family members for helping me reach where I am today. Thank you once again,” Gill added.

Indian triple jumper Selva Prabhu clinches silver medal at NCAA Indoor Championships

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

India’s Selva Prabhu produced a personal best on his way to clinching the silver medal in the men’s triple jump event at the NCAA Indoor Championships in Fayetteville, USA.

A silver medallist at the World Athletics U20 Championships in 2022 and the U20 national record holder, Prabhu breached the 17m barrier for the first time, producing a best jump of 17.05m on Saturday.

With the effort the 21-year old, who is enrolled in the Kansas State University, also set a



national Indoor record.

However, the Athletics Federation of India (AFI) has strict guidelines for the ratification of national records, which often leads

to the non-recognition of performances achieved in foreign competitions, including the National Collegiate Athletic Association (NCAA), if they

do not meet AFI’s technical and anti-doping requirements. NCAA manages its own dope-testing programme but it is not a signatory to the WADA Code.

Theegala back in top 10, Aberg extends lead at Players Championship

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Florida

Indian American Sahith Theegala carded a solid four-under 68 to move back into the top 10 with one round left to play at the USD 25million Players Championship.

Theegala had six birdies against two bogeys in his 68 that took his total score to seven-under par. He is six shots behind Sweden’s Ludvig Aberg, who extended his lead to three shots after carding one-under 71. His total score is now 13-under par.

Theegala is currently placed T-10 on the leaderboard alongside four other

players, Robert MacIntyre, Austin Smotherman, Jacob Bridgeman and Sepp Straka.

Another Indian American Akshay Bhatia carded two-under 70 to gain two positions and be placed at T-26 alongside world number one Scottie Scheffler, who carded four-under 68 to have a total score of four-under par.

Indo-Canadian Sudarshan Yellamaraju carded a strong round six-under 66 to move into the top 20. Yellamaraju is now T-19 with a score of five-under par.

Rory McIlroy continues to have a forgettable week as he is placed T-57 after carding an even par third round as his total score



stands at one-over par.

Theegala started his third round with a birdie on the first hole before dropping the stroke on the seventh and turned in even par. On the back nine the 28-year-old set himself up for a strong round with consecutive birdies on the 11th and 12th holes before making his final bogey of the round on the 14th. He went on to birdie the 15th, 17th and 18th holes.

If Theegala finished within the top 10 this week he could move into the top 15 of the FedExCup rankings.

Michael Thorbjorsen moved into second position after carding five-under 67. Thorbjorsen’s total is

now 10-under par.

In third place is Cameron Young with a total score of nine-under par and there is a six-way tie for fourth place between Matt Fitzpatrick, Brian Hartman, Viktor Hovland, Justin Thomas, Corey Connors and Xander Schauffele who are all at 8-under par after three rounds.

MacIntyre shot the low round of the day, seven-under 65 to move up to T-10.

If the current positions are to hold Bridgeman will replace Collin Morikawa as the FedExCup leader by the end of the week and Akshay Bhatia will retain his second position as Morikawa will drop down to third.

Formula 1 calls off April races in Bahrain and Saudi Arabia due to Iran war

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Shanghai

Formula 1 and its governing body FIA said the Grand Prix races in Bahrain and Saudi Arabia will not happen in April because of safety concerns related to the Iran war.

Both countries have been struck during Iran’s response after the United States and Israel launched a wave of attacks on Iran.

The announcement was made early Sunday morning in Shanghai ahead of the Chinese Grand Prix.

“Due to the ongoing situation in the Middle East region, the Bahrain and Saudi Arabian Grands Prix will not take place

in April,” F1 said. “While several alternatives were considered, it was ultimately decided that no substitutions would be made in April.” F1 was due to race in Bahrain on April 12 and in the Saudi Arabian city of Jeddah on April 19.

“While this was a difficult decision to take, it is unfortunately the right one at this stage considering the current situation in the Middle East,” said Stefano Domenicali, president and CEO of F1.

The FIA said the two races “will not take place in April” and that no replacements would be organized.

“The FIA will always place the safety and well being of our community and col-



leagues first. After careful consideration, we have taken this decision with that responsibility firmly in mind,” FIA President Mohammed Ben Sulayem said.

The FIA didn’t explicitly rule out rescheduling the races and, along with F1, did not use the words “cancel” or

“postpone” in announcing the series would not be in Bahrain or Saudi Arabia next month. Ben Sulayem said: “Bahrain and Saudi Arabia are incredibly important to the ecosystem of our racing season, and I look forward to returning to both as soon as circumstances allow.”

The promoters of the races in Bahrain and Saudi Arabia said they supported the decision. F1’s packed schedule doesn’t have any obvious open dates for rescheduled races this year.

Calling off the Bahrain and Saudi Arabian races means there will be a five-week gap from the Japanese Grand Prix on March 29 and the next race, the Miami Grand Prix on May 3. Without any rescheduling, the 22-race schedule would be the shortest since 2023. The two Middle East races weren’t until next month but F1 faced making a decision earlier because it typically flies in the first staff and cargo to tracks weeks in

advance. F1 was also faced with the difficulty of selling tickets at short notice, which make it almost impossible to set up a replacement race in other countries.

Kimi Antonelli, the Mercedes driver who qualified in pole position for Sunday’s race in Shanghai, said his thoughts were “with the ones that are suffering from this situation” and that safety needed to be the priority, adding of the FIA and F1: “I’m sure they will do the right thing.”

The schedule is a joint matter for the FIA and for F1’s commercial rights holder and teams had signaled a willingness to follow their lead.

Chinese GP: Antonelli claims maiden F1 win

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Shanghai

He’s been defined by being Lewis Hamilton’s successor and George Russell’s teammate. Now Kimi Antonelli is a Formula 1 race-winner in his own right, and the second-youngest in history.

The 19-year-old Italian pulled clear of an entertaining battle between Russell and the two Ferraris to take a commanding win at the Chinese Grand Prix on Sunday and share the podium with his teammate and Hamilton, the seven-time champion he replaced last year.

It’s a vindication of the



gamble Mercedes team principal Toto Wolff took in picking the youngster, who’d joined Mercedes’ junior program aged just 11, to replace an all-time great

when Hamilton moved to Ferrari for 2025. There were plenty of doubters when Antonelli crashed 10 minutes into his practice debut in 2024.

“Many said it was just too early last year, and obviously we asked ourselves that question, whether it was too much to throw him into this pressure cooker,” Wolff told Sky Sport Germany.

“One year with ups and downs and he’s young. We have to forgive him these mistakes, and now he’s in the second Grand Prix (of 2026) and brings it home ruthlessly. It’s good.”

The 19-year-old Italian was the youngest pole-position starter and briefly lost the lead to Hamilton at the start but retook it soon after and was in control the rest of the way.



Hamilton thanks Ferrari as long wait for podium ends

JAMES ELLINGWORTH
■ Shanghai

Lewis Hamilton says he is “incredibly grateful” to Ferrari for letting him guide the development of the car that put him back on a Grand Prix podium for the first time since 2024.

Hamilton’s third-place finish at the Chinese Grand Prix followed a race-long battle with teammate Charles Leclerc and what Hamilton called “just a kiss” of contact between the pair. It ended a long wait for a finish in the top three for Hamilton in a full Formula 1 race since his blockbuster move from Mercedes, which took the win Sunday with the driver who replaced him at the team, Kimi Antonelli.

“To see them listen and put some of those things that I’d asked for on the car I’m just incredibly grateful to them for listening on that side of things,” Hamilton said.

“It just makes you feel more united with everyone because you’re moving in the same direction. I’m looking forward

to getting back next week to (Ferrari HQ in) Maranello and seeing everybody. Big, big push.” Hamilton’s first year with Ferrari was full of frustration as he and the team failed to get to grips with a car that was very sensitive to setup changes, except for a sprint race win in China a year ago. Ferrari failed to win a single Grand Prix all year.

At times, Hamilton blamed himself, even suggesting in August the team consider a driver change after he was far off Leclerc’s qualifying pace. He’s said a big part of preparing for 2026 was to come back with a fresh mindset.

Ferrari’s fast-starting car helped Hamilton to charge past Antonelli into the lead at the start Sunday, but holding onto that place proved too difficult against a Mercedes pair with what’s widely considered to be the best all-round car on the grid. Hamilton said Ferrari would double down on working to out-develop Mercedes for the rest of the year.